HOLY TRINITY UNIVERSITY

THEOLOGY OF ETHIOPIAN FATHERS

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Abstract

This module, "Theology of Ethiopian Fathers," Facilitated by Mhr. Behailu Bekele (MTh, Theology; MA, Ethiopian Studies), a senior lecturer here at Holy Trinity University, is a journey into the heart of the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church's (EOTC) unique way of understanding God and faith. We'll explore how the early thinkers of our Church—the Fathers—shaped what we believe, how we worship, and our spiritual path. What's really striking about this tradition is how it wove together the Bible, key ideas from early Christian centers like Alexandria (especially on who Christ is), and our own African spiritual insights. We'll get to know who these Fathers were and why they still matter so much.

A big piece of this is looking at the strong Hebraic threads in Ethiopian Christianity. Think of the stories in the Kəbrä Nägäśt (Glory of Kings), our deep respect for the Tabot (Ark of the Covenant), and even how we observe the Sabbath. We'll also touch on what different scholars say about these connections. Then, we'll look at how Christianity first took root in Ethiopia and really became Ethiopian, from its earliest days with figures like St. Frumentius (Abba Salama) and the Nine Saints. Understanding Holy Tradition (Srəʿat)—that living flow of faith, scripture, and practice passed down through generations—is also a really important part of this. From there, the module joints into the Ethiopian Orthodox Liturgy, the Qəddase. We'll unpack the rich theology in its prayers, especially the Anaphoras, and see how our unique ways of worship express core beliefs, like Christ being truly present in the Eucharist and our understanding of the Holy Trinity. We'll also see how Ethiopian theologians, like Emperor Gelawdewos in his well-known Confession, stood up for our distinct practices and beliefs, especially about the Tabot and holy icons, always drawing from our own ancient sources.

Core beliefs are, of course, a major focus. We'll examine how the Ethiopian Orthodox Church understands the Holy Trinity (Śəllase)—its mystery, its roots in scripture, and how our Fathers responded to different ideas over time. A good chunk of our time will be on Christology (Nägärä Krəstos), with a special look at Saint Yared. His hymns are more than just beautiful music; they are profound statements about the Tewahedo (Union) doctrine – that single, perfectly united divine-human nature of Christ – and they explore how we are saved. The module will make clear this Miaphysite view of Christ and also consider how modern Ethiopian scholars, like Abune Melketsedek, have talked about these ideas. Finally, we'll explore the very special place of the Virgin Mary (ʾƎgəzʾətənä Maryam) in Ethiopian hearts and minds, looking at her title Wäladitä Amlak (Mother of God), her perpetual virginity, her role in God's plan of salvation, the many symbols used to honor her, and the EOTC's teaching on her unique holiness right from her beginning.

The whole idea of this course is to really engage with Ethiopian sources, the wisdom of our own scholars (both old and new), and the living faith of the Church. The goal is to give you a solid, well-rounded picture of this ancient and very much alive theological tradition, from our own perspective.

Keywords: *Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church (EOTC), Ethiopian Fathers, Tewahedo, Christology, Mariology, Holy Trinity, Divine Liturgy (Qəddase), Ark of the Covenant (Tabot), Holy Tradition, St. Yared, Hebraic Elements, Indigenous Theology, Patristics.*

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Chapter one
1 Introduction
This module introduces the rich theological landscape shaped by the Ethiopian Fathers. We will explore the distinctive heritage of the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church (EOTC), an ancient tradition that has uniquely synthesized biblical revelation, Alexandrian Christology, and indigenous African spirituality. Our focus will be on understanding the core theological contributions and historical context of these foundational figures.

1.1 Ethiopian Fathers

The Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church venerates its Church Fathers (*Abatoch*, **አባቶች**) as seminal figures who defined its theological, liturgical, and spiritual character. Recognition as a Father within the EOTC is based on several criteria;

- Orthodox Teaching (*Bärtəᶜt Haymanot Mäṣnat*, **በርትዕት ሃይማኖት መጽናት**); Central to this is the defense of *Tewahedo* (**ተዋሕዶ**), the doctrine of the unified divine and human natures of Christ, and a stance distinct from Chalcedonian Christology.
- Holiness of Life (*Yäqəddəsənna Ḥəywät*, **የቅድስና ሕይወት**); This includes exemplary asceticism (*Täbaḥtəwo*, **ተባሕትዎ**), Spirit-empowered miracles (*bämänfäs qəddus yähonä gäbare täʾammərat*, **በመንፈስ ቅዱስ የሆነ ገባሬ ተአምራት**), or martyrdom (*Sämaᶜətənät*, **ሰማዕትነት**). Monastic founders like Abba Iyäsus Mo'a (**አባ ኢየሱስ ሞዐ**) exemplify this.
- Liturgical or Literary Contribution; This involves authorship of *Ge'ez* (**ግዕዝ**) hymns, such as those by Saint Yared (**ቅዱስ ያሬድ**), biblical commentaries (*Mätärgumä Mäṣaḥəft Mäməhran*, **መተርጉመ መጻሕፍት መምህራን**), or scriptural translations, like the work of Abba Ǝnbaqom (**አባ እንባቆም**).
- Historical Impact; Their influence through evangelization or defending the faith during crises (e.g., Islamic incursions, exemplified by Abba Ǝnbaqom) is critical. An apostolic connection, such as Frumentius's ordination by St. Athanasius, is also significant.
- Ecclesiastical Recognition; Commemoration in the *Sənkəssar* (Synaxarium, **ስንክሳር**) or liturgical calendars, and sustained veneration by Ethiopian clergy and laity, affirms their status.

From the earliest periods, marked by figures like *Abba Salama* (Frumentius) and the Nine Saints (5th–6th centuries), to the later contributions of luminaries like St. Yared, Ethiopian theology has consistently affirmed the *Tewahedo* doctrine. This Christ-centered understanding, nurtured in monastic settings and expressed in liturgical worship, also incorporates certain Hebraic traditions, such as Sabbath observance and a profound reverence for the Ark of the Covenant, symbolized by the *Tabot* (**ታቦት**).

Ethiopian Fathers engaged with patristic sources from other centers of Christianity but did so creatively, embedding these theological insights within the indigenous linguistic and cultural contexts of *Ge'ez*, Amharic, and other regional languages. Their extensive literary output, from hagiographies (*Mäṣaḥəftä Qəddusat*, **መጻሕፍተ ቅዱሳት**) to Marian homilies, reveals a theology that is both contemplative and communal, mystical and deeply incarnational. This course will delve into how these Fathers addressed fundamental theological questions, preserving a distinct Ethiopian theological identity.

1.2 Hebraic Elements in Ethiopian Christianity

A notable feature of the EOTC is its incorporation of Hebraic elements, a legacy stemming from ancient historical narratives and cultural practices. The *Kəbrä Nägäśt* (**ክብረ ነገሥት**), 'The Glory of Kings', a foundational Ethiopian text, recounts the Queen of Sheba's (Makeda) visit to King Solomon and the subsequent journey of their son, Menelik I, who is said to have brought the Ark of the Covenant (*Tabot*, **ታቦት**) to Ethiopia (Brooks, 1996). This narrative establishes a sense of Ethiopia as a "New Israel."
This historical self-understanding is reflected in various practices;

- The centrality of the *Tabot* (**ታቦት**), a consecrated replica of the Ark, in every EOTC altar.
- Observance of the Sabbath (Saturday) alongside Sunday.
- Dietary customs, such as the avoidance of pork, reminiscent of Old Testament laws (Leviticus 11;7).
- Practices of ritual purity.

These elements are not seen as mere adherence to Old Testament law, but as integral parts of Ethiopian Christian identity, interpreted through the lens of the Gospel (Matthew 5;17-18).

1.3 Scholars Debate

The precise origins and integration of these Hebraic elements have been a subject of scholarly discussion.

- Edward Ullendorff (1968) proposed a "Judaic substrate," suggesting a pre-Christian Judaic influence in Ethiopia that was later absorbed into its Christianity.
- Ephraim Isaac (1986) posited that these similarities might stem from a shared ancient Afro-Asiatic heritage rather than direct large-scale Jewish conversion or settlement.
- Steven Kaplan (1992) highlighted the long history of interaction and mutual influence between Ethiopian Christians and the *Beta Israel* (**ቤተ እስራኤል**) community.

While academic perspectives vary, the Hebraic dimensions are an undeniable and defining characteristic of the EOTC's indigenous Christian expression.

1.4 Presentation of Christianity in Ethiopian

The Christian faith reached Ethiopia in the apostolic era, traditionally linked to the baptism of the Ethiopian eunuch by Philip the Evangelist (*Acts 8;26–39*). Early Church Fathers like Irenaeus also attest to this early evangelization. The Ethiopian *Sənkəssar* (Synaxarium, **ስንክሳር**) further names St. Matthew the Apostle as an evangelist to Ethiopia (Isaac, 1986).

The formal establishment of the Church is widely attributed to the 4th-century conversion of King Ezana of Aksum. This was facilitated by St. Frumentius (*Abba Salama*, **አባ ሰላማ**), who was consecrated as the first bishop for Ethiopia by St. Athanasius of Alexandria. This event linked the nascent Ethiopian Church directly with Alexandrian Orthodoxy shortly after the Council of Nicaea (325 AD).

The arrival of the Nine Saints in the late 5th century, following the Council of Chalcedon (451 AD), further solidified and expanded Christianity in Ethiopia. These monastic figures, largely from Syria and other parts of the Byzantine Empire who opposed the Chalcedonian definition, played a crucial role in translating scriptures into *Ge'ez* (**ግዕዝ**), establishing monasteries, and deepening the theological and spiritual life of the Church. Their work was instrumental in shaping the distinct non-Chalcedonian (Miaphysite) stance of the EOTC.

1.5 Holy Tradition in Ethiopia

Holy Tradition (*Paradosis*, παράδοσις, or in *Ge'ez Srəᶜat*, **ሥርዓት**) is the lifeblood of the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church. It is understood not as a static repetition of the past, but as the living transmission of the fullness of the Christian faith – including Scripture, doctrine, worship, sacraments, and the lives of the saints – from one generation to the next, guided by the Holy Spirit.

This Tradition encompasses;

- The core Orthodox faith in the Triune God and His saving acts.
- The Holy Scriptures (Old and New Testaments), whose canon and interpretation are received within the Church's Tradition.
- Liturgical worship (*Qəddase*, **ቅዳሴ**; *Zema*, **ዜማ**) and the sacramental life (*Məśṭirat*, **ምሥጢራት**).
- The teachings and writings of the Church Fathers, both universal and Ethiopian.
- The lives and intercessions of the saints (*Qəddusan*, **ቅዱሳን**), especially the Virgin Mary.

- The canons (*Qänona*, ቀኖና) and decisions of the holy councils.

For the EOTC, Tradition is the context in which Scripture is understood and lived, ensuring continuity with the apostolic Church and providing the framework for its ongoing life and witness.

1.6 Summary

Chapter one has introduced the foundational elements of the Theology of Ethiopian Fathers. We have identified the Ethiopian Fathers (*Abatoch*) as key figures recognized for their orthodox teaching, holiness, and contributions to the EOTC's unique heritage, particularly their defense of *Tewahedo* (ተዋሕዶ) Christology. The chapter highlighted the distinctive Hebraic elements integrated into Ethiopian Christianity, such as the reverence for the *Tabot* (ታቦት) and Sabbath observance, understood within a Christian framework. The establishment of Christianity in Ethiopia was traced from apostolic times, through the 4th-century conversion of King Ezana and the pivotal role of *Abba Salama* (St. Frumentius) and the later Nine Saints, who solidified the Church's Miaphysite theological orientation. Finally, the concept of Holy Tradition (*Paradosis*, παράδοσις / *Sərᶜat*, ሥርዓት) was presented as the comprehensive and living transmission of the Orthodox faith, encompassing Scripture, doctrine, worship, and the life of the Church, as preserved and articulated by the Ethiopian Fathers.

To elaborate your knowledge;

- Please read the journal articles;
    - Moore, D. H. (1936). Christianity in Ethiopia. *Church History*, *5*(3), 271–284. https://doi.org/10.2307/3160789
    - Meyendorff, J. (1978). *Living Tradition*. St. Vladimir's Seminary Press.

Chapter Two

2 Divine Liturgy and the Theology of Ethiopian Fathers

Now we move into the heart of Ethiopian Orthodox worship; the Divine Liturgy, or as we know it, the *Qəddase* (**ቅዳሴ**). This isn't just a set of rituals. For the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church, the *Qəddase* is a profound theological event, a living encounter with God's saving work. It's where the theology of our Fathers comes alive, not just in words, but in action, in prayer, in music, and in mystery. We're talking about a journey that takes us from creation, through the fall, to the cross and resurrection of Christ, and even looks forward to His glorious return.

2.1 Key Theological Themes in the Anaphora

The Anaphora is the central Eucharistic prayer in the *Qəddase*, and it's packed with theology. We can think of the themes in two main ways;

- Dogmatic Themes; These are about the core beliefs. What we believe about Christ's nature, what happens to the bread and wine in the Eucharist – these are big dogmatic questions that the Anaphoras address.
- Canonical Themes; These relate more to the liturgical practices themselves, the rules and regulations that shape how we celebrate. For example, the *Sənodos* (**ሲኖዶስ**), which contains decrees from councils and apostolic-era writings, guides these practices. A priest leading the *Qəddase* needs to be familiar with important texts like the *Mäṣḥafä Kidan* (**መጽሐፈ ኪዳን**, Book of the Covenant), the Apostolic Canons (*Qänonatä Hawarəyat*, **ቀኖናተ ሐዋርያት**), the *Dəsqəlya* (Didaskalia, **ድስቅልያ**, Teachings of the Apostles), and the *ʾAbṭəlis* (**አብጥሊስ**, Canons). There's a strong warning from the *Sənodos* (Synodos) saying; *Kämäz mäharunä Hawarəyat bäʾabṭəlisomu* (**ከመዝ መሀሩነ ሐዋርያት በአብጥሊሶሙ**, "Thus the Apostles taught us in their Abtilis/Canons"). If a clergy member isn't well-versed in these, they really shouldn't be serving.

These two, dogmatic and canonical, they work together. Preparing the bread and wine is a canonical act, but believing they become the Body and Blood of Christ – that's a deep dogmatic belief.

The *Sənodos* (Synodos) also emphasizes the importance of reverence during the liturgy. For example, it states; *Hallelujah ʾəmäbo bəʾəsi ʾəmʾəmmänan zäboʾa betäkrəstiyan bägize qəddase wäʾisämᶜa mäṣaḥəftä qəddusatä wäʾitäᶜaggäś ʾəskä yəfeṣṣəmu ṣälotä qəddase wäʾitämәṭṭäwä ʾəm qurbran*

yəssäddäd ʾəmbetä krəstiyan ʾəsmä ʾamasänä ḥəggä ʾƎgziʾabḥer… (**ሃሌ ሉያ እመቦ ብእሲ እምእመናን ዘቦአ ቤተክርስቲያን በጊዜ ቅዳሴ ወኢሰምዐ መጻሕፍተ ቅዱሳተ ወኢተዐገሠ እስከ ይፈጽሙ ጸሎተ ቅዳሴ ወኢተመጠወ እምቁርባን ይሰደድ እምቤተ ክርስቲያን እስመ አማሰነ ሕገ እግዚአብሔር**…, "Hallelujah! If there be anyone of the faithful who has entered the church at the time of Qidase and has not heard the holy Scriptures, and has not waited until they finish the prayer of the Qidase, and has not received the holy communion, let him be driven out of the church for he has violated the law of God..."). This shows how seriously the Church takes participation and respect.

Central to our liturgy is the Real Presence of Christ. We don't just use the term "Transubstantiation" like some other traditions; for us, it's about the actual, real presence of Jesus Christ on the altar. The bread and wine truly become His Body and Blood. This isn't just symbolic; it's a mystical reality. Through this, we have communion with Christ and with the holy heavenly powers. The *Qəddase* is a covenantal meeting with God, where we receive grace and anticipate the fullness of His Kingdom. The richness of our liturgical texts, the ancient *Zema* (**ዜማ**, chant), and the rituals all invite us into this cosmic reality. This liturgical heritage, especially the composition of several anaphoras, really flourished from the early 15th to the first quarter of the 16th century, a "Golden Period" partly spurred by local theological discussions among Ethiopian *Mäməhran* (**መምህራን**, doctors/teachers) (Mäbratu K., p. 29).

2.2 Unique behavior in Ethiopian Divine liturgy

Our Divine Liturgy has some really unique features;

- **The number of *Qədasewoč̌č̌* (ቅዳሴዎች**, Anaphoras); It's not a simple thing to count them all. In the early days, the Ethiopian Church probably adapted Anaphoras from places like Egypt, like the Liturgy of St. Mark (*Qəddase Marqos*, **ቅዳሴ ማርቆስ**) (Getachew, 2012). Over time, this number grew. Traditionally, we talk about 20 Anaphoras, but commonly today, 14 are in regular use. This itself is a testament to the theological richness and liturgical creativity within our indigenous tradition.
- **The Authority of the name**; Ethiopian Church Fathers often attributed specific Anaphoras to well-known early Church scholars, which helped make these texts respected and used. Scholars like Getachew Haile and Mäbratu Kiros Gəbru have studied this. Interestingly, while some Anaphoras bear the names of ancient Greek Fathers, like Gregory of Nyssa, there's evidence they might have been significantly influenced or even composed by Ethiopian theologians. For

example, Mäbratu Kiros Gəbru notes that the Anaphora of St. Gregory of Nyssa, which speaks of the Trinity as *Śälästu ʾəḏäw* (**ሠለስቱ እደው**, "three men/persons") – *Śälästu ʾəḏäw hälläwu ḫəbenä ʾaḫazəyanä kʷəllu ʿaläm bäʾaḥatti məkər wäbäʾaḥatti śəlṭan wäbäʾaḥatti ṣəmərät* (**ሠለስቱ እደው ሀለዉ ኀቤነ አዕዝያነ ኵሉ ዓለም በአሐቲ ምክር ወበ አሐቲ ሥልጣን ወበ አሐቲ ፅምረት**, "There are among Us three persons who hold all the world with one counsel, with one authority and with one unity") – might show the influence of Abba Giyorgis of Sagla. This highlights the EOTC's confidence in its own theological insights and its ability to contribute original liturgical texts, rather than just borrowing. Out of the commonly used 14, only St. Basil's *Qəddase* (**ቅዳሴ**) is generally considered to be directly from a foreign (Egyptian) source. Many others are attributed to Ethiopian figures like Abba Giyorgis of Gasəčča or are anonymous Ethiopian compositions.

The fourteen Anaphoras most commonly known are;

1. The Anaphora of the Apostles (*Qəddase Hawarəyat*, **ቅዳሴ ሐዋርያት**)
2. The Anaphora of the Lord (*Qəddase ʾƎgziʾə*, **ቅዳሴ እግዚእ**)
3. The Anaphora of John, Son of Thunder (*Qəddase Yoḥannəs Wäldä Nägʷädgʷad*, **ቅዳሴ ዮሐንስ ወልደ ነጐድጓድ**)
4. The Anaphora of St. Mary (*Qəddase Maryam*, **ቅዳሴ ማርያም**)
5. The Anaphora of St. Athanasius (*Qəddase Atnatewos*, **ቅዳሴ አትናቴዎስ**)
6. The Anaphora of St. Basil (*Qəddase Basəlyos*, **ቅዳሴ ባስልዮስ**)
7. The Anaphora of St. Gregory I (Nyssa) (*Qəddase Gorgorəyos I*, **ቅዳሴ ጎርጎርዮስ ፩**)
8. The Anaphora of the Three Hundred (*Qəddase Śälästu Məʾət*, **ቅዳሴ ሠለስቱ ምእት**)
9. The Anaphora of St. Epiphanius (*Qəddase ʾEpifanyos*, **ቅዳሴ ኤጲፋንዮስ**)
10. The Anaphora of St. John Chrysostom (*Qəddase Yoḥannəs ʾAfäwärq*, **ቅዳሴ ዮሐንስ አፈወርቅ**)
11. The Anaphora of St. Cyril (*Qəddase Qerəllos*, **ቅዳሴ ቄርሎስ**)
12. The Anaphora of St. Jacob of Serough (*Qəddase Yaʿəqob zäŚərug*, **ቅዳሴ ያዕቆብ ዘሥሩግ**)
13. The Anaphora of St. Dioscorus (*Qəddase Dəyosqoros*, **ቅዳሴ ዲዮስቆሮስ**)
14. The Anaphora of St. Gregory II (The Wonder-worker) (*Qəddase Gorgorəyos II*, **ቅዳሴ ጎርጎርዮስ ፪**)

Our tradition holds that the Apostles themselves composed the core of their Anaphora, with later Fathers adding to it to form the Anaphora of the Lord. The Anaphora of the Three Hundred is linked to the Council of Nicaea. The Anaphora of St. Mary, a cornerstone of Ethiopian devotion, is attributed to Abba

Həryaqos, an Egyptian bishop, who was inspired by the Virgin Mary and shared it with St. Yared. This indigenous adoption and development of liturgical forms is a key aspect of our tradition.
According to Marcos Daoud, our Divine Liturgy generally has two main parts; the preparatory service and the main Divine Liturgy itself.

2.3 The Divine Liturgy of the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church

The *Qəddase* (**ቅዳሴ**) of the EOTC is a rich theological tapestry. It's not just a repetition of old rites; it's a dynamic expression of faith that has evolved, blending ancient Christian universal traditions with our own Ethiopian cultural and spiritual genius.

2.3.1 Incarnation and Eucharist

The Real Presence is absolutely central. We affirm; *ʾAʾammən ʾaʾammən kämä zəntu wəʾətu śəgahu wädämu läʾƎgziʾənä wäʾAmlakənä wämədḫaninä Iyäsus Krəstos* (**አአምን አአምን ከመ ዝንቱ ውእቱ ሥጋሁ ወደሙ ለእግዚእነ ወአምላክነ ወምድኀኒነ ኢየሱስ ክርስቶስ**, "I believe, I believe that this is the Body and Blood of our Lord and God and Savior Jesus Christ") (Qəddase Hawarəyat, **ቅዳሴ ሐዋርያት**). This isn't just symbolic. Through the invocation of the Holy Spirit by the priest (*Fänu ṣägga Mänfäs Qəddus laʿəlenä*, **ፈኑ ጸጋ መንፈስ ቅዱስ ላዕሌነ**, "Send the grace of the Holy Spirit upon us"), the bread and wine are truly changed into the Body and Blood of Christ.

The Eucharist is also a participation in Christ's sacrifice. It's a re-presentation, a making present, of His death on the cross; *Bägəʿ yəmṣaʾ nərʾayo bäʾaʿəyənt wänəṭəbḥo bäʾaʾədaw kämä nətfäśśaḥ botu* (**በግዕ ይምጻእ ንርአዮ በአዕይንት ወንጥብሖ በአእዳው ከመ ንትፈሣሕ ቦቱ**, "Let the Lamb come, let us see Him with (our) eyes and slaughter Him with (our) hands so that we may rejoice in Him") (Qəddase ʾEpifanyos 99, **ቅዳሴ ኤጲፋንዮስ ፺፱**). This powerful imagery underscores the reality of the sacrifice. And again, *Zəntu wəʾətu zänəḥənä nəśäwəʿo lämädḫanitənä bäkämä täśoʿa bäQäranəyo läḥəywätä kʷəllu ʿaläm* (**ዝንቱ ውእቱ ዘንሕነ ንሠውዮ ለመድኃኒትነ በከመ ተሠዐ በቀራንዮ ለሕይወተ ኵሉ ዓለም**, "This is what we sacrifice for our salvation as He was sacrificed on Calvary for the life of all the world") (Qəddase Yoḥannəs ʾAfäwärq 85, **ቅዳሴ ዮሐንስ አፈወርቅ ፹፭**). Through consuming the Holy Gifts, we are spiritually united with Christ. *Wäʾiyəmsəlo läʾaḥadu ʾəmnenä sobä yəbälʿə śəga baḥtito zäʾənbälä däm wämänfäs… ʾalla ʾaḥadu wəʾətu śəga wädäm wämänfäs bäkämä konä mäläkotu məślä təsbəʾətu ʾaḥadä läʿalämä ʿaläm* (**ወኢይምሰሎ ለአሐዱ እምኔነ ሶበ ይበልዕ ሥጋ ባሕቲቶ ዘእንበለ ደም ወመንፈስ……. አላ አሐዱ ውእቱ ሥጋ ወደም ወመንፈስ በከመ ኮነ መለኮቱ ምሥለ ትስብእቱ አሐደ ለዓለመ ዓለም**, "And let it not seem to one of us when he eats the flesh alone without the blood and

spirit... but it is one, flesh and blood and spirit, just as His divinity became one with His humanity forever and ever") (Qəddase ʾEpifanyos 100, **ቅዳሴ ኤጲፋንዮስ ፻**).

2.3.2 The teaching of Trinity;

Our liturgy is deeply Trinitarian. We affirm the co-essential Trinity; one God who is Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. Each divine Person is God, yet there is one God. The *Qəddase* (**ቅዳሴ**) frequently invokes all three Persons.

Regarding the Holy Spirit, for instance; *Wəʾətu zəku Mänfäs Qəddus zäʾiyətfättän wäzäʾiyəḥaṣṣəṣ* (**ውእቱ ዝኩ መንፈስ ቅዱስ ዘኢይትፈተን ወዘኢይሐጽጽ**, "May this Holy Spirit, who is neither searchable nor inferior...") (Qəddase Yoḥannəs ʾAfäwärq 72, **ቅዳሴ ዮሐንስ አፈወርቅ ፸፪**). This echoes the Nicene Creed's teaching on the Spirit proceeding from the Father.

The nature, attributes, and being of God are beautifully expressed.

From the *Qəddase Dəyosqoros* (**ቅዳሴ ዲዮስቆሮስ**);

- *ʾƎmqədmä ʿaläm wäʾəskäläʿaläm halle ʾƎgziʾabḥer bätəśəlstu ʾƎgziʾabḥer bämäläkotu ʾƎgziʾabḥer bämäläkotu ʾƎgziʾabḥer bämängəśtu* (**እምቅድመ ዓለም ወእስከለዓለም ሀሌ እግዚአብሔር በትሥልስቱ እግዚአብሔር በመለኮቱ እግዚአብሔር በመለኮቱ እግዚአብሔር በመንግሥቱ**, "From before the world and ever after, God is in His Trinity, God is in His divinity, God is in His kingdom.")

  From the *Qəddase Qerəllos* (**ቅዳሴ ቄርሎስ**);

- *ʾƎśat bällaʿi wäʾəśat maḥyäwi ʾAmlakä ʾamalakət wäʾƎgziʾa ʾagāʾəzət zämälʿəltä sämayat mänbäru wämədər mäkäyädä ʾəgərihu ləʿul wämәṭuq wəstä bərhan zäyäḫədr* (**እሣት በላዒ ወእሣት ማሕየዊ አምላከ አማልክት ወእግዚአ አጋእዝት ዘመልዕልተ ሰማያት መንበሩ ወምድር መከየደ እገሪሁ ልዑል ወምጡቅ ውስተ ብርሃን ዘየኀድር**, "He is the consuming fire, the life-giving fire, the God of gods and the Lord of lords, Whose throne is above the heavens and Whose footstool is the earth, He is high and far away, and dwells in light.")

  From the *Qəddase Yoḥannəs ʾAfäwärq* (**ቅዳሴ ዮሐንስ አፈወርቅ**);

- *Nahu nəzenu həllawehu läʾAb zähallo ʾəmqədmä yətfäṭär ʿaläm wäyəhelu ʾəskä läʿaläm ʾalbo ʾəmqədmehu wäʾalbo ʾəmdədḫərehu wäʾalbo zä kämahu wäʾalbo wäʾalbo zäyäʾamər zäkämä ʾəfo wəʾətu* (**ናሁ ንዜኑ ህላዌሁ ለአብ ዘህሎ እምቅድመ ይትፈጠር ዓለም ወይሄሉ እስከ ለዓለም አልቦ እምቅድሜሁ ወአልቦ እምድኅሬሁ ወአልቦ ዘ ከማሁ ወአልቦ ወአልቦ ዘየአምር ዘከመ እፎ ውእቱ**, "Behold we proclaim the existence of the Father Who was before the world was created and will live for ever. None was before Him, none will be after Him, none is like Him, and none knows

what is His being.")

From the *Qəddase ʾEpifanyos* (**ቅዳሴ ኤጲፋንዮስ**);

- *ʿAbiy wəʾətu ʾƎgziʾabḥer bäʿəbäyu qəddus bäqəddasehu ʾək*ʷ*ət bäʾakk*ʷ*ätetu wäsəbuḥ bäsəbḥatihu* (**ዐቢይ ውእቱ እግዚአብሔር በዕበዩ ቅዱስ በቅዳሴሁ እኵት በአኩቴቱ ወስቡህ በስብሐቲሁ**, "God is great in His greatness, holy in His holiness, blessed in His beatitude and glorified in His glory.")
- *Qädamawi wəʾətu zäʾiyəblәʾəwo ʾamaʾəze wämaʾəkälawi zäʾiyəblәʾəwo ʾəskäyəʾəze wädäḫarawi wəʾətu zäʾiyəblәʾəwo ʾəskä zəyä* (**ቀዳማዊ ውእቱ ዘኢይብልእዎ አማእዜ ወማእከላዊ ዘኢይብልእዎ እስከይእዜ ወደኃራዊ ውእቱ ዘኢይብልእዎ እስከ ዝየ**, "He is the first, yet of Him it is not asked, 'When was His beginning?' With Him it is ever 'now.' Yet of Him it is not asked, 'How long will He endure?'; And He is the last. Yet of Him it is not asked, 'When will His end be?'")

  From the *Qəddase Śälästu Məʾət* (**ቅዳሴ ሠለስቱ ምእት**);
- *ʾAlbo ʾamä ʾihallo* (**አልቦ አመ ኢሀሎ**, "There is no time in which He was not").

  From the *Qəddase Basəlyos zäQisarya* (**ቅዳሴ ባስልዮስ ዘቂሳርያ**, Anaphora of Basil of Caesarea);
- *Həlläw ʾƎgziʾabḥer ʾAmlakənä zäbäʾäman ʾəmqədmä yətfäṭär ʿaläm wäyənägəś ʾəskä zäläʿaläm zäyənäbər wəstä ʾarəyam wäyəreʾi təḥutanä* (**ህልው እግዚአብሔር አምላነ ዘበ አማን እምቅድመ ይትፈጠር ዓለም ወይነግስ እስከ ዘለዓለም ዘይነብር ውስተ አርያም ወይሬኢ ትሑታነ**, "Living Master, Lord our God, Who in truth was before the world was created, who reigns for ever and art in the highest and beholds the humble.")

2.3.3 The Economy of Salvation in Orthodox Theology;

The entire plan of salvation, *God's economy*, revolves around the Incarnation of God the Son. The *Qəddase Yaʿəqob zäŚərug* (**ቅዳሴ ያዕቆብ ዘሥሩግ**) beautifully recounts Christ's life; *BäBetäləḥem täwäldəkä wäkämä śäbʾ ʾastärʾayəkä ʾəm habä Yoḥannəs täṭämäqkä wädəbä baḥər horəkä näfaśatä gäśäṣkä* (**በቤተልሔም ተወለድከ ወከመ ሰብእ አስተርአይከ እም ሀበ ዮሐንስ ተጠመቅከ ወዲበ ባሕር ሖርከ ነፋሣተ ገሠፅከ**, "…was born at Bethlehem and Thou appeared like a man. Thou was baptized by John, walked on the sea, rebuked the winds…"). His death; *ʿArəb ʾameha ʾəkuyan ʾAyəhud dibä ʾəṣ śäqälukä* (**ዓርብ አሜሃ እኩያን አይሁድ ዲበ ዕጽ ሰቀሉከ**, "At that time, on Friday, the evil Jews crucified Thee on the tree of the cross"). The *Qəddase Yoḥannəs ʾAfäwärq* (**ቅዳሴ ዮሐንስ አፈወርቅ**) exclaims about His

passion; *ʾAy af wäʾay känäfər wäʾay ləsan zäyətənaggär ḥəmamatəhu läWäld* (**አይ አፍ ወአይ ከነፍር ወአይ ልሳን ዘይትናገር ሕማማቲሁ ለወልድ**, "What mouth, what lips, what tongue can express the sufferings of the Son?"). His resurrection; *ʾƎmmutan tänśəʾakä… wämutanä ʾänśaʾəkä* (**እሙታን ተንሣእከ… ወሙታነ አንሣእከ**, "[Thou] rose from the dead… and raised the dead") (Qəddase Yaᶜəqob zäŚərug, **ቅዳሴ ያዕቆብ ዘሥሩግ**).

The *Qəddase ʾEpifanyos* (**ቅዳሴ ኤጲፋንዮስ**) states; *Wäʾəmzə sobä rəʾəyä kämä ʾibaquᶜ lädəḫnätä ᶜaläm dämä näbiyat qəddusan… fänäwä länä Wäldo mädḫənä wämäbezwä* (**ወእምዝ ሶበ ርእየ ከመ ኢባቁዕ ለድኅነተ ዓለም ደመ ነቢያት ቅዱሳን… ፈነወ ለነ ወልዶ መድኀኒ ወመቤዝወ**, "After this, when He saw that the blood of the holy prophets… was not sufficient for the salvation of the world, He sent unto us His Son, a Saviour and Redeemer").

His coming was by the Father's will; *Bäfäqadä ʾAbuhu wärädä* (**በፈቃደ አቡሁ ወረደ**, "He came down by the will of His Father") (Qəddase Dəyosqoros, **ቅዳሴ ዲዮስቆሮስ**). And His passion was also according to this divine plan; *Ḥamä bäfäqadu wätäsäqlä bäśəmrätu wämotä bäməkərä ʾAbuhu wätänśəʾa bäsaləst ʾəlät* (**ሐመ በፈቃዱ ወተሰቅለ በሥምረቱ ወሞተ በምክረ አቡሁ ወተንሥአ በሣልስት እለት**, "He suffered by His will, was pleased to be crucified, died through the counsel of His Father, rose on the third day") (Qəddase Gorgorəyos, **ቅዳሴ ጎርጎርዮስ**).

2.3.4 Mariology;

The Virgin Mary, *ʾƎgəzaʾətənä Maryam* (**እግዝእትነ ማርያም**, Our Lady Mary), holds an exalted place. She is the *Theotokos* (Θεοτόκος, God-bearer, or in *Ge'ez*, *Wälalidtä Amlak*, **ወላዲተ አምላክ**). The *Qəddase Qerəllos* (**ቅዳሴ ቄርሎስ**) affirms; *Nənəgər wänzzenu ləddäto ʾəmdəngəl baḥtitu Wäldä ʾAmlak zäʾəm baḥtita Wälättä Dawit zäʾənbälä ʾab mədrayi* (**ንንግር ወንዜኑ ልደቶ እምድንግል ባሕቲቱ ወልደ አምላክ ዘእም ባህቲታ ወለተ ዳዊት ዘእንበለ አብ ምድራዊ**, "Let us speak of and proclaim the birth of Him Who is alone the Son of God, and, Who alone was born without an earthly Father from the Virgin, the daughter of David."). Her perpetual virginity and her role in salvation are deeply woven into our worship. We will explore this further in Chapter 8 (as per the TOC).

2.3.5 Eschatology; Last Judgment

Our liturgies also look to the end times (*mäṣḥafä fiṣṣame*, **መጽሐፈ ፍጻሜ**). The *Qəddase Yaᶜəqob zäŚərug* (**ቅዳሴ ያዕቆብ ዘሥሩግ**) is particularly rich in eschatological themes, painting a vivid picture of Christ's second coming, the resurrection of the dead, and the final judgment. It reminds us; *ʾAko länä*

ʾƎgziʾo läkərəstiyan ḥəzbəkä zəntu ʿaläm täsfa zäʾiyəbäli wäzäʾiyəmasən ʾalla zäyəmṣəʾ nəsəfo wənəṣänəḥ (**አኮ ለነ እግዚኦ ለክርስቲያን ሕዝብከ ዝንቱ ዓለም ተስፋ ዘኢይበሊ ወዘኢይማስን አላ ዘይመጽእ ንሴፎ ወንጸንሕ**, "Lord, this corruptible and transient world of hoping is not for us, Thy Christian people; but we hope and wait for that which is to come."). The liturgy describes the trumpets sounding (*nəfḥatä qärn*, **ንፍሐተ ቀርን**), the gathering of the dust of bodies (*ṣäbälä śəga*, **ጸበለ ሥጋ**), and the separation of the righteous and sinners, echoing Matthew 25. The faithful place their trust in the Eucharist and the intercession of St. Mary and all saints for mercy on that day; *ʾAmeha kämä təmḥaränä wätəśahaläna tämaḫṣənnä bäzäbälaʿənnä śəgakä wäbäzäsätäynä dämäkä ʾəsmä ʾantä təbe zäbälʿa śəgayä wäsätyä dämyä bo ḥəywät zäläʿaläm* (**አሜሃ ከመ ትምሐረነ ወትሣሃለነ ተማኅፀነ በዘበላዕነ ሥጋከ ወበዘሰተይነ ደመከ እስመ አንተ ትቤ ዘበልዐ ሥጋየ ወሰትየ ደምየ ቦ ሕይወት ዘለዓለም**, "We have trusted on Thy body which we have eaten and Thy blood which we have drunk that Thou at that time may have compassion and mercy upon us, because Thou said, 'Whoever eats My flesh, and drinks My blood, has eternal life.'").

Chapter Three
3 Ethiopian Orthodox Theology and Practice

Now we're going to look at how Ethiopian Orthodox theology isn't just abstract ideas, but how it's lived out in practice. The EOTC has a way of doing things that is deeply rooted in ancient times, and as we touched on before, it has this noticeable connection to Jewish customs, which gives it a unique *Judeo-Christian* flavor. We'll explore some of these practices and then look at a very important historical document, the Confession of Emperor Gelawdewos, which really lays out some core beliefs in response to outside challenges.

3.1 Jewish Element and Ethiopia

We've already mentioned the *Kəbrä Nägäśt* (**ክብረ ነገሥት**) and the story of Solomon, Sheba, Menelik I, and the Ark. This narrative isn't just a story; it underpins a lot of practices. The idea of Ethiopia having this special link to the Old Covenant is strong.

Some of the practices that show this connection include;

- A diet that resembles *Kosher* laws in some ways – for example, the traditional avoidance of pork and certain shellfish (Leviticus 11).
- Sabbath observance; celebrating Saturday as a Sabbath, often involving abstaining from certain work, alongside Sunday, the Lord's Day. This is quite unique in the Christian world.
- Circumcision (*Gəzrät*, **ግዝረት**); while also an ancient African custom in many places, its practice in Ethiopia is often seen through this Hebraic lens as well.
- Pilgrimage; the importance of pilgrimage to holy sites has ancient parallels.
- The Solomonic Dynasty claim itself.
- A strong emphasis on the Old Testament; it features very prominently in our prayer life, our liturgy (*Qəddase*, **ቅዳሴ**), and our general spiritual understanding.

3.2 The confession of Claudies the Emperor

A really important document for understanding Ethiopian Orthodox belief, especially how it saw itself in relation to outside influences, is the Confession of Emperor Gelawdewos (Gäla गुड्डेवोस). He reigned from 1540 to 1559, and his reigning name was *Aṣnaf Sägäd I* (**አጽናፍ ሰገድ ፩**). He wrote this confession in the 16th century, largely as a response to Jesuit missionaries who were trying to bring the

Ethiopian Church under Roman Catholic authority and were critical of Ethiopian practices. His confession, sometimes called *Ṭomarä Gäla* ጉጅለወስ (**ጦማረ ገላውዴዎስ** - Letter of Gelawdewos) or *Ṣälotä Haymanot zäʾAfriqiya* (**ጸሎተ ሃይማኖት ዘአፍሪቂያ** - The Prayer of Faith of Africa), clearly states the Ethiopian Orthodox position on core Christian doctrines and defends these unique practices.
This Confession is a powerful example of an indigenous African Christian articulation of faith encountering European interpretations. The Jesuits, coming with their own understanding, perhaps didn't grasp the deep historical and cultural roots of Ethiopian practices. Emperor Gelawdewos wasn't just making things up; he was drawing on a long literary and theological tradition within the EOTC of defining and defending its faith. His work shows how culture and belief are intertwined and how rituals like circumcision or Sabbath observance had profound meaning for Ethiopians, both religiously and culturally. For instance, to be uncircumcised was seen as a serious defect, making someone ritually 'unclean' in a traditional sense. These weren't things that could just be dropped easily.
Let's look at some key parts of his Confession (translations adapted from Lule Melaku's "History of The Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church," pp. 113-115, and other scholarly editions);

3.2.1 Fundamental belief

He begins by affirming the core Trinitarian faith and the Nicene Creed;

- *Bäsəmä ʾAb wäWäld wäMänfäs Qəddus ʾAḥadu ʾAmlak. Amen. Zəntu wəʾətu Haymanotəyä wäHaymanotä ʾAbäwəyä Nägäśt ʾƏśraʾelawəyan wäHaymanotä Mərᶜetəyä ʾəllä hälläw bäᶜAṣädä Mängəśtəyä.*
  (**በስመ አብ ወወልድ ወመንፈስ ቅዱስ አሐዱ አምላክ አሜን ዝንቱ ውእቱ ሃይማኖትየ ወሃይማኖተ አበውየ ነገሥት እስራኤላውያን ወሃይማኖተ መርዔትየ እለ ሀለው በዐፀደ መንግሥትየ** - "In the Name of the Father, and the Son, and the Holy Spirit, one God. Amen. This is my faith, and the faith of my fathers, the Israelite kings, and the faith of my flock which is within the fold of my kingdom.")
- He then confesses belief in One God; and in His only Son, Jesus Christ – His Word, Power, Counsel, and Wisdom, who was with Him before the world's creation. In the last days, Christ came, not leaving His divine throne, and was made man by the Holy Spirit and of the Holy Virgin Mary. He was baptized in the Jordan in His thirtieth year.

- *Nəḥənä nəʾamən bäʾAḥadu ʾAmlak wäbäWäldu Waḥəd Iyäsus Krəstos wəʾətu Qalu wäwəʾətu Ḫaylu wəʾətu Məkru wäwəʾətu Ṭəbäbu. Zähälläwä məślehu ʾəmqədmä yətfäṭär ʿaläm; wäbädäḫari mäwaʿəl mäṣʾa ḫabenä ʾənzä ʾiyäʿərq ʾəmmänbärä Mäläkotu. Wätäsäbʾa ʾəmMänfäs Qəddus wäʾəMaryam ʾəmqəddəst Dəngəl. Wätäṭämqä bäYordanos bäŚälasa kərəmət.*

  (ንሕነ ነአምን በአሐዱ አምላክ ወበወልዱ ዋሕድ ኢየሱስ ክርስቶስ ውእቱ ቃሉ ወውእቱ ኃይሉ ውእቱ ምክሩ ወውእቱ ጥበቡ ፡ ፡ ዘሀለወ ምስሌሁ እምቅድመ ይትፈጠር ዓለም ፤ ወበደኃሪ መዋዕል መጽአ ኀቤነ እንዘ ኢየዐርቅ እመንበረ መለኮቱ ፡ ፡ ወተሰብአ እመንፈስ ቅዱስ ወእማርያም እምቅድስት ድንግል ፡ ፡ ወተጠምቀ በዮርዳኖስ በሥላሳ ክረምት)

- He affirms Christ was perfect man, crucified under Pontius Pilate, suffered, died, was buried, and rose on the third day. On the fortieth day, He ascended to heaven and sat at the right hand of the Father. He will come again to judge the living and the dead, and His kingdom will have no end. He also confesses belief in the Holy Spirit, the Lord and Giver of Life, who proceeds from the Father; in One Baptism for the remission of sins; and hope for the resurrection of the dead and eternal life.
  - *Wäkonä bəʾəse fəṣṣumä; wätäsäqlä dibä ʾəṣä Mäsqäl bämäwaʿəlä Pilaṭos Ṗänṭenawi. Ḥamä wämotä wätäqäbrä wätänəśʾa bäŚaləst ʾəlät. Wäʾəmz bäʿArəbʿa ʾəlät ʿarägä bäsəbḥat wəstä Sämayat wänäbärä bäyämanä ʾAbuhu. Wäkaʿəbä yəməṣəʾ bäsəbḥat yəkonnən ḥəyawanä wämutanä; wäʾalbo maḫəläqt läMängəśtu.*

    (ወኮነ ብእሴ ፍጹመ ፤ ወተሰቅለ ዲበ ዕፀ መስቀል በመዋዕለ ጲላጦስ ጰንጤናዊ ፡ ፡ ሐመ ወሞተ ወተቀብረ ወተንሥአ በሣልስት ዕለት ፡ ፡ ወእምዝ በዓርብዓ ዕለት ዐርገ በስብሐት ውስተ ሰማያት ወነበረ በየማነ አቡሁ ፡ ፡ ወካዕበ ይመጽእ በስብሐት ይኮንን ሕያዋነ ወሙታነ ፤ ወአልቦ ማኅለቅት ለመንግሥቱ ፡ ፡)

- Crucially, he states the source of this faith; *Nəḥənäsä näḥawər bäfənotä Nəguś ṣəyuḥ ʾamanawi wäʾinaṣännən ʾilä yäman wäʾiläṣägam ʾəmtəməhərtä ʾAbäwinä; 12 Ḥawarəyat wäṖawlos fəlfälä ṭəbäb wä72 ʾArədʾət wä318 Rətuʿanä Haymanot zätägabʾu bäNiqiya wä150 bäQʷəsṭənṭənəya wä200 bäʾEfeson. Kämäz ʾəsäbək wäkämäz ʾəmehhər ʾAnä Gäla ግኔዎስ Nəguś zäʾItəyoṗṗəya wäsəmä Mängəśtəyä ʾAṣnaf Sägäd Wäldä Wänag Sägäd Wäldä Naʾod.*

  (ንሕነሰ ፡ ነሐውር ፡ በፍኖተ ፡ ንጉሥ ፡ ጽዮሕ ፡ አማናዊ ፡ ወኢናጸንን ፡ ኢለ የማን ፡ ወኢለፀጋም ፡ እምትምህርተ ፡ አበዊነ ፡ ፲ወ፪ሐዋርያት ፡ ወጳውሎ ስ ፡ ፈልፈለ ፡ ጥበብ ፡

ወሧወፀአርድእት ፡ ወቮያኀወቷ ፡ ርቱዓነ ፡ ሃይማኖት ፡ ዘተጋብኡ ፡ በኒቅያ ፡ ወያወፃ ፡ በቀኖስጥንጥንያ ፡ ወፀያበኤፌሶን ። ከመዝ ፡ እሰብክ ፡ ወከመዝ ፡ እሜህር ፡ አነ ፡ ገላውዴዎስ ፡ ንጉሥ ፡ ዘኢትዮጵያ ፡ ወ ስመ ፡ መንግስትየ ፡ አጽናፍ ፡ ሰገድ ፡ ወልደ ፡ ወናግ ፡ ሰገድ ፡ ወልደ ፡ ናኦ ድ - "And we walk in the King's Highway, evident and true; and neither to the right, nor to the left, do we turn aside from the doctrine of our fathers, the Twelve Apostles; and of Paul, the Font of Wisdom; and of the seventy-two disciples; and of the three-hundred and eighteen Orthodox [Fathers], who were gathered together in Nicaea; and of the one-hundred and fifty, in Constantinople; and of the two hundred, in Ephesus. Thus do I proclaim, and thus do I teach: I, Gelawdewos, King of Ethiopia, whose reigning name is Asnaf Seged, the son of Wanag Seged, and the son of Naod.") This emphasizes adherence to the first three Ecumenical Councils, the foundational councils for the Oriental Orthodox communion.

3.2.2 On Celebration of Sabath

Gelawdewos then defends Ethiopian practices, distinguishing them from Jewish observance while affirming their Christian meaning.

- Regarding the Sabbath (Saturday); *Wäbəʾəntä məkənəyatä ʾAkəbərotənä ʾəlätä qädamit Sänbät ʾako zənaʾakəbəra kämä ʾAyəhud ʾəllä säqäləwo läKrəstos... Nəḥənä sä naʾakəbəra ʾənzä naʿarəg bati Qʷərban wänəgäbər bati məsaḥä bäkämä ʾazzäzunä ʾAbäwinä Ḥawarəyat bäDidəsəqəlya.*
(**ወበእንተ ፡ ምክንያተ ፡ አክብሮትነ ፡ ዕለተ ፡ ቀዳሚት ፡ ሰንበት ፡ አኮ ፡ ዘናከ ብራ ፡ ከመ ፡ አይሁድ ፡ እለ ፡ ሰቀልዎ ፡ ለክርስቶስ ፡**... **ንሕነ ሰ ፡ ናከብራ ፡ እንዘ ፡ ናዓርግ ፡ ባቲ ፡ቍርባን ፡ ወንገብር ፡ ባቲ ፡ ምሳሐ ፡ በ ከመ ፡ አዘዙነ ፡ አበዊነ ፡ ሐዋርያት ፡ በዲድስቅልያ ።** - "Now, with regard to observance of the Original Sabbath [Saturday], we do not keep it as the Jews do, who crucified Christ... but we keep it, in that we celebrate, thereon, the Lord's Supper, and hold love feasts, as our fathers, [the Apostles], have instructed us, in the Didascalia.")
- He contrasts this with Sunday, the Lord's Day of Resurrection; *ʾAko zənaʾakəbəra kämä Sänbätä ʾƏḥud ʾəntä yəʾəti ʾəlätä ḥadäs... ʾƎsmä bati tänəśʾa ʾƎgziʾənä Iyäsus Krəstos wäbati wärädä Mänfäs Qəddus laʿəlä Ḥawarəyat...*
(**አኮ ፡ ዘናከብራ ፡ ከ መ ፡ ሰንበተ ፡ እሑድ ፡ እንተ ፡ ይእቲ ፡ ዕለተ ፡ ሐደስ ፡**... **እስመ ፡ ባቲ ፡ ተንሥአ ፡ እግዚእነ ፡ ኢየሱስ ፡ ክርስቶስ ፡ ወባ ቲ ፡ ወረደ ፡ መንፈስ ፡ ቅዱስ ፡ ላዕለ ፡ ሐዋርያት ፡**... - "We don't observe it as the Sabbath of the first day of the week, [Sunday], which

is a new day... because, on it, our Lord Jesus Christ rose again and, on it, the Holy Ghost descended on the Apostles...") Sunday is also affirmed as the day of Incarnation and the future Second Coming.

3.2.3 On Circumsision

Regarding circumcision (*Gəzrät*, **ግዝረት**);

- *Wäbəʾəntä śərʿatä Gəzrätəni ʾako zənətəgäzzär kämä ʾAyəhud ʾəsmä nəḥənä naʾamər Qalä məhrohu läPawlos... tägəzrohi ʾiyəbäqʷəʿ wäʾitägəzrohi ʾiyaśäləṭ zäʾənbälä daʾəmu ḥadäs fəṭrät...*
(ወበእንተ ፡ ሥርዓተ ፡ ግዝረትኒ ፡ አኮ ፡ ዘንትገዘር ፡ ከመ ፡ አይሁድ ፡ እስ መ ፡ ንሕነ ፡ ናአምር ፡ ቃለ ፡ ምህሮሁ ፡ ለጳውሎስ ፡… ተገዝሮሂ ፡ ኢይበቍዕ ፡ ወኢተገዝሮሂ ፡ ኢያሠልጥ ፡ ዘእንበለ ፡ ዳእ ሙ ፡ ሐደስ ፡ ፍጥረት ፡… - "Again, concerning the question of circumcision; we are not circumcised as the Jews, because we know the words of the doctrine of Paul... 'Neither is circumcision anything, nor uncircumcision, but a new creature...'" (Galatians 5;6, 6;15)).
- He explains it as a national custom; *Wäbaḥətu Gəzrät sä zäkonä bäḫabenä bäləmadä hagär... Zäntäsä zänəgäbər ʾako bäʿAqibä ḥəgägä ʾOrit daʾəmu bäləmadä śäbʾ.*
(ወባሕቱ ፡ ግዝረት ሰ ፡ ዘኮነ ፡ በ'ንቤነ ፡ በልማደ ፡ ሀገር ፡… ዘንተሰ ፡ ዘንገብር ፡ አኮ ፡ በዐቂበ ፡ ሕገገ ፡ ኦሪት ፡ ዳእሙ ፡ በልማደ ፡ ሰብእ ።። - "But circumcision, amongst us, is according to the custom of the country... And what we do is not in observance of the Mosaic Law, but according to the custom of men.") He likens it to other cultural practices like facial markings or ear piercing in other lands.

3.2.4 On Khosher (Dietary Laws)

Finally, concerning dietary laws, like avoiding pork;

- *Wäbəʾəntä bäliʿa ḥarawəyani ʾako zənətəkalaʾ bäʿAqibä ḥəgägä ʾOrit kämä ʾAyəhud... Lläzäni bälʿa ʾinasəqʷərro wäʾinarəkʷəso wäläzäni ʾibälʿa kämä yəbəlaʿ ʾinagebəro.*
(ወበእንተ ፡ በሊዐ ፡ ሐራው'ኒ ፡ አኮ ፡ ዘንትከላእ ፡ በዐቂበ ፡ ሕገገ ፡ ኦሪት ፡ ከመ ፡ አይሁድ ፡… ለዘኒ ፡ በልዐ ፡ ኢናስቆርሮ ፡ ወኢናረኵሶ ፡ ወለዘኒ ፡ ኢበ ልዐ ፡ ከመ ፡ ይብላዕ ፡ ኢናጌብሮ ።። - "Finally, with regard to eating the flesh of swine; we are not prohibited from it, as the Jews are, by observance of the Law of Moses... But he who eats thereof, we do not despise or consider unclean; and him who doesn't eat thereof, we do not compel to it.")

- He quotes St. Paul (Romans 14;3, 17) and Jesus' words from Matthew 15;17-20 about what truly defiles a person, concluding that all food is clean in the New Covenant. He frames dietary choices as personal preference rather than Mosaic law; *Kämäz wəʾətu śəmrätu wäfäqadu läśäbʾ. Bäʾəntä mäbəllᶜa śəga ʾənəsəsasä ʾalbo ḥəggä wäʾalbo qänona wəstä Mäṣḥaf ḥadäs kʷəllu nəṣuḥ länəṣuḥan.*

  (**ከመዝ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ሥምረቱ ፡ ወፈቃዱ ፡ ለሰብእ ። በእንተ ፡ መብልዐ ፡ ሥጋ ፡ እንስሳሰ ፡ አልቦ ፡ ሕገ ፡ ወአልቦ ፡ ቀኖና ፡ ውስተ ፡ መጽ ሐፍ ፡ ሐደስ ፡ ኮሉ ፡ ንጹሕ ፡ ለንጹሐን ።** - "This is the good will and pleasure of men. And touching the eating of animal food, there is no law or canon in the New Testament: 'All is clean, to the clean'" (Titus 1;15)).

Emperor Gelawdewos concludes his Confession by stating its purpose; *Yəhən lämäṣaf yätägahut yähaymanoten əwənätən əndətawəqu näw...* (**ይህን ለመጻፍ የተጋሁት የሃይማኖቴን እውነቱን እንድታውቁ ነው**... - "This is all that I desired to write, that you may know the truth of my faith..."). It remains a powerful testament to the EOTC's distinct theological understanding and practice, articulated from an indigenous Ethiopian perspective in the face of external pressure.

Chapter Four
4 Ethiopian Fathers teaching on the Ark of the covenant

The Ark of the Covenant, or *Tabotä Ṣəyon* (**ታቦተ ጽዮን** - Ark of Zion) as it's often referred to in our tradition, holds an absolutely central place in Ethiopian Orthodox theology and worship. It's not just a historical relic for us; it's a living symbol of God's presence, His covenant, and it deeply informs our understanding of Christ and Our Lady St. Mary.

In general Jewish and Christian understanding, the Ark represented God's dwelling place, the *Shekinah*, among His people. It housed the Ten Commandments, a testament to the covenant. The Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church sees this Old Testament reality as profoundly foreshadowing New Testament truths. The Ark is often understood as a type, a prefigurement, of Christ Himself, who is the ultimate fulfillment of God's covenant and the very embodiment of God's presence with humanity. One of our liturgical texts puts it this way; *...Tabot bäwärq ləbuṭ ʾəmkʷəllehe zägəbur ʾəm ʾəṣ yətmessä länä zäʾƎgziʾabḥer Qalä zäkonä śäbʾa* (*…***ታቦት በወርቅ ልቡጥ እምኵለሄ ዘግቡር እም እፅ ይትሜሰል ለነ ዘእግዚአብሔር ቃለ ዘኮነ ሰብአ** - "...the Ark, overlaid with gold on all sides, made of wood, symbolizes for us the Word of God who became man") (from *Haymanotä Abäw*, Faith of the Fathers, often quoting sources like Cyril of Alexandria).

Furthermore, the Ark is a powerful symbol of the Holy Virgin Mary. Just as the Ark contained the Manna (the bread from heaven) and the tablets of the Law (God's Word), St. Mary contained within her womb Christ, the true Bread of Life and the Incarnate Word of God. A well-known hymn, drawing from Psalm 132;8 ("Arise, O Lord, into thy rest; thou, and the ark of thy strength"), is applied to her; *Tänəśʾə ʾƎgziʾo wəstä ʾərəfətkä* (**ተንሥእ እግዚኦ ውስተ እረፍትከ** - "Arise, O Lord, into Your rest"). St. Ephrem the Syrian, whose homilies are highly regarded in our tradition, also famously refers to Mary with this typology; *ʾƎsmä konät Tabotä läʾAḥadu zäʾəmqəddəst Śəllase* (**እስመ ኮነት ታቦተ ለአሐዱ ዘእምቅድስት ሥላሴ** - "For she became the Ark for the One of the Holy Trinity").

The tradition, as we discussed before, of Menelik I bringing the Ark to Ethiopia, detailed in the *Kəbrä Nägäśt* (**ክብረ ነገሥት**) (Brooks, 1996), solidifies its physical and spiritual importance for Ethiopia. The belief that the original Ark resides in the Church of Our Lady Mary of Zion in Aksum is a cornerstone of Ethiopian Orthodox identity.

Now, this profound reverence for the *Tabot* (**ታቦት**) – the consecrated replica present in every church – and also for holy icons (*Śəʾəlat*, **ሥዕላት**) has sometimes been misunderstood or challenged from outside. Our Ethiopian Fathers have, therefore, produced texts defending these sacred practices.

4.1 About EMML2136

One such important text is found in the manuscript designated EMML 2136, which is kept at the Məṭṭaq Täklä Haymanot (**ምጣቅ ተክለ ሃይማኖት**) Church. This manuscript contains a treatise in *Ge'ez* (**ግዕዝ**) specifically titled *Bəʾəntä Śəʾəl wäTabot* (**በእንተ ሥዕል ወታቦት** - "Concerning Icon and Tabot"), which defends the veneration of icons and the central role of the *Tabot*. According to Getatchew Haile (1982), who cataloged many of these manuscripts, EMML 2136 is likely a copy of an older original. Such texts are invaluable because they articulate an indigenous Ethiopian theological rationale for practices that are deeply embedded in our tradition, demonstrating how our Fathers understood these symbols in relation to God's commands and presence.

4.2 A text in defense of Tabots and icons; *Bəʾəntä Śəʾəl wäTabot*

The manuscript EMML 2136, housed at the Məṭṭaq Täklä Haymanot (**ምጣቅ ተክለ ሃይማኖት**) Church, contains an important *Ge'ez* (**ግዕዝ**) treatise titled *Bəʾəntä Śəʾəl wäTabot* (**በእንተ ሥዕል ወታቦት**), meaning "Concerning Icon and Tabot." This text specifically aims to provide a theological defense for the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church's use and veneration of holy icons (*Śəʾəlat*, **ሥዕላት**) and the central place of the *Tabot* (**ታቦት**) in worship. Such defenses became particularly important when these indigenous practices were questioned or misunderstood by those outside the tradition. The arguments presented are rooted in Scripture, patristic understanding, and the lived experience of the Church.

4.2.1 About Icons (*Śəʾəlat*, **ሥዕላት**)

The defense of icons in texts like this typically begins by clarifying what is *not* occurring; it is not idolatry but a means to remember and honor God, especially given human frailty.

- The text might state something along these lines; *Mäṣḥafä Näbiyat fəkkare raʾəyomu nənäggər bäʾəntä śəʾəl wäTabot zänəsägd lotu ʾako zəntu gäbirä fäṭära ʾəmḫabenä.*
  (**መጽሐፈ ነቢያት ፍካሬ ራእዮሙ ንነግር በእንተ ሥዕል ወታቦት ዘንሰግድ ሎቱ አኮ ዝንቱ ገቢረ ፈጠራ እምኀቤነ ።** - "The Books of the Prophets: We (hereby) tell the interpretation of their vision(s) on icon and Tabot. The fact that we bow to them is not an act of our making (i.e., not our own invention).")

- It then refutes the idea of worshipping the material itself; *Ḥəsä länä ʾəmzəntu kämä nəḫdəgo läFäṭarinä wänəsəgd läʾəṣäw wäläməslat; ʾalla ləlihu ʾAmlakənä ʾazzäzänä kämä nəśəʿal ʾamsalihu wäyəkʷən wətrå śəʿul qədmä ʾaʿəyəntinä kämä ʾinərəśaʿ zəkəroto bäʾəntä ḥəmamä śəganä.*

  (**ሐሰ ለነ እምዝንቱ ከመ ንኀድጎ ለፈጣሪነ ወንስግድ ለዕፀው ወለምስላት ፤ አላ ለሊሁ አምላክነ አዘዘነ ከመ ንሥዐል አምሳሊሁ ወይኩን ወትረ ሥዑል ቅድመ አዕይንቲነ ከመ ኢንርሣዕ ዘክሮቶ በእንተ ሕማመ ሥጋ ነ ።** - "Far be it from us that we leave Our Creator and worship woods and images. Rather, Our God himself has ordered us to picture his image and that it is always pictured before our eyes lest we forget remembering him because of the weakness of our body.")

The justification often turns to biblical precedents where God Himself commanded the making of images or where holy images were miraculously produced;

- The Cherubim on the Ark; *ʾƎsmä yibelo ʾƎgziʾabḥer läMuse gəbär 2tä śəʾəlä Kirub wäʾəmhəyä ʾətʾeməräkä wäʾətənaggəräkä.*

  (**እስመ ይቤሎ እግዚአብሔር ለሙሴ ግበር ፪ተ ሥዕለ ኪሩብ ወእምህየ እትኤመረከ ወእትናገረከ ።** - "For God has said to Moses, 'Make two pictures of the Cherubim, and from there, I will be known to you and speak with you.'") (cf. Exodus 25;18-22).

- The tradition of Christ sending His image to King Abgar (the Mandylion); *WäläḪawarəyatəni ʾarʾayomu śəʾəlä ziʾahu ʾƎgziʾənä ʾamä fännäwä ḫabehu ʾAqarəyos wäḫaśśäśä gäṣo bäləbs wätäśəʾəlä ʾamsalu bäləbs. Wäwəʾətu ləbs hallo ʾəskä yəʾəze.*

  (**ወለሐዋርያትኒ አርአዮሙ ሥዕለ ዚአሁ እግዚእነ አመ ፈነወ ኀቤሁ አቃርዮስ ወኃሠሠ ገጸ በልብስ ወተሥዕለ አምሳሉ በልብስ ። ወውእቱ ልብስ ሀሎ እስከ ይእዜ ።** - "To the Apostles, too, Our Lord showed them his picture when Abgar sent a missive to him. (Our Lord), felt his countenance with a (piece of) cloth and his image was pictured on the cloth. The particular cloth is still there until now.")

- The image given to Veronica (*Abranqəs* in some Ethiopian versions); *Wäkamahu läʾAbəranqəs wähäbä mändilä zäśəʿul wəstetu śəʾəlä ziʾahu ʾamä ḫaśśäśä ḫafä gäṣu ʾəmdəkam ḫabä ʾänbärä Mäsqälä.*

  (**ወከማሁ ለአብራንቅስ ወሀበ መንዲለ ዘሥዑል ውስቴቱ ሥዕለ ዚአሁ አመ ኃሠሠ ሐፈ ገጹ እምድካም ኀበ አንበረ መስቀለ ።** - "Similarly, he gave to Abranqəs a handkerchief on which his

picture was pictured when he felt the sweat of his face when he put down the Cross because of exhaustion.")

- The tradition of apostles painting icons, such as St. John for Caesar, or St. Luke painting the Virgin Mary; *Wäᶜadi Yoḥannəsä fəqurä [ʾƎgziʾə] śäᶜalä lotu läQeṣar śəʾəlä śəqlätu läʾƎgziʾə. Wäśəʾəlä ʾƎgəzʾətənä Maryam bäṢedenəya ləbstä śəga bäʾədä Luqas Wängelawi täśəʾəlät.* (**ወዓዲ ዮሐንስ ፍቁረ [እግዚእ] ሠዐለ ሎቱ ለቄሣር ሥዕለ ስቅለቱ ለእግዚእ ። ወሥዕለ እግዝእትነ ማርያም በጼዴንያ ልብስተ ሥጋ በእደ ሉቃስ ወንጌላዊ ተሥዕለት ።** - "Furthermore, John the beloved of [the Lord] has painted for Caesar the picture of crucifixion of the Lord. And the incarnate icon of Our Lady Mary at Sadanya was painted by the hand of Luke the Evangelist.")

The core argument is that these images are not objects of worship in themselves but are divinely sanctioned aids to faith, reminding believers of God and His saints.

4.2.2 About the Ark of the Covenant (*Tabot*, **ታቦት**)

The defense of the *Tabot* (**ታቦት**) lies at the very heart of Ethiopian Orthodox self-understanding.

- Its origin is divine; *WälläTabotəsä ləlihu ʾƎgziʾənä bäʾədehu mäṭäwo läMuse wäʾazzäzä yəgbär 2tä Kirubä mälᶜəltä Tabot məsmakä laᶜəlä Tabot ḫabä yäḫədr ḫaylä ʾƎgziʾabḫer zäyäḫədr.* (**ወለታቦትሰ ለሊሁ እግዚእነ በእዴሁ መጠዎ ለሙሴ ወአዘዘ ይግበር ፪ቱ ኪሩበ መልዕልተ ታቦት ምስማክ ላዕለ ታቦት ኀበ የኀድር ኀይለ እግዚአብሔር ዘየኀድር ።** - "As for the Tabot, Our Lord himself gave it to Moses with his own hand and ordered him to make two Cherubim on top of the Tabot, a (mercy) seat, where the power of the dwelling God might dwell.")
- The veneration is directed towards God's power, not the object; *Wänəḥnänni kamahu ʾako läśəʾəl zänəsägd wäläʾəṣ wäqäläm ʾəraqu ʾalla nəsägd läḫaylä ʾƎgziʾabḫer zäyäḫədr wəstä śəʾəl wäyənäbər mälᶜəltä Tabot ʾaminänä Qalä Fäṭari zäbotu kʷəllu konä ʾəsmä yibeläna gəbäru litä məśəwaᶜa ʾamləko.* (**ወንሕነኒ ከማሁ አኮ ለሥዕል ዘንሰግድ ወለዕፅ ወቀለም ዕራቁ አላ ንሰግድ ለኀይለ እግዚአብሔር ዘየኀድር ውስተ ሥዕል ወይነብር መልዕልተ ታቦት አሚነ ቃለ ፈጣሪ ዘቦቱ ኵሉ ኮነ እስመ ይቤለነ ግበሩ ሊተ ምሥዋዐ አምልኮ ።** - "Similarly, we, too, do not bow to a picture or (a piece of) wood or to mere pigment, but we bow to the power of God that dwells in the icon and sits on the Tabot, believing the words of the Creator, ‘by whom all things were made,’ for he has said to us, ‘Make for me an altar of worship.’")

- The sanctuary and altar are understood as belonging to God; *Yibe kaʿəbä gəbäru mäqdäsä ʾəsmä mäqdäsəni wämäśwaʿəni ziʾahu wəʾətu.*
  (**ይቤ ካዕበ ግበሩ መቅደሰ እስመ መቅደስኒ ወምሥዋዕኒ ዚአሁ ውእቱ ።** - "He has also said, 'Build a sanctuary;' for sanctuary and altar are his.")
- King David's worship in God's presence is cited; *Dawitəni yibe bäqədmä Mälaʾəktikä ʾəzemmər läkä wäʾəsägd wəstä ṣərḥa Mäqdäsəkä.*
  (**ዳዊትኒ ይቤ በቅድመ መላእክቲከ እዜምር ለከ ወእሰግድ ውስተ ጽርሐ መቅደስከ ።** - "David, too, says, 'I sing to you before your angels and bow down in the hall of your temple.'") (Psalm 138;1-2).
- The apostolic tradition, perhaps referencing the *Synodos* (**ሲኖዶስ**), distinguishes types of altars, suggesting the unique, sanctified, and portable nature of the *Tabot*; *...ʾƎsmä Ṗeṭros yibe bäSinodos wäyəqäddəsu 2tä mäśəwaʿətä 1 zäyəṣäwərwo ʾəmmäkan wəstä mäkan 1 zäʾiyanqäläqəl; läʾəmä ʾanqälqälä məśəwaʿ nähu ʾaʿtätä qəddəsənahu.*
  (…**እስመ ጴጥሮስ ይቤ በሲኖዶስ ወይቀድሱ ፪ቱ መሥዋዕተ ፩ ዘይጸውርዎ እመካን ውስተ መካን ፩ ዘኢያንቀለቅል ፤ ለእመ አንቀልቀለ ምሥዋዕ ናሁ አዕተተ ቅድስናሁ ።** - "...for Peter says in the Synodos, 'Let them sanctify two altars, one which they carry from place to place, and one that does not move. If an (immovable) altar is moved, behold it loses its sanctity.'") This implies the *Tabot* is consecrated for its specific, mobile role as the locus of God's presence in the liturgy.

A significant portion of such texts addresses the objection; if God's power resides in the *Tabot* or icons, why can they be destroyed by enemies?

- The question is posed directly; *Wäläʾəmäbo zäyəbəl wäʾəmäsä ʾƎgziʾə yəhelu wəstä Tabot wäŚəʾəl wäwəstä Betä Krəstiyan läməntə ʾənkä yəwʿəyu bäʾəsat wäyəśeṣəromu maḫəṣe wägʷədəb bäʾədä ʾArämi.*
  (**ወለእመቦ ዘይብል ወእመሰ እግዚእ ይሄሉ ውስተ ታቦት ወሥዕል ወውስተ ቤተ ክርስቲያን ለምንት እንከ ይውዕዩ በእሳት ወይሄዕሮሙ ማኅፌ ወጕድጓ በእደ አረሚ ።** - "If one says, 'If the Lord is present on a Tabot, an icon, and in a church, behold, why are they burned by fire and axe and pickaxe split them by the hands of heathens?'")

The Ethiopian Fathers' response often draws a powerful analogy to the historical destruction of Jerusalem and its Temple. Despite God's explicit promises of His presence there (e.g., Psalm 132;13-14; *ʾƎsmä ḫaräya ʾƎgziʾabḥer läṢəyon wäʾabdära kämä təkuno maḫdəro. Zati yəʾəti məʿrafəyä wämaḫdärəyä*

läʿaläm. Zəyä ʾaḫədr ʾəsmä ḫaräykəwa. **እስመ ኀረያ እግዚአብሔር ለጽዮን ወአብደራ ከመ ትኩኖ ማኅደሮ ። ዛቲ ይእቲ ምዕራፍየ ወማኅደርየ ለዓለም ። ዝየ አኅድር እስመ ኀረይክዋ ።** - "For the Lord has chosen Zion; he has desired it for his habitation. This is my resting place forever; here I will dwell, for I have desired it."), it was nevertheless destroyed due to the sins of the people, as lamented by the prophets (e.g., Psalm 74;7).

- *Rəʾike kämä ʾawʿäyəwa ʿələwan läʾIyyärusalem bäʾəsat wäsäbärəwa bämaḫṣe wäbämäfṣəḥ zäbäʾəntiha yibe Mäṣḥafä Nägäśt wäṣällälä Səbḥatä ʾƎgziʾabḥer ʾəskä śəʾənu Kahənat bäwiʾa.*
  (**ርኢኬ ከመ አውዐይዋ ዕልዋን ለኢየሩሳሌም በእሳት ወሰበርዋ በማኅፄ ወበመፍጽሕ ዘበእንቲሃ ይቤ መጽሐፈ ነገሥት ወጸለለ ስብሐተ እግዚአብሔር እስከ ስእኑ ካህናት በዊአ ።** - "Therefore, see how perverts have burnt Jerusalem with fire and destroyed it with axe and hammer, (the city) about which the Book of Kings has said, 'The glory of God filled (the sanctuary) so much so that the priests were unable to come in.'")

The theological point is that the sanctity and protection of these holy objects are contingent upon God's will and the faithfulness of the community. If God withdraws His active, protective presence (often due to sin), then these items, materially, are just wood or stone.

- *Wäkamahu Tabotəni wäŚəʾəl wäBetä Krəstiyan ʾənzä hallo ḫudur wəstetomu ḫaylä ʾƎgziʾabḥer ʾalbo zäyəkəhlomu... Wäʾəmäsä tägəḫəśä ʾəmnnehomu yək ፍሁማ ፋለ ʾəṣä rəṭubä ʾəraqu wäʾəbnä ṣəmumä...*
  (**ወከማሁ ታቦትኒ ወሥዕል ወቤተ ክርስቲያን እንዘ ሀሎ ኀይሩ ውስቴቶሙ ኀይለ እግዚአብሔር አልቦ ዘይክህሎሙ... ወእመሰ ተግኅሠ እምኔሆሙ ይከውኑ ዕፀ ርጡበ ዕራቁ ወእብነ ጽሙመ...** - "Similarly, nothing...would violate a Tabot, or an icon or a church, as long as the power of God dwells in them. But if it (His power) is removed from them, they become mere green wood, and a sheer stone...")

The example of Moses breaking the first Tablets of the Law (Exodus 32;19) is invoked. God was not angered by the physical destruction of the stone tablets but by the Israelites' idolatry. He then commanded Moses to prepare new tablets, which He would again sanctify.

- *Wäʾitämə^{cc}a ʾƎgziʾabḥer bäʾəntä zäsäbäron wägädäfon ʾalla täfäśśəḥa botu wäʾafəqäro wäyibelo qär 2tä ṣəlätä wäʾəqäddəso läkä kämä qädaməy.*
  (**ወኢተምዕዓ እግዚአብሔር በእንተ ዘሰበሮን ወገደፎን አላ ተፈሥሐ ቦቱ ወአፍቀሮ ወይቤሎ ቀር ፪ተ ጽላተ ወእቀድሶ ለከ ከመ ቀዳሚ ።** - "God was not angry that he broke them and cast them

down. Rather, he was pleased with him (Moses) and loved him. He said to him, ‘Hew two tablets and I will sanctify them for you as before.’")

The conclusion of such arguments is that the physical vulnerability of sacred objects to destruction due to human sin or enemy action does not negate their inherent sanctity or the truth of God's potential presence within them. Faith should not diminish when one sees a *Tabot* or icon from which God's protective power might have been withdrawn due to human transgression, for the divine power itself, when actively present, cannot be overcome by material force.

Chapter Five
5 Ethiopian Orthodox Teaching on Holy Trinity

The doctrine of the Holy Trinity, or *Śəllase* (**ሥላሴ**) in *Ge'ez* (**ግዕዝ**), is absolutely fundamental to Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Christian theology. It's the core understanding of who God is; One God existing in three distinct, co-equal, and co-eternal Persons (*Akalat*, **አካላት**); the Father (*Ab*, **አብ**), the Son (*Wäld*, **ወልድ**), and the Holy Spirit (*Mänfäs Qəddus*, **መንፈስ ቅዱስ**). This isn't just an abstract theological puzzle for our Fathers; it's a revealed mystery that shapes all aspects of faith, worship, and spiritual life.

A beautiful expression of this mystery comes from Abba Giyorgis of Gasəčča (**አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘጋሥጫ**) in his *Mäṣḥafä Məstir* (Book of Mystery, **መጽሐፈ ምሥጢር**);

Bäsəmä ʾƎgziʾabḥer Śəllus zäʾiyətəleyäy ḫəbuʾ zäʾiyətəräʾay məluʾ zäʾiyətənäkäy gundä Haymanot zäʾiyətəwäqqäy mäzgäbä bäräkät wəstä ləbä məʾəmänan zäʾiyətəwäddäy.

(**በስመ እግዚአብሔር ሥሉስ ዘኢይትሌለይ ኀቡዕ ዘኢይትረአይ ምሉዕ ዘኢይትነክይ ጉንደ ሃይማኖት ዘኢይትወቀይ መዝገበ በረከት ውስተ ልበ ምእመናን ዘኢይትወደይ** - "In the name of God, the Trinity that is not separated, hidden that is not seen, full that is not touched, pillar of Faith that is not shaken, treasury of blessing in the heart of believers that is not exhausted.") (Abba Giyorgis, *Mäṣḥafä Məstir*, p. 1 [approximate reference, actual page varies by edition]).

This encapsulates the transcendence and immanence of the Trinity; a divine, indivisible reality, yet intimately present in the hearts of the faithful.

Our Fathers teach that the Trinity is a mystery that ultimately goes beyond full human comprehension. It's a truth revealed by God, not figured out by human reason alone. As another saying goes; *Məśṭir zäyətənäggär lämäḥayəmənan wäʾako läʾi mäḥayəmənan* (**ምሥጢር ዘይትነገር ለመሃይምናን ወአኮ ለኢ መሃይምናን** - "A mystery is spoken to believers, and not to unbelievers"). Faith is the key to approaching this divine reality.

The core formula is often expressed as "Worship the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, three in one and one in three." Each Person is fully God, yet there is only one God. There's no hierarchy of age or power within the Trinity; the Three are One in all essential divine attributes (cf. John 10;30, 1 John 5;7). An ancient liturgical or theological phrase captures this timelessness;

Qädamawi zäʾənbälä təmaləm wämaᶜəkälawi zäʾənbälä yom wädäḫarawi zäʾənbälä gesäm. Bəluyä mäwaᶜəl zäʾənbälä ᶜam näwiḫa ʾäzman zäʾənbälä ʾäkram.

(**ቀዳማዊ ዘእንበለ ትማልም ወማዕከላዊ ዘእንበለ ዮም ወደኃራዊ ዘእንበለ ጌሠም ብሉየ መዋዕል ዘእንበለ**

ዓም ነዊኃ አዝማን ዘእንበለ አክራም ፡ ፡ - "First without yesterday, Medial without today, Last without tomorrow. Ancient of Days without year, Long of Ages without limit.") This speaks to God's eternal nature, beyond our human constructs of time.

They are One in divine nature (*Baḥrəy*, **ባሕርይ**), authority, Lordship, Godhead (*Mäläkot*, **መለኮት**), Divinity, creation, salvation, giving and taking away. The one eternal God is revealed as three co-eternal Persons. The Father is the unbegotten source, the Son is eternally begotten of the Father, and the Holy Spirit eternally proceeds from the Father. This understanding is crucial and distinguishes the Orthodox view from various heresies.

For a deeper dive into the Ethiopian Fathers' teaching on the Holy Trinity, students are encouraged to study works like the *Mäṣḥafä Məstir* (Book of Mystery, **መጽሐፈ ምሥጢር**) by Abba Giyorgis of Gasəčča and the *Rətuʿa Haymanot* (True Faith, **ርቱዐ ሃይማኖት**).

5.1 Beyond Human Understanding; The Mystery of the Holy Trinity

The EOTC consistently teaches that while we can know *that* God is Trinity, *how* God is Trinity is a divine mystery beyond our full grasp. We apprehend it through faith, guided by the teachings of the Apostles;

Nəḥənäsä nəläbbu bäkämä mäharunä Ḥawarəyat bäʾəntä ʾAb wäWäld wäMänfäs Qəddus ʾənzä yəblu; ʾAb yənäggər bäʾəntä Wäldu wəʾətu Iyäsus Krəstos zäWaḥəd lotu; wäWäld yənäggər kämä ʾƎgziʾabḥer ʾAb zäwäläʾdo; wäMänfäs Qəddus yəzenu zäkamä wäṣʾa ʾəm ʾAb...

(ንሕነሰ ንለቡ በከመ መሐሩነ ሐዋርያት በእንተ አብ ወወልድ ወመንፈስ ቅዱስ እንዘ ይብሉ ፤ አብ ይነግር በእንተ ወልዱውእቱ ኢየሱስ ክርስቶስ ዘዋሕድ ሎቱ ፤ ወወልድ ይነግር ከመ እግዚአብሔር አብ ዘወለዶ ፤ ወመንፈስ ቅዱስ ይዜኑ ዘከመ ወጽአ እም አብ.. - "But we understand concerning the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit as the Apostles taught us, saying; The Father speaks concerning His Son, Jesus Christ, His Only-Begotten; and the Son speaks that God the Father begot Him; and the Holy Spirit proclaims how He proceeded from the Father...") (from *Qəddase Śälästu Məʾət*, Anaphora of the Three Hundred, 41 [approximate section]).

The Son is eternally begotten, of the Father's essence (*Baḥrəy*, **ባሕርይ**), co-essential (*homoousios*, ὁμοούσιος) with the Father, as St. Athanasius championed. God is One, yet this unity is a perfect, dynamic communion of three Persons. The Anaphora of St. Mary states; "Three names and one God... three persons and one essence (*Baḥrəy*, **ባሕርይ**)." God is eternally Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. The

Father did not exist for a time *before* begetting the Son; the begetting is an eternal, timeless relation. One Person is not "older" or "younger" than another.

ʾAko kämä ʾAbrəham zäyəlḥəq ʾəm Yəsḥaq wäYəsḥaq zäyəlḥəq ʾəm Yaʿəqob; ʾako kamahu läMäläkot ʾiyəlḥəq ʾAb ʾəm Wäldu wäWäldəni ʾiyəlḥəq ʾəm Mänfäs Qəddus wäMänfäs Qəddusəni ʾiyənʾəs ʾəm Wäld wäWäldəni ʾiyənʾəs ʾəm ʾAbuhu.

(**አኮ ከመ አብርሐም ዘይልሕቅ እም ይስሐቅ ወይስሐቅ ዘይልሕቅ እም ያዕቆብ ፤ አኮ ከማሁ ለመለኮት ኢይልሀቅ አብ እም ወልዱ ወወልድኒ ኢይልሕቅ እም መንፈስ ቅዱስ ወመንፈስ ቅዱስኒ ኢይንእስ እም ወልድ ወወልድኒ ኢይንእስ እም አቡሁ ፡ ፡** - "It is not like Abraham who is older than Isaac, and Isaac who is older than Jacob; it is not so for the Godhead. The Father is not older than His Son, nor is the Son older than the Holy Spirit, nor is the Holy Spirit younger than the Son, nor is the Son younger than His Father.")

God is the only eternally existing Being; *ʾAlbo ṭənt läḥəllawihu wäʾalbo maḫəläqt läkəwanihu ʾalbo ḫʷəläq lämäwaʿəlihu; wäʾalbo hassab läʿamätatihu* (**አልቦ ጥንት ለህላዌሁ ወአልቦ ማኅለቅት ለክዋኔሁ አልቦ ኍልቅ ለመዋዕሊሁ ፤ ወአልቦ ሀሳብ ለዓመታቲሁ** - "He has no beginning to His existence and no end to His being, no number for His days, and no counting for His years").

The term Trinity denotes the one God who is Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. They are one in nature (*Baḥrəy*, **ባሕርይ**), essence (*Həllawe*, **ህላዌ**), divinity (*Mäläkot*, **መለኮት**), and will, yet three in name and Person (*Akal*, **አካል**). The Father begets, the Son is begotten, the Holy Spirit proceeds – these are their distinguishing personal properties, yet they do not divide the divine essence. As the *Haymanotä Abäw* (Faith of the Fathers, **ሃይማኖተ አበው**), quoting St. Ignatius, states; *ʾAb Wäldən Mänfäs Qəddusən wädä mähon ʾayəläwwäṭəm...* (**አብ ወልድን መንፈስ ቅዱስን ወደ መሆን አይለወጥም ፤**... - "The Father does not change into becoming the Son or Holy Spirit..." etc.) (Haymanotä Abäw, St. Ignatius, Ch. 11, Pt. 1, No. 5 [varies by edition]). God is three Persons, one essence.

5.2 Holy Trinity in Holy Bible

The Ethiopian Fathers, like all Orthodox Fathers, ground their understanding of the Trinity firmly in Holy Scripture. St. Cyril is quoted as saying; *LäTəmhərt Qəddusat Mäṣaḥəft gəmura ʾalbo zäyəṣṣägəbo...* (**ቄርሎስ ይቤ ለትምህርት ቅዱሳት መጻሕፍት ግሙራ አልቦ ዘይጸግቦ**… - "Concerning the teaching of the Holy Scriptures, no one can fully exhaust them...") (Discourse of Cyril, p. 34 [source needed for precise citation]). And Severus of Esmunain; *ʾƎsmä Mäṣḥaf Qəddus Qalä ʾƎgziʾabḥer Fäṭari*

wäwəʾətu kəbur wäyäʿabi ʾəmləb zäfəṭur (**እስመ መጽሐፍ ቅዱስ ቃለ እግዚአብሔር ፈጣሪ ወውእቱ ክቡር ወየዐቢ እምልብ ዘፍጡር** - "For Holy Scripture is the Word of God the Creator, and it is honored and greater than the heart of a creature.") (Severus of Esmunain, Discourse, p. 5 [source needed]).
Indications of plurality within the one Godhead are seen in the Old Testament;

- "Let **Us** create man in **Our** likeness, in **Our** image." (Genesis 1;26)
- "And the Lord God said, Behold, Adam is become as one of **us**..." (Genesis 3;22)
- "Come, let **Us** go down and there confuse their language..." (Genesis 11;6-7)
  The plural "Us" suggests multiple persons, while "the Lord said" affirms one God.
  The appearance of the three "men" to Abraham is also understood as a manifestation of the Trinity (Genesis 18;1-3). Abraham saw three, but addressed them as "My Lord" (*ʾƎgziʾo*, **እግዚኦ**), recognizing the one Godhead.

The New Testament provides clearer revelation;

- The baptismal formula; "Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit." (Matthew 28;19). St. Ambrose noted "in the *name*" (singular) because God is One.
- The apostolic blessing; "The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, and the love of God, and the communion of the Holy Spirit be with you all. Amen." (2 Corinthians 13;14)
- The Johannine Comma (though its textual history is complex, it reflects established Trinitarian belief); "For there are three that bear witness in heaven: the Father, the Word, and the Holy Spirit, and these three are one." (1 John 5;7)
  The Theophany at Christ's baptism (Matthew 3;16-17) is a key New Testament manifestation; the Son is baptized, the Spirit descends like a dove, and the Father's voice is heard from heaven.

5.3 Revision of Trinity on the Bible

"For your own study, review these scriptural passages and consider how they contribute to the Church's understanding of the Holy Trinity. Look for hints of plurality in the Old Testament, such as in the creation accounts (Genesis 1), the Psalms (e.g., Psalm 33;6, Psalm 110;1), and prophetic writings (e.g., Isaiah 6;3, Isaiah 48;16). Then, examine the clearer New Testament revelations, particularly in the Gospels (e.g., John 1;1, John 14;16-17, 26, John 15;26) and the Epistles (e.g., Ephesians 2;18, Titus 3;4-6, 1 Peter 1;2). Note how the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are distinct yet work in unity."

5.4 Understanding the Mystery of Holy Trinity

While a full grasp is beyond us, key aspects of the Trinity can be understood through faith;

- **One God, Three Persons**; The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are distinct Persons (*Akalat*, **አካላት**), yet share one divine nature (*Baḥrəy*, **ባሕርይ**). *Nətəʾamän bäŚälästu ʾAkalat wäŚälästu Gäṣṣat ʾəntä ʾAḥadu Baḥrəyä Mäläkot* (**ንትአመን በሠለስቱ አካላት ወሠለስቱ ገጻት እንተ አሐዱ ባሕርየ መለኮት** - "We believe in three Persons and three Countenances, which have one divine nature.") (John of Antioch, *Ank., Ch. 1, No. 6* [Source reference would be to an Ethiopian collection like *Haymanotä Abäw*]).
- **Co-equality and Co-eternality**; Each Person is fully God, without beginning or end, equal in honor and glory. *Nəbəl ʾAb ḥəywät Wäld ḥəywät Mänfäs Qəddus ḥəywät ʾənzä ʾAḥadu ḥəywät bäḥəllawä Mäläkot* (**ንብል አብ ሕይወት ወልድ ሕይወት መንፈስ ቅዱስ ሕይወት እንዘ አሐዱ ሕይወት በሕላዌ መለኮት** - "We say the Father is Life, the Son is Life, the Holy Spirit is Life, while being one Life in the existence of the Godhead.") (John of Antioch, *Ank., Ch. 2, No. 5* [Again, specific Ethiopian source needed]).
- **Unique Roles (Divine Economy)**; While inseparable in their divine action, each Person has a distinct role in relation to creation and salvation. The Father is the Source, the Son is the Redeemer, the Holy Spirit is the Sanctifier. *ʾAʾammən wäʾətəʾamän kämä ʾAb ləbb; wäWäld Qal; wäMänfäs Qəddus ḥəywät wəʾətu* (**አአምን ወእትአመን ከመ አብ ልብ ፤ ወወልድ ቃል ፣ ወመንፈስ ቅዱስ ሕይወት ውእቱ** - "I believe and I am certain that the Father is Heart, the Son is Word, and the Holy Spirit is Life.") (From *Mäzgäbä Haymanot*, Treasury of Faith, p. 34, no. 13, attributed to Jacob of Elberdei [Serugh] [Precise citation needed]). This assigns attributes; Father as source of love/will, Son as revealer/wisdom, Spirit as perfecter/life-giver.

5.5 The teaching of Trinity and Ethiopian Orthodox Church Life

The doctrine of the Trinity isn't just for theologians; it pervades the life of the EOTC.

- **Worship and Prayer**; The Divine Liturgy (*Qəddase*, **ቅዳሴ**) is profoundly Trinitarian. We pray to the Father, through the Son, in the Holy Spirit. A common doxology is; *Halle luya Halle luya Halle luya. Nəsəgd läʾAbä Bərhanat wäläWäldu Waḥəd wäläMänfäs Qəddus Ṗaraqliṭos Śəllus ʿəruy* (**ሃሌ ሉ.ያ ሃሌ ሉ.ያ ሃሌ ሉ.ያ ንስግድ ለአበ ብርሃናት ወለወልዱ ዋሕድ ወለ መንፈስ ቅዱስ**

ጸራቅሊጦስ ሥሉስ ዕሩይ - "Hallelujah, Hallelujah, Hallelujah. Let us worship the Father of Lights, and His Only-begotten Son, and the Holy Spirit, the Paraclete, the equal Trinity.")

- Sacraments (*Məśṭirat*, **ምሥጢራት**); Baptism, for example, is administered in the name of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, as Christ commanded (Matthew 28;19). The blessing often includes; *Buruk ʾƎgziʾabḥer ʾAb ʾAḫazu kʷəllu ʿaläm ʾAmlakənä wäBuruk Wäld Waḥəd Iyäsus Krəstos… wäBuruk Mänfäs Qəddus Ṗaraqliṭos…* (**ቡሩክ እግዚአብሔር አብ አሐዙ ኵሉ ዓለም አምላክነ ወቡሩክ ወልድ ዋሕድ ኢየሱስ ክርስቶስ …… ወቡሩክ መንፈስ ቅዱስ ጸራቅሊጦስ ……** - "Blessed is God the Father, Ruler of all the world, our God, and blessed is the Only-begotten Son Jesus Christ… and blessed is the Holy Spirit the Paraclete…").
- Daily Life; The Trinity guides and empowers believers. The sign of the cross, made in the name of the Trinity, sanctifies daily actions.
- Icons (*Śəʾəlat*, **ሥዕላት**); Icons, like the famous "Hospitality of Abraham," depict the Trinity, visually teaching the faith.

  The Trinity is a lived reality, a source of comfort, hope, and divine love. An old teaching states; *ʾAʾəmər O bəʾəsi Krəstiyanawi zäntä nägärä məśṭirä Śəllase. ʾAbəhi ʾikonä śällästä; (wä) Wäldəhi ʾikonä śällästä; (wä) Mänfäs Qəddusəhi ʾikonä śällästä; bäkämä mäharunä Ḥawarəyat ʾAbäwinä bäSinodosomu.* (**አእምር ኦ ብእሲ ክርስቲያናዊ ዘንተ ነገረ ምሥጢረ ሥላሴ ፡ ፡ አብሂ ኢኮነ ሠለስተ ፤ (ወ) ወልድሂ ኢኮነ ሠለስተ ፤ (ወ) መንፈስቅዱስሂ ኢኮነ ሠለስተ ፤ በከመ መሀሩነ ሐዋርያት አበዊነ በሲኖዶሶሙ ፡ ፡** - "Know, O Christian man, this matter of the mystery of the Trinity. The Father is not three; and the Son is not three; and the Holy Spirit is not three; as our Fathers the Apostles taught us in their Synodos.") (*Mäṣḥafä Məʿlad*, Book of Order/Nativity, 1962 E.C. [This likely refers to a specific print edition, the work itself is older]).

5.6 Main Heretical teaching on Holy Trinity

Throughout history, the Church has had to defend the true doctrine of the Trinity against various misunderstandings or heresies. The Ethiopian Fathers inherited and upheld these defenses.

- Arianism; Taught by Arius (4th century), denied Christ's full divinity, claiming the Son was a created being, "there was a time when He was not." This was condemned at the Council of Nicaea (325 AD).

- **Apollinarianism**; Taught by Apollinaris of Laodicea (+390), denied Christ's full humanity, suggesting the Divine Logos took the place of the human soul/mind in Jesus. Condemned for compromising Christ's complete human nature.
- **Nestorianism**; Associated with Nestorius (5th century), taught a separation between Christ's divine and human natures, almost implying two persons. Condemned at the Council of Ephesus (431 AD).
- **Adoptionism**; The view that Jesus was a mere human who was "adopted" by God as Son, usually at his baptism or resurrection.
- **Modalism (Sabellianism)**; Taught by Sabellius (3rd century), denied the real distinctions between the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, suggesting they were just different "modes" or "faces" of the one God appearing at different times (Father in OT, Son in Gospels, Spirit in Church).
- **Tritheism**; The belief in three separate gods, overemphasizing the distinctness of the Persons at the expense of the one divine essence.

Other subtle distinctions that were debated include terms describing the Son's relationship to the Father;

1. *Anomoios* (ἀνόμοιος) - "unlike" in essence (Arian/Eunomian).
2. *Homoousios* (ὁμοούσιος) - "of the same essence" (Orthodox/Nicene).
3. *Homoiousios* (ὁμοιούσιος) - "of similar essence" (Semi-Arian).
4. Sabellianism – one substance, different modes.
5. Homoousian – distinct Persons, identical substance.
6. Homoiousian – distinct Persons, similar substance.
7. Homoianism – generally "like" the Father, avoiding substance language.
8. Neo-Arianism or Heteroousians – "unlike in substance."

The Orthodox Church, in response, firmly teaches "One God, one essence (*Baḥrəy*, **ባሕርይ**) in three Persons/Hypostases (*Akalat*, **አካላት**)." Errors often arose from trying to explain this divine mystery using purely human reason or philosophy, rather than accepting God's self-revelation. The Trinity is more for prayerful contemplation than for exhaustive logical dissection.

5.7 The Ethiopian Fathers Answer for Heretical teaching

Our Fathers consistently refuted these heresies, affirming the orthodox understanding.

- For example, concerning Photinus (often conflated or seen as similar to Arius or Sabellius in some patristic polemics), Arius, and Sabellius, one Ethiopian source notes; *LäFoṭonos wäläʾArəyos wäläSäbəlianos ʾaḥatti fətəwätä ḥəllinahomu... yətənnaṣṣäru läʾaʾəkəyo həllawihu wäläʾaṣṣo kəwanihu läWäld ʾəmʾAb.*
  (**ለፎጦኖስ ወለአርዮስ ወለሰብልያኖስ አሐቲ ፍትወተ ሕሊናሆሙ… በዓይነ ልቦሙሰ ይትናጸሩ ለአእክዮ ህላዌሁ ወለአፅያ ክዋኔሁ ለወልድ እምአብ** - "For Photinus and for Arius and for Sabellius, the desire of their mind is one... in the eye of their heart they contend to diminish His (the Son's) existence and to belittle His being from the Father.") (Mäməhər [Teacher/Commentary], p. 77 [Specific source needed]).
  - Photinus was seen as teaching the Son's being began with Mary; *...kəwanihu läWäld yəmäləd mägäññät käMaryam wädih näw alä* (...**የመልድ መገኘት ከማርያም ወዲህ ነው አለ** - "...the Son's being/generation is after Mary, he said") (Mäməhər, p. 78). Orthodox response; the Son is co-eternal, Mary is *Theotokos* (God-bearer), not the origin of His divine being.
  - Arius stated Christ born of Mary is a creature; *ʾArəyos yibe fəṭur wəʾətu Krəstos wəʾətu zätäwäldä ʾəMaryam* (**አርዮስ ይቤ ፍጡር ውእቱ ክርስቶስ ውእቱ ዘተወልደ እማርያም** - "Arius said, 'Christ who was born of Mary is a creature.'") (Mäməhər, p. 77). Orthodox response; Christ is fully God, co-eternal, not created.
  - Sabellius used human analogies inappropriately; *Säbəlianos yibe ʾAb kämä bəʾəsi Wäld kämä nəbabä ləssanu wäMänfäs Qəddus kämä ʾəsətnəfasä ʾAfuhu wäbäʾəntäz yibe ʾAḥadu Gäṣṣ.* (**ሰልብያኖስ ይቤ አብ ከመ ብእሲ ወልድ ከመ ንባበ ልሳኑ ወመንፈስ ቅዱስ ከመ እስትንፋሰ አፉሁ ወበእንተዝ ይቤ አሐዱ ገጽ ፡ ፡** - "Sabellius said, 'The Father is like a man, the Son like the speech of his tongue, and the Holy Spirit like the breath of his mouth, and therefore he said One Countenance/Person.'") (Mäməhər, p. 77). Orthodox response; the Persons are distinct, not mere modes.

5.7.1 For tritheism

The Fathers stressed God is one in essence, though three in Person.

- *Śällästu səm ʾAḥadu ʾƎgziʾabḥer* (**ሠለስቱ ስም አሐዱ እግዚአብሔር** - "Three names, one God.") (Qəddase Maryam, Anaphora of Mary, 54).

- *ʾAbəni bämälku bägäṣu bäʾakalu fəṣṣum wəʾətu; Wäldəni bämälku bäʾakalu bägäṣu fəṣṣum wəʾətu; Mänfäs Qəddusəni bämälku bägäṣu bäʾakalu fəṣṣum wəʾətu.* (**አብኒ በመልኩ በገጹ በአካሉ ፍጹም ውእቱ ፤ ወልድኒ በመልኩ በአካሉ በገጹ ፍጹም ውእቱ ፤ መንፈስ ቅዱስኒ በመልኩ በገጹ በአካሉ ፍጹም ውእቱ ፡ ፡** - "The Father in His image, His countenance, His Person is perfect; the Son in His image, His Person, His countenance is perfect; the Holy Spirit in His image, His countenance, His Person is perfect.") (Haymanotä Abäw, Gregory of Nazianzus, Ch. 60, Pt. 1, No. 2).
- *Wäʾinəsägd läŚällästu ʾAmaləkt ʾalla ʾAḥadu ʾAmlak* (**ወኢንሰግድ ለሠለስቱ አማልክት አላ አሐዱ አምላክ** - "And we do not worship three Gods, but one God.") (Gregory the Theologian, Ch. 1, No. 5).
- *ʾAḥadu həllawe dibä ʾAḥadu mänbär ʾənzä ʾiyətkäffäl; ʾAḥatti ṭəbäb, wäʾAḥatti məkər; ʾAḥatti Mängəśt wäʾAḥatti Śəlṭan, ʾAḥadu Mäläkot wäʾAḥadu Śəlṭan...* (**አሐዱ ህላዌ ዲበ አሐዱ መንበር እንዘ ኢይትከፈል ፤ አሐቲ ጥበብ ፣ ወአሐቲ ምክር ፤ አሐቲ መንግሥት ወአሐቲ ሥልጣን ፣ አሐዱ መለኮት ወአሐዱ ሥልጣን**….. - "One existence upon one throne, while not being divided; One wisdom, and One counsel; One Kingdom and One Authority, One Godhead and One Authority...") (*Mäzgäbä Haymanot*, Treasury of Faith, 4).

5.7.2 For Arian Heresy (See also 5.7)

The co-eternity and co-equality of the Son with the Father were strongly defended.

- *ʾAlbo ʾamä ʾihallo ʾalbo zägäbrä ʾAb baḥtitu zäʾənbälä Wäld* (**አልቦ አመ ኢሀሎ አልቦ ዘገብረ አብ ባሕቲቱ ዘእንበለ ወልድ** - "There was no time He (the Son) was not; there is nothing the Father did alone without the Son.") (*Mäzgäbä Haymanot*, 2,4).
- *Wälädo ʾAb läWäldu ʾiyətbähal zä gize wäbä zäkämäz mäwaʿəl wälädo* (**ወለዶ አብ ለወልዱ ኢይትበሀል ዘ ጊዜ ወበ ዘከመዝ መዋዕል ወለዶ** - "The Father's begetting of His Son is not said to be of time or 'in such and such days He begot Him.'") (From *Qəddase Śälästu Məʾət*, Anaphora of the Three Hundred, 24).

5.7.3 For Nestorius

Nestorius was seen as dividing Christ into two persons. Ethiopian Fathers affirmed the one Person of the Incarnate Word.

- A critique of Nestorius; *Nəsṭoros yibe… sobä tärakäbo Wäldä ʾƎgziʾabḥer bäwəstä Yordanos konä ʾAmlakä bäṣägga.* (**ንስጥሮስ ይቤ …. ሶበ ተራክቦ ወልደ እግዚአብሔር በውስተ ዮርዳኖስ ኮነ አምላክ በጸጋ** - "Nestorius said… when the Son of God met him in the Jordan, he became God by grace.")
- The Orthodox response; *Nəḥənäsä nəbəl ʾAmlak wəʾətu ʾəmqədmä ʿaläm wäʾəskäläʿaläm.* (**ንሕነሰ ንብል አምላክ ውእቱ እምቅድመ ዓለም ወእስከለዓለም** - "But we say, He is God from before the world and unto eternity.")

5.7.4 For Appolinarius (Apollinarianism)

Apollinaris denied the completeness of Christ's human soul/mind.

- *Kaʿəbä ʾAburəyos yibe ʾalbotu ləbb wänäfs lätəsəbʾət Krəstos wäMäläkotu kono həyäntä ləbb wänäfs.* (**ካዕበ አቡርዮስ ይቤ አልቦቱ ልብ ወነፍስ ለትስብእት ክርስቶስ ወመለኮቱ ኮኖ ህየንተ ልብ ወነፍስ** - "Again Apollinaris said, Christ's humanity has no heart (mind) and soul, and His Godhead became for it in place of heart and soul.")
- The Orthodox response; *Nəḥənäsä nəbəl botu näfsä śäbʾawi, wäbotu ləbbuna ṭäbayʾawi, wäkaʿəbä botu ʿəbəyä Mäläkotawi.* (**ንህነሰ ንብል ቦቱ ነፍስ ሰብአዊ ፣ ወቦቱ ልቡና ጠባይአዊ ፣ ወካዕበ ቦቱ ዕበየ መለኮታዊ** - "But we say, He has a human soul, and He has a natural mind, and again He has divine greatness.")
- Abba Giyorgis challenges him directly; *O ʾAborəyos ʾəfo təkəfəlo läzä ʾiyətkäffäl wäʾəfo təleləyo läzäʾiyətleläy.* (**ኦ አቦርዮስ እፎ ትከፍሎ ለዘ ኢይትከፈል ወእፎ ትሌሊዮ ለዘኢይትሌለይ** - "O Apollinaris, how do you divide the indivisible, and how do you separate the inseparable?") (Abba Giyorgis of Gasəççça, *Mäṣḥafä Məstir*, p. 10).

5.7.5 For Sebbalianism (Sabellianism)

Sabellius taught one Person with three modes.

- *Säbəlianos yibe ʾAb wäWäld wäMänfäs Qəddus ʾAḥadu Gäṣṣ; Nəḥənäsä nəbəl Śällästu Gäṣṣ wäʾAḥadu Raʾəy.* (**ሰልጠያኖስ ይቤ አብ ወወልድ ወመንፈስ ቅዱስ አሐዱ ገጽ ፤ ንሕነሰ ንብል ሠለስቱ ገጽ ወአሐዱ ራዕይ** - "Sabellius said the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are one Person/Countenance; but we say three Persons/Countenances and one Vision/Appearance (of Godhead).")

- Theodosius of Alexandria in *Haymanotä Abäw*; *Wäʾi ʾəbəl ʾAḥadä ʾAkalä ʾəmnätä ʾAyəhudawi wäSäbaləyosawi.* (**ወኢ እብል አሐደ አካለ እምነተ አይሁዳዊ ወሰባልዮሳዊ** - "And I do not say one Person, the belief of the Jew and the Sabellian.") (Theodosius of Alexandria, *Haymanotä Abäw*, p. 466, Pt. 1, No. 8 [Edition specific]).
- Shenoute, Patriarch of Alexandria; *Wänawäggəz Säbaləyosəha räsiʿa zäyəwäṣəʾ ʾəm ṣədəq bäbəhilotu Śällästu ʾAsmat baḥtitomu ʾəntä zäʾAḥadu ʾAkal.* (**ወናወግዝ ሰባልዮስሃ ረሲዐ ዘይወጽእ እም ጽድቅ በብሂሎቱ ሠለስቱ አስማት ባሕቲቶሙ እንተ ዘአሐዱ አካል** - "And we anathematize the wicked Sabellius who departs from righteousness by his saying Three Names only for one Person.") (Shenoute, Patriarch of Alexandria, Pt. 1, No. 11 [Edition specific, from a collection like *Haymanotä Abäw*]).
- *Mäṣḥafä Məstir*; *Wäzäsä yəmehhər ʾAḥadä Gäṣṣä ʾiṭəmuq wäʾiqəbuʿ wäʾi Krəstun wəʾətu.* (**ወዘሰ ይሜህር አሐደ ገጸ ኢ ጥሙቅ ወኢ ቅቡዕ ወኢ ክርስቱን ውእቱ** - "And he who teaches one Person/Countenance is not baptized, nor anointed, nor a Christian.") (*Mäṣḥafä Məstir*, p. 8).

5.8 The Ethiopian Orthodox Church fathers in ancient Church fathers mind

The Ethiopian Fathers saw themselves in continuity with the broader stream of orthodox patristic thought, especially the Alexandrian tradition and the Cappadocians.

5.8.1 Early Church Fathers

Figures like Irenaeus of Lyons, Tertullian, and Origen of Alexandria laid early groundwork in Trinitarian articulation against Gnosticism and Modalism, emphasizing God's unity and the distinctness of the Persons. Their insights were foundational.

5.8.2 Cappadocian Fathers

The Cappadocians were particularly influential in refining Trinitarian language.

- St. Basil the Great; His work was crucial in distinguishing *ousia* (essence) from *hypostasis* (person). A prayer attributed or related to him might say; *ʿƏqäb litä ʾAkalatä bätäwaḥədo* (**ዕቀብ ሊተ አካላተ በተዋሕዶ** - "Preserve for me the Persons in union/distinction"). This means "Preserve for me the understanding of the Persons as they exist distinctly yet in union."

- St. Yared in his *Dəggʷa* (**ድጓ** - Collection of Hymns) for the season of flowers (*Zämänä Ṣəge*, **ዘመነ ጽጌ**), speaks of the Trinity metaphorically; *Bäʾəntä Śəllus təṭəgämmäd wəṭafäri län ʾäskalä bäräkät* (**በእንተ ሥሉስ ትትገመድ ወታፈሪ ለነ አስካለ በረከት** - "Concerning the Trinity, it is woven and bears for us clusters of blessing."). This image of a three-stranded cord (*fəṭl śəllus*) is also used by Abba Giyorgis of Gasəčča; *Fəṭl Śəllus zäʾiyəṭbäṭäk... ʾəsmä ṣənʿa Mäläkot zäʾAb wäWäld wäMänfäs Qəddus ʾəḫuz bäṣəmərät.* (**ፈትል ሥሉስ ዘኢይትበጥክ… እስመ ፅንዐ መለኮት ዘአብ ወወልድ ወመንፈስ ቅዱስ እጉዝ በፅምረት** - "A three-ply cord which is not broken... for the strength of the Godhead of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit is held in unity.") (*Mäṣḥafä Məstir*, p. 42).
- St. Gregory of Nyssa; Explored the mystery deeply. A sentiment reflecting his thought; *ʾAsmä ʾihallo ḥəllina laʿəlä ʾAb zäʾihallo ḥəllina laʿəlä Wäld; wäʾihallo ḥəllina laʿəlä Wäld zäʾihallo ḥəllina laʿəlä Mänfäs Qəddus ʾəsmä ʾAḥadä yəḥeləyu wäʾAḥadu Mäläkotomu.* (**አስመ ኢሀሎ ሕሊና ላዕለ አብ ዘኢሀሎ ሕሊና ላዕለ ወልድ ፤ ወኢሀሎ ሕሊና ላዕለ ወልድ ዘኢሀሎ ሕሊና ላዕለ መንፈስ ቅዱስ አስመ አሐደ ይሔልዩ ወአሐዱ መለኮቶሙ** - "For there is no thought concerning the Father that is not a thought concerning the Son; and there is no thought concerning the Son that is not a thought concerning the Holy Spirit, for they think One and their Godhead is One.") (*Mäṣḥafä Məstir*, p. 47, reflecting a common patristic idea).
- St. Gregory of Nazianzus (the Theologian); Defended the Trinity powerfully. He warns; *Wäʾiyəṭəhabälu ḫəgulan yabəʾu wəstä Qəddəst Śəllase fəlṭätä Mäläkot wäʾidəmare ʾAkalat.* (**ወኢይትሀበሉ ኀጉላን ያብኡ ውስተ ቅድስት ሥላሴ ፍልጠተ መለኮት ወኢ ድማሬ አካላት** - "And let not the lost dare to introduce into the Holy Trinity a division of Godhead or a confusion of Persons.") (Gregory, Ch. 1, No. 5 [source needed]).

  St. Athanasius of Alexandria, though earlier than the Cappadocians, was the great champion against Arianism, and his defense of the Son's divinity and the term *homoousios* is foundational for all Orthodox understanding of the Trinity, including the Ethiopian.

Chapter Six
6 Christology of Ethiopian Fathers

The heart of Ethiopian Orthodox theology beats with a profound understanding of Jesus Christ – His person, His nature, and His saving work. This is what we call Christology (*Nägärä Krəstos*, **ነገረ ክርስቶስ**). The Ethiopian Fathers, deeply rooted in the Alexandrian tradition and the teachings of figures like St. Cyril, developed and preserved a Christology centered on the perfect and indivisible union of divinity and humanity in the one Person of the Incarnate Word. This is famously encapsulated in the term *Tewahedo* (**ተዋሕዶ** - "made one," "unified").

6.1 Christology a special emphasis on Saint Yared's teaching

While many Ethiopian Fathers contributed to Christological understanding, Saint Yared (**ቅዱስ ያሬድ**), the 6th-century Aksumite scholar and composer, holds a unique place. Though renowned primarily for his divinely inspired liturgical music and hymns (*Zema*, **ዜማ**), these compositions are not merely beautiful melodies; they are deeply theological. St. Yared's hymns are a primary indigenous source for understanding Ethiopian Christology, expressing complex doctrines in poetic and worshipful language. His work constantly emphasizes the *Tewahedo* – the one, united divine-human nature of Christ, His eternal pre-existence with the Father, and the reality of His Incarnation for our salvation.

A powerful encapsulating phrase often attributed to the spirit of St. Yared's understanding of the Incarnation and its effect is;

Wärädä Sämayawi, wätäsäbḥa Meretawi.

(**ወረደ ሰማያዊ ፥ ወተሰብሐ መሬታዊ ።** - "The Heavenly descended, and the earthly became exalted/glorified.")

This simple yet profound statement captures the essence of the salvific exchange that occurred in Christ.

6.1.1 His Works and Christology

St. Yared's major literary and musical works are the foundation of the EOTC's liturgical chant. These include;

- ***Dəggʷa*** (**ድጓ**): The main collection of hymns for the entire church year, covering feasts, fasts, and Sundays.
- ***Ṣomä Dəggʷa*** (**ጾመ ድጓ**): Hymns specifically for the Great Fast (Lent).

- *Məʿəraf* (ምዕራፍ): Chants for daily prayer, Sabbath, and important feasts.
- *Zəmmare* (ዝማሬ): Chantal responses sung after the Holy Communion (*Qurban*, ቁርባን).
- *Mäwasəʾət* (መዋስዕት): Chants for funeral services and commemorations of the dead.

Within these, St. Yared developed a sophisticated system of musical notation using signs (*məlkkətočč*, ምልክቶች) to indicate melody, rhythm, and vocal inflection. Some of these signs themselves carry theological weight, often alluding to aspects of Christ's life and passion. For example, terms associated with his notation system, as later explained by commentators, are sometimes linked symbolically (though this is more in the tradition of interpretation than inherent in the signs themselves);

1. *Dəfat* (ድፋት) - "humble descent," linked to the Incarnation.
2. *Ḥidät* (ሐዲት) - "procession/ministry," linked to Christ's public life.
3. *Qənat* (ቅናት) - "zeal/conspiracy," linked to the opposition He faced.
4. *Yəzät* (ይዘት) - "holding/betrayal," linked to His arrest.
5. *Qurṭ* (ቁርጥ) - "cut/ordained plan," linked to the divine plan of salvation through suffering.
6. *Čärät* (ጭረት) - "scratch/bruise," linked to His scourging.
7. *Rəkərk* (ርክርክ) - "pouring/sprinkling," linked to the shedding of His precious blood.
8. *Därät* (ደረት) - "exaltation/ascension," linked to His glorious ascension.
   (Interpretation based on commentators like Andəʿalem Dagəmawi, as cited in Hable Selassie, 1969, pp. 172-173, though direct Yaredian attribution of these meanings to the signs is complex).

6.1.2 Hymn and Christology

St. Yared's hymns are rich Christological statements.

- Union of Natures (*Tewahedo*): His poetry beautifully articulates the mystery of the Incarnation. For instance, regarding the Eucharist, a hymn in the *Dəggʷa* might express the indivisible unity; *Dämmäränä nähalu, məslä kʷəllomu qəddusanikä. Dämmäränä nähalu, qədmä gäṣṣəkä, bäsəbḥat. Kämä zəntu ṣəwwaʿa wäyn, zätusuḥ dämkä wəstetu, ʾalbo zäyəkəl lelilləyoto, ʾəḥədu wəʾətu Mäläkotu.*
  (ደምረነ ነሀሉ ፥ ምስለ ኵሉሙ ቅዱሳኒከ ። ደምረነ ነሀሉ ፥ ቅድመ ገጽከ ፥ በስብሐት ። ከመ ዝንቱ ጽዋዓ ወይን ፥ ዘቱሶሕ ደምከ ውስቴቱ ፥ አልቦ ዘይክል ሌልዮቶ ፥ ፩ዱ ውእቱ መለኮቱ ። - "Unite us to be with all Your saints. Unite us to be before Your face in glory. As this cup of wine, in which Your blood is mingled, none can separate its unity, for His Divinity is one.") (St.

Yared, *Dəggʷa*, BD127 [Approximate reference]). This emphasizes the indivisible divinity present in the Eucharist, reflecting the indivisible union in Christ Himself.

- **Eternal Pre-existence and Divine Origin**: St. Yared clearly teaches Christ's eternal being and His unique divine sonship. A profound line states; *ʾIḫaśśäśä ʾAbä, bädibä mədər, wäʾiʾəmmä bäsämayat.*
  (**ኢኃሠሠ አበ ፥ በዲበ ምድር ፥ ወኢእመ በሰማያት ።** - "He sought neither a father on earth, nor a mother in heaven.") This powerfully asserts Christ's unique origin, not bound by earthly parentage for His divine nature, nor needing a heavenly "mother" as He is eternally the Son of the Father. It affirms His pre-existence and divine self-sufficiency.
- **Incarnation as God's Act**: The Word became flesh; this is a constant theme. *Wäld śəga konä.* (**ቃል ሥጋ ኮነ** - "The Word became flesh.") He connects Old Testament prophecies to Christ, for instance, interpreting Isaiah's vision of the Lord riding on a "swift cloud" into Egypt (Isaiah 19;1) as the Virgin Mary carrying the infant Emmanuel; *Bäkämä yibe Isayyas Näbiy nahu yəwärəd ʾƎgziʾabḥer wəstä Gəbṣ täṣʿino dibä dämäna qälil. Dämänasä zäyibe yəʾətike Dəngəl zäḥazälätto bäzäbana läʾAmmanuʾel.*
  (**በከመ ይቤ ኢሳይያስ ነቢይ ናሁ ይወርድ እግዚአብሔር ውስተ ግብጽ ተፅዒኖ ዲበ ደመና ቀሊል ደመናሰ ዘይቤ ይእቲኬ ድንግል ዘሐዘለቶ በዘባና ለአማኑኤል** - "As Isaiah the prophet said, 'Behold, the LORD is riding on a swift cloud and comes to Egypt.' The cloud is the Virgin that carried Emmanuel on her back.") (St. Yared, *Dəggʷa*, BD, 327).
- **Christ as True God and True Man**: The hymns affirm both Christ's full divinity and His true humanity, without confusing them. He is the "Heavenly One" baptized by the "earthly" John, yet He is also the one who "was born from the hidden to the revealed."

6.2 Salivation according to Saint Yared

For St. Yared, Christology is inseparable from Soteriology (the doctrine of salvation, *Nägärä Mədḫan*, **ነገረ ምድኀን**). Christ's person and work are entirely for our salvation. His hymns trace this saving work from the fall of humanity to Christ's ultimate victory.

A comprehensive passage from his *Dəggʷa* illustrates this;

Wäsobä rəʾəyä ʾƎgziʾabḥer, kämä yətəḫagʷäl ʿaläm, bämaʿəśärä ḫaṭiʾat, fännäwo läBäkʷəru wəstä ʿaläm zäyafäqər... Ḫabiʾo Mäläkoto... wäwärädä ḫabenä, wäläbsä śəga śäbʾ mäwati; ʾəsmä bäʾəntä Adam,

täfäṭrä mot wəstä ʿaläm, bägʷəḥəlutu läSäyṭan... Wäbäyəʾəti śəga, täsäqlä Krəstos dibä ʾəṣä Mäsqäl, kämä yəśʿar gəbro läMälʾakä mot, kämä yəqäddəsomu läʾəllä śəḥətu, bäqädami śərʿat... Zäbämotu śäʿaro lämot, wäbäməṣʾatu ʾaʿoro läṣəlmät. Tänəśʾa ʾəmmutan, bätiko kʷəllo maʿəśärihu lämot. Tänəśʾio ʿarägä bäsəbḥat.

(ወሶበ ርእየ እግዚአብሔር ፥ ከመ ይትጋንፆል ዓለም ፥ በማዕሠረ ኃጢአት ፥ ፈነዎ ለበኵሩ ውስተ ዓለም ዘያፈቅር ። … ኃቢያ መለኮቶ ፥ … ወወረደ ኀቤነ ፥ ወለብሰ ሥጋ ሰብእ መዋቲ ፤ እስመ በእንተ አዳም ፥ ተፈጥረ ሞት ውስተ ዓለም ፥ በጕሕሉቱ ለሰይጣን ። … ወበይእቲ ሥጋ ፥ ተሰቅለ ክርስቶስ ዲበ ዕፀ መስቀል ፥ ከመ ይሥዓር ግብሮ ለመልአከ ሞት ፥ ከመ ይቀድሶሙ ለእለ ስሕቱ ፥ በቀዳሚ ሥርዓት ። … ዘበሞቱ ሠዓሮ ለሞት ፥ ወበምጽአቱ አያሮ ለጽልመት ። ተንሥአ እሙታን ፥ በቲኮ ኵሎ ማዕሠሪሁ ለሞት ። ተንሢአ ዓርገ በስብሐት ። - "When God saw the world being vanquished by the bondage of sin, He sent His Firstborn into the world which He loves… Having hidden His Divinity… He came down to us and put on mortal human flesh. For because of Adam, death entered the world, by the deception of Satan… And in that flesh, Christ was crucified on the tree of the cross, so that He might destroy the work of the angel of death, and sanctify those who had erred from the first ordinance… He Who by His death abolished death, and by His coming blinded the darkness. He rose from the dead, having broken all the bonds of death. Having risen, He ascended in glory.") (St. Yared, *Dəggʷa*, [approximate reference]).

This shows God's loving initiative, the Incarnation as the means, the crucifixion as the battle, and the resurrection and ascension as the ultimate victory over sin and death.

St. Yared often uses Old Testament typologies to explain Christ's saving work. For example, Jacob rolling the stone from the well to water his flock is a type of Christ opening the way to the living water of baptism, which the prophets before Him could not fully reveal. *Wäbəzuḫan nolawəyan mäṣʾu, wäsəʿənu käśito OOT läʾəbən...ʾəskä yəməṣəʾ Yaʿəqob...käśśätä wäʾastäyä mərʿeto. Wäkamahumä mäṣʾu, bəzuḫan Näbiyat, wäsəʿənu käśitota läṭəmqät, ʾəskä yəməṣəʾ, ʿAbiy Nolawi ʾəmsämay...*

(ወብዙኃን ኖሎት መጽኡ ፥ ወስዕኑ ኮኒቶታ ለዕብን ፥ እምአፈ ዓዘቅት ፥ እስከ ይመጽእ ያዕቆብ ፤… ከሠተ ወአስተየ መርዔቶ ፤ ወከማሁመ መጽኡ ፥ ብዙኃን ነቢያት ፥ ወስዕኑ ኮኒቶታ ለጥምቀት ፥ እስከ ይመጽእ ፥ ዐቢይ ኖላዊ እምሰማይ ፤… - "Many shepherds came and they were not able to roll back the stone...until the arrival of Jacob...he opened and made his flock drink. Likewise, many prophets came and they were not able to open Baptism until the Great Shepherd came from heaven...")

6.3 Creation and fall of Man

St. Yared's hymns acknowledge the goodness of God's creation and the special place of humanity, while also lamenting the tragedy of the fall.

6.3.1 Creation

Humanity is seen as the pinnacle of God's creation, made in His image.

- *ʾƎmkʷəllu ʾəlät Sänbätä ʾäkəbärkä; ʾəmkʷəllu fəṭrät, śäbʾa zäʾaʿəbäykä.*
  (**እምኵሉ ዕለት ሰንበተ አክበርከ ፤ እምኵሉ ፍጥረት ፥ ሰብአ ዘአዕበይከ ።** - "From every day You have honored the Sabbath; from all creation, You have exalted humanity.") (St. Yared, *Dəggʷa*, 143, 147, 160).
- *Wäśäbʾ yəkäbbär ʾəm kʷəllu fəṭrät.* (**ወሰብእ ይከብር እም ኵሉ ፍጥረት** - "And humanity is honored above all creation.") (*Dəggʷa zäKərəmt* - Hymns for Winter).
- *Läḥakko läśäbʾ bäʾarəyakä wäbäʾaməsalikä.* (**ለሐኮ ለሰብእ በአርያከ ወበአምሳሊከ** - "You formed man in Your image and Your likeness.")

6.3.2 The Fall

The hymns recount Adam's transgression and its consequences.

- *Zäbälʿa Adam wəstä Gännät, Krəstos wəʾətu, dämsäsä län □ʾäbäsanä, ʾəsmä bämäsqälu täḫadgä län □ ḫaṭiʾatänä.*
  (**ዘበልዓ አዳም ውስተ ገነት ፥ ክርስቶስ ውእቱ ፥ ደምሰሰ ለነ አበሳነ ፥ እስመ በመስቀሉ ተጎድገ ለነ ፥ ኃጢአተነ ።** - "Because of what Adam ate in Paradise, Christ Himself erased for us our trespasses. For our sins are forgiven through His cross.") This connects the fall directly to Christ's redemptive work.
- The consequence of Adam's sin is death for all humanity, but through Christ comes life; *Bäkämä ʾAbunä Adam, kʷəllənä nəm ﷺväkamahu bäʾəntä Krəstos, kʷəllənä näḥayu.*
  (**በከመ አቡነ አዳም ፥ ኵልነ ንመውት ፥ ወከማሁ በእንተ ክርስቶስ ፥ ኵልነ ነሐዩ ።** - "As in Adam our father, we all die, so also in Christ, we shall all be made alive.")

6.4 Salivation through incarnation

The Incarnation is the pivotal act in God's plan of salvation.

6.4.1 God's Plan of Salvation

God's mercy was promised from the beginning. St. Yared echoes the Protoevangelium (Genesis 3;15) and other traditions (like the Ethiopian *Book of Clement*) which speak of God's promise to Adam;
Wäyibelo läʾAbunä Adam, kämä yastärʾi məḥrätəyä bälaʿəlekä, ʾətəwälläd ʾəmwälätəkä wäʾədəḫək wəstä märḫəbəkä, wäʾəkälluən ḥəṣanä bäʾəntiʾakä.
(ወይቤሎ ለአቡነ አዳም ፥ ከመ ያስተርኢ ምሕረትየ በላዕሌከ ፥ እትወለድ እምወለትከ ፥ ወእድኅክ ውስተ መርጎብከ ፥ ወእከውን ሕፃነ በእንቲአከ ። - "He said to our father Adam, 'That My mercy might be revealed unto you, I shall be born from your daughter, and I shall crawl in your yard, and I shall become a child for your sake.'")

6.4.2 The Incarnation as the Climax of History

The birth of Christ from the Virgin Mary is celebrated as a unique, divine event;
Täwäldä bätədəla Mäläkot bəḥutä lədät ʾəMaryam ʾəmqəddəst Dəngəl.
(ተወልደ በተድላ መለኮት ብሔተ ልደት እማርያም እም ቅድስት ድንግል - "He was born with a joy befitting Divinity, a unique birth from Mary, from the Holy Virgin.") (St. Yared, *Dəggʷa*, BD, 186, 188, 189).

6.4.3 Redemption

Christ came to redeem and save the world.
Rəʾəyəwo Nolawəyan, ʾaʾəkʷətəwo Mäläʾəkt, läzätäwäldä ʾəMaryam ʾəmqəddəst Dəngəl. Täwäldä wämäṣʾa ḫabenä; wäläbsä śəganä, kämä yibezu wäyadḫən ʿalämä; ḥəṣan täwäldä län Krəstos.
(ርእይዎ ኖሎት ፥ አእኰትዎ መላእክት ፥ ለዘተወልደ እማርያም እምቅድስት ድንግል ። ተወልደ ወመጽአ ኀቤነ ፤ ወለብሰ ሥጋነ ፥ ከመ ይቤዙ ወያድኅን ዓለመ ፤ ሕፃን ተወልደ ለነ ክርስቶስ ። - "Shepherds saw Him, Angels praised Him, Who was born of Mary from the Holy Virgin. He was born and came to us; and put on our flesh, that He might redeem and save the world; a child was born for us, Christ.") (St. Yared, *Dəggʷa*, BD, 205).

God's mercy is highlighted; *ʾItäzäkiro ʾäbäsa ziʾanä, ʾiḫadägänä fəṣṣumä nəmasən, ḫer ʾƎgziʾabḥer. Fännäwä län Wäldo Mädḫənä, kämä yibezu wäyadḫən ʿalämä.*

(**ኢተዘኪሮ አበሳ ዚአነ ፥ ኢኃደገነ ፍጹመ ንማስን ፥ ኀር እግዚአብሔር ። ፈነወ ለነ ወልዶ መድኀነ ፥ ከመ ይቤዙ ወያድኅን ዓለመ ።** - "Not remembering our sin, He did not leave us to completely perish, good is God. He sent to us His Son, a Savior, that He might redeem and save the world.") (St. Yared, *Dəggʷa*, BD, 20, 164, 118, 220).

His descent into Hades (*Siʾol*, **ሲኦል**) to free the captives is also a key theme; *ʾƎsmä bäʾənti ʾakä wäbäʾəntä ʾəllä kamakä, wärädku wəstä Siʾol, bäśəlṭanä ʾAbuyä zäbäsämayat... Mədərawitä śəga läbsä, wäbäyəʾəti śəga wärädä wəstä Siʾol. Bäḫəyä fätḫa maʿəśärihu lämot, ʾənzä yəbəl, Muquḥan nəʿu ṣaʿu ʾəmzəyä. Bo läʾəllä wəstä ṣəlmät, yibelomu rəʾəyu bərhanä.*

(**እስመ በእንቲአከ ወበእንተ እለ ከማከ ፥ ወረድኩ ውስተ ሲኦል ፥ በሥልጣነ አቡየ ዘበሰማያት ።** … **ምድራዊተ ሥጋ ለብሰ ፥ ወበይእቲ ሥጋ ወረደ ውስተ ሲኦል ። በህየ ፈትሐ ማዕሠሪሁ ለሞት ፥ እንዘ ይብል ፥ ሙቁሐን ንዑ ፃኡ እምዝየ ። ቦ ለእለ ውስተ ጽልመት ፥ ይቤሎሙ ርእዩ ብርሃነ ።** - "For your sake and for the sake of those like you, I descended into Hades with the authority of My Father Who is in heaven… He assumed the earthly flesh and with this flesh He descended into Hades where He unbound the bondage of death saying, 'Come and get out from there you that were imprisoned.' And He said to those who were in the darkness, 'See the light.'") (St. Yared, *Dəggʷa*, BD, 307, 219).

6.5 Salivation with His Crusification [Crucifixion]

The Cross is central to St. Yared's soteriology.

6.5.1 Eternal Life

Through Christ's sacrifice, humanity is offered eternal life and joy.

ʾƎsmä käfäläna ḫəywätä ziʾahu wäʾabəʾanä wəstä fəśśəḫahu.

(**እስመ ከፈለነ ሕይወተ ዚአሁ ወአብአነ ውስተ ፍሥሐሁ** - "For He has shared His life with us and has brought us into His joy.")

The effects of the Cross are transformative;

Yom śäsälä ʾəmnenä, ḫəmzu läkäysi; tämälḫa śokä ḫaṭiʾatu läʾAdam... Yom wädqät kʷənat, ʾəmʾədä Kirubel, ʾəntä tənäddəd... Yom täʾatätä, ʾəmnenä mot... Yom täśəʿərä, mərgamma läḪewa... Yom nəgəddəf ʾəṣä ʾələwät, wänəṣur Mäsqälo kəburä, ʾəṣä ḫəywät.

(ዮም ሰሰለ እምኔነ ፥ ኀምዙ ለከይሲ ፤ ተመልሐ ሦከ ኃጢኣቱ ለአዳም ። … ዮም ወድቀት ኮናት ፥ እምእደ ኪሩቤል ፥ እንተ ትነድድ ። … ዮም ተአተተ ፥ እምኔነ ሞት… ዮም ተሥዕረ ፥ መርገማ ለሔዋ ፥ እንተ ዐለወት ትእዛዘ ። … ዮም ንግድፍ ዕፀ ዕልወት ፥ ወንፁር መስቀሎ ክቡረ ፥ ዕፀ ሕይወት ። - "Today, the venom of the serpent is removed from us; Adam's thorn of sin became uprooted… Today, the flaming spear dropped from the hands of the Cherubim… Today, death was taken away from us… Today, the curse of Eve, who transgressed the commandment, is abolished… Today, let us cast away the tree of transgression and let us bear His precious cross, which is the tree of life.") (St. Yared, *Zəmmare*, BZM, 165).

Christ's suffering is the source of our salvation; *ʾƎgziʾa ḥəyawan wämutan, gäbrä mädḫanitä bämaʿəkälä mədər, bäʾIyyärusalem hagär. Säfḥa ʾədäwihu bäQäranəyo mäkan, täṭäbḥa śəgahu, säqälu ʾƎgziʾa kʷəllu, zäyäḥayu bäQalu.*

(እግዚአ ሕያዋን ወሙታን ፥ ገብረ መድኃኒተ በማዕከለ ምድር ፥ በኢየሩሳሌም ሀገር ። ሰፍሐ እደዊሁ በቀራንዮ መካን ፥ ተጠብሐ ሥጋሁ ፥ ሰቀሉ እግዚአ ኵሉ ፥ ዘየሐዩ በቃሉ ። - "O Lord of the living and the dead, He worked salvation in the midst of the earth, in the land of Jerusalem. He stretched out His hands on Calvary, His flesh was slain, they crucified the Lord of all, Who gives life by His Word.") (St. Yared, *Dəggʷa*, BD, 26).

The piercing of His side brings forth life-giving sacraments; *Täqänäwä ʾədäwihu qəddusatä, rägäzəwo gäbohu bäKʷənat, wuḫəzä may wädäm, lämədḫanitä kʷəllu ʿaläm.*

(ተቀነወ እደዊሁ ቅዱሳተ ፥ ረገዝዎ ገቦሁ በኵናት ፥ ውኀዘ ማይ ወደምፅ ፥ ለመድኃኒተ ኵሉ ዓለም ። - "His holy hands were nailed. They pierced His side with a spear. Water and blood flowed for the salvation of the entire world.") (St. Yared, *Dəggʷa*, BD, 30).

6.5.2 His Will for Cross

Christ's suffering was voluntary, an act of His own divine will for our salvation.

Bäfäqadu Wäld, ʾaqtälä rəʾəso, Siʾolä wärido säbäkä gəʿəzanä. Bämäsqälu Wäld, gäbrä mädḫanitä. Ṣärḥät Siʾol wätəbe, Sämayawi zəsəku zäläkifoto ʾiyəkl.

(በፈቃዱ ወልድ ፥ አቅተለ ርእሶ ፥ ሲኦለ ወሪዶ ሰበከ ግዕዛነ ። በመስቀሉ ወልድ ፥ ገብረ መድኃኒተ ። ጸርሐት ሲኦል ወትቤ ፥ ሰማያዊ ዝስኩ ዘለኪፎቶ ኢይክል ። - "The Son died by His own will. Having descended into Hades, He proclaimed deliverance. The Son made salvation through His cross. Hades cried aloud and said, 'This is of the heavenly One Whom I cannot even touch.'") (St. Yared, *Dəggʷa*,

BD, 299).

The exchange of suffering for glory is a theme; *ʾAkəlilä zäśok ʾästäqäṣṣälukä, zäbäsämayat län ፣ ʾakəlilä ṣədəq ʾästädalokä; säqälukä dibä ʾəṣ, bəhiʿa zäməslä ḥamot ʾästäyukä, kämä läntastäyənä, wäynä təfəśḥət wäḥaśśet; rägäzukä wätärəḫəwä gäbokä, kämä läntähäbänä, śəgakä qəddusä, wädämäkä kəburä, kämä təṣäggəwänä.*

(አክሊለ ዘሠኽ አስተቀፀሉከ ፥ ዘበሰማያት ለነ ፥ አክሊለ ጽድቅ አስተዳሎከ ፤ ሰቀሉከ ዲበ ዕፅ ፥ ብሂዓ ዘምስለ ሐሞት አስተዩከ ፥ ከመ ለነ ታስተየነ ፥ ወይነ ትፍሥሕት ወሐሤት ፤ ረገዙከ ወተርጎመ ገቦከ ፥ ከመ ለነ ተሀበነ ፥ ሥጋከ ቅዱሰ ፥ ወደመከ ክቡረ ፥ ከመ ትጸግወነ ። - "They put a thorny crown upon You; and yet You prepared for us the crown of righteousness in heaven. They crucified You on the tree and they made You drink bile with vinegar so that You might make us drink the wine of joy and gladness. They pierced You and Your side was opened so that You might give us Your holy body and Your precious blood, that You might give us grace.")

The union of our death with His death and our life with His life; *Täśäggäwä Qal wəstä śəganä, wäkonä 1dä śəga. Dämmärä motänä bämotu, wäḥəywätənä bäḥəywätä ziʾahu... Zäśoʿa rəʾəso bäʾəntiʾanä, bäʾəntä ḫaṭiʾatänä.*

(ተሠገወ ቃል ውስተ ሥጋነ ፥ ወኮነ ፀደ ሥጋ ። ደመረ ሞተነ በሞቱ ፥ ወሕይወትነ በሕይወተ ዚአሁ ። … ዘሥዓ ርእሶ በእንቲአነ ፥ በእንተ ኃጢአተነ ። - "The Word became flesh and united with our flesh. He added our death into His death, and He added our life into His life… He sacrificed Himself for us and for our sins.")

6.5.3 Salivation by his Precious Blood

St. Yared emphasizes the unique, saving power of Christ's blood, contrasting it with all other blood shed in history.

Zəntu däm, ʾako kämä dämä ʾAbel ṣadəq... Zəntu däm, ʾako kämä dämä wälätu läYoftaḥe... Zəntu däm, ʾako kämä Isayyas Näbiy... Zəntu däm, ʾako kämä dämä ʾErməyas Näbiy... Zəntu däm, ʾako kämä dämä Ḥəzəqəʾel Näbiy... Zəntu däm, ʾako kämä dämä Nabute ʾƏśraʾelawi... Zəntu däm, ʾako kämä dämä Zäkaryas... Zəntu däm ʾako kämä dämä Yoḥannəs Mäṭməq... Zəntu däm, ʾako kämä dämä ḥəṣanat...

(ዝንቱ ደም ፥ አኮ ከመ ደመ አቤል ጻድቅ ፥… ዝንቱ ደም ፥ አኮ ከመ ደመ ወለቱ ለዮፍታሔ ፥… ዝንቱ ደም ፥ አኮ ከመ ኢሳይያስ ነቢይ ፥… ዝንቱ ደም ፥ አኮ ከመ ደመ ኤርምያስ ነቢይ ፥… ዝንቱ ደም ፥ አኮ ከመ ደመ ሕዝቅኤል ነቢይ ፥… ዝንቱ ደም ፥ አኮ ከመ ደመ ናቡቴ እስራኤላዊ ፥… ዝንቱ ደም ፥ አኮ ከመ

ደመ ዘካርያስ ፥… ዝንቱ ደም አኮ ከመ ደመ ዮሐንስ መጥምቅ ፥… ዝንቱ ደም ፥ አኮ ከመ ደመ ሕፃናት ፥… - "This blood, it is not like the blood of Abel the righteous... This blood, it is not like the blood of Jephthah's daughter... This blood, it is not like the blood of Isaiah the prophet... This blood, it is not like the blood of Jeremiah the prophet... This blood, it is not like the blood of Ezekiel the prophet... This blood, it is not like the blood of Naboth the Israelite... This blood, it is not like the blood of Zechariah... This blood, it is not like the blood of John the Baptist... This blood, it is not like the blood of the infants...")

Instead, Christ's blood is uniquely redemptive;

Zəntu däm, dämä ʾƎgziʾənä Iyäsus Krəstos, zätäkəʿəwä läśəryätä ḫaṭiʾat. Zəntu däm, zäqäddäsä kʷəllo ʿalämä. Zəntu däm, zäʾadḫano läʾAdam, wälädäqiqu ʾəmSiʾol. Zəntu däm, zäʾadḫano läNoḥ, ʾəmayä ʿayəḫ. Zəntu däm... zäkonä beza kʷəllu ʿaläm.

(**ዝንቱ ደም ፥ ደመ እግዚእነ ኢየሱስ ክርስቶስ ፥ ዘተክዕወ ለሥርየተ ኃጢአት ፥ ዝንቱ ደም ፥ ዘቀደሰ ኵሎ ዓለመ ፥ ዝንቱ ደም ፥ ዘአድኃኖ ለአዳም ፥ ወለደቂቁ እምሲዖል ፥ ዝንቱ ደም ፥ ዘአድኃኖ ለኖኅ ፥ እማየ ዓይኅ ፥ ዝንቱ ደም ፥**… **ዘኮነ ቤዛ ኵሉ ዓለም ።** - "This blood, the blood of our Lord Jesus Christ, which was shed for the forgiveness of sins. This blood, which sanctified the whole world. This blood, which saved Adam and his descendants from Hades. This blood, which saved Noah from the great flood. This blood... which became the ransom for the whole world.") (St. Yared, *Zəmmare*, BZM, 163-164).

6.6 The Road of Salivation with Sacraments

The sacraments (*Məśṭirat*, **ምሥጢራት**) are essential means by which we participate in Christ's salvation. St. Yared stresses the need for purity and preparation to receive these mysteries.

ʾAnəṣəḥu śəgakəmu, Halle Luya, wäʾako ʾalbasikəmu, Halle Luya, ʾanəṣəḥu śəgakəmu, kunu dəlwanä, läməśṭirkəmu, kämä təkʷənu beto, läMänfäs Qəddus.

(**አንጽሑ ሥጋክሙ ፥ ሃሌ ሉያ ፥ ወአኮ አልባሲክሙ ፥ ሃሌ ሉያ ፥ አንጽሑ ሥጋክሙ ፥ ኩኑ ድልዋነ ፥ ለምሥጢርክሙ ፥ ከመ ትኩኑ ቤቶ ፥ ለመንፈስ ቅዱስ ።** - "Cleanse your body, Hallelujah, and not your clothes. Hallelujah, cleanse your body and be prepared for your mysteries so that you might become the abode of the Holy Spirit.") (St. Yared, *Dəggʷa*, 150).

Baptism is essential for new birth;

Bäləḍätu täwäläḍənä wäbäṭəmqätu täṭämäqnä Iyäsus Krəstos ḫabä ʾAbuhu ʾaqräbänä.

(**በልደቱ ተወለድነ ወበ ጥምቀቱ ተጠመቅነ ኢየሱስ ክርስቶስ ኀበ አቡሁ አቅረበነ** - "By His birth we were

born, and by His baptism we were baptized; Jesus Christ brought us near to His Father.")

ʾƎfo ʾaṭmäqo bəmay, meretawi läsämayawi, kämä yətəqäddäs may, bäYordanos qälay.

(**እፎ አጥመቆ በማይ ፥ መሬታዊ ለሰማያዊ ፥ ከመ ይትቀደስ ማይ ፥ በዮርዳኖስ ቀላይ ።** - "How did the earthly baptize the heavenly with water, so that water might be sanctified in the sea of Jordan?")

Krəstos täṭämqä, wälädänä dagəmä, ʾəmay wäʾəmMänfäs Qəddus.

(**ክርስቶስ ተጠምቀ ፥ ወለደነ ዳግመ ፥ እማይ ወእመንፈስ ቅዱስ ።** - "Christ was baptized, and He begot us again from water and the Holy Spirit.")

Zäʾitäwäldä, ʾəmay wäʾəmMänfäs Qəddus, ʾiyəkl mäṣiʾa ḫabeyä.

(**ዘኢተወልደ ፥ እማይ ወእመንፈስ ቅዱስ ፥ ኢይክል መጺአ ኀቤየ ።** - "Whoever is not born of water and the Holy Spirit cannot come to Me.")

ʾƎmäni ʾitäṭämäqməmu bəmay, ʾaləbkəmu ḥəywät.

(**እመኒ ኢተጠመቅሙ በማይ ፥ አልብክሙ ሕይወት ።** - "Unless you are baptized with water, you have no life.")

The Eucharist is the partaking of Christ's salvific sacrifice;

Rägäzukä bäKʷənat wätärəḫəwä gäbokä kämä län tähäbänä śəgakä qəddusä wädämäkä kəburä kämä təṣäggəwänä.

(**ረገዙከ በኩናት ወተርጎወ ገቦከ ከመ ለነ ተህበነ ሥጋከ ቅዱሰ ወደመከ ክቡረ ከመ ትጸግወነ ።** - "They pierced You with a spear, and Your side was opened, so that You might give us Your holy Body and Your precious Blood, that You might give us grace.") (*Qəddase Śərʿat* - Liturgy of the Rite/Order, *Zäqädam*, a common Eucharistic phrase often echoed in Yaredian hymnody). St. Yared, through his hymns, provides a profound, indigenous Ethiopian articulation of Christology and Soteriology, deeply liturgical and scriptural, which continues to shape the faith and worship of the EOTC.

Chapter Seven
7 The Miaphysite [Understanding] of the Two Natures
7.1 An Ethiopian Perspective

The Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church, in communion with other Oriental Orthodox Churches, holds a Christological understanding often termed *Miaphysite*. This term, from the Greek *mia physis* (μία φύσις), meaning "one nature," is crucial. It signifies that after the Incarnation, Jesus Christ is one Person (*Akal*, **አካል**) possessing one united divine-human nature. This is not to say that divinity or humanity was diminished or confused, but rather that they came together in a perfect, inseparable union – *Tewahedo* (**ተዋሕዶ**) – in the single Person of the Incarnate Word.

This perspective is distinct from the Chalcedonian definition (451 AD), which speaks of Christ as one person *in two natures*. The Ethiopian Fathers, following St. Cyril of Alexandria, found the "in two natures" formulation problematic, fearing it could lead to a separation or division in Christ, akin to Nestorianism. For the EOTC, the emphasis is on the *oneness* of Christ after the union.

The union is often described using four key negations, attributed to St. Cyril, to safeguard its mystery;

- Without confusion (*bäʾənbälä təwsəḥo*, **ያለመቀላቀል** / *bäʾənbälä təḥəwəśət*, **ያለመቀላቀል**/**ያለመደባለቅ**) – the divinity did not become humanity, nor humanity divinity.
- Without change (*bäʾənbälä wəllaṭe*, **ያለመለወጥ**) – neither nature was altered into the other.
- Without division/separation (*bäʾənbälä fəlṭät*, **ያለመለያየት**) – the two cannot be torn apart after the union.
- Without mingling (*bäʾənbälä tusaḥe*, **ያለመደባለቅ** – often used synonymously with 'confusion') – the properties of each nature remain distinct within the union.

7.1.1 Miaphysite Christology

The core tenets of this Ethiopian (Miaphysite) Christology include;

- **One Person and One Nature, From Two Natures**: Jesus Christ is truly one Person. This one Person results from the union of two natures – divine and human – which come together to form His single, composite, incarnate nature. A traditional Ethiopian saying contrasts this with the Chalcedonian view; *Maḫbärä Kelqedon yəbelu Mäläkot wäTəsəbʾət bəkəlʾe fənaw wäbəkəlʾe śərʿat. Nəḥənäsä nəbəl ʾAmlak zätäsäbʾa ʾəMaryam Dəngəl ʾAḥadu ʾAmlak wäʾAḥadu Səmrät.*

(**ማኅበረ ኬልቄዶን ይቤሉ· መለኮት ወትስብእት በክልኤ ፍናው· ወበክልዔ ሥርዓት ፡ ፡ ንሕነሰ ንብል አምላክ ዘተሰብአ እማርያም ድንግል አሐዱ· አምላክ ወአሐዱ· ስምረት ፡ ፡** - "The Council of Chalcedon says, 'Divinity and humanity in two ways/paths and in two orders/properties.' But we say, 'God who became incarnate from the Virgin Mary, one God and one Union.'") This "one Union" (*ʾAḥadu Səmrät*) is key to understanding *Tewahedo*.

- Inseparable Union: The divine and human natures are united inseparably. A classic formulation found in Ethiopian theological texts, like the *Mäzgäbä Haymanot* (Treasury of Faith, **መዝገበ ሃይማኖት**), states; *Konä fəṣṣumä śäbʾa zäʾənbälä təwsəḥo wäʾi təḏmərt ʾənbälä fəlṭät wäʾiwəllaṭe bäBetäləḥem täwäldä wäʾəmdəḫrä wälädät dəngələnna-ha täräkbä.*
(**ኮነ ፍጹመ ሰብአ ዘእንበለ ቶስሖ ወኢ ትድምርት እንበለ ፍልጠት ወኢውላጤ በቤተልሔም ተወልደ ወእምድኅረ ወለደት ድንግልናሃ ተረክበ** - "He became perfect man without confusion and without addition, without separation and without change; He was born in Bethlehem, and after she gave birth, her virginity was found [intact].") (Mäzgäbä Haymanot, 14 [approximate reference]). The negations are crucial here;
    - *zäʾənbälä təwsəḥo* (**ዘእንበለ ቶስሖ**) - without confusion/mixture.
    - *wäʾi təḏmərt* (**ወኢ ትድምርት**) - and without addition (no third new thing was created).
    - *ʾənbälä fəlṭät* (**እንበለ ፍልጠት**) - without separation/division.
    - *wäʾiwəllaṭe* (**ወኢውላጤ**) - and without change/alteration.
- Perfect God, Perfect Man: Christ is simultaneously fully God and fully human. His divinity is not diminished by His humanity, nor is His humanity absorbed or overwhelmed by His divinity. He is *fəṣṣum śäbʾa* (**ፍጹም ሰብአ** - "perfect man") and *fəṣṣum ʾAmlak* (**ፍጹም አምላክ** - "perfect God").

7.1.2 Main Concept

- One Nature after the Union: This is the hallmark. Before the Incarnation, one can speak of the Divine Word (Logos) and the potential for human nature. But *after* the union took place in the womb of the Virgin Mary, there is only one incarnate nature of God the Word. An important statement in *Mäzgäbä Haymanot* asserts; *ʾItäwäläṭä ʾəmśəgahu ʾi ʾaḥattä säʿatä wäʾikämä qəṣbätä ʿayn ʾəmdəḫrä ʾAḥadu käwin.*
(**ኢተወለጠ እምሥጋሁ ኢ አሐተ ሰዓተ ወኢከመ ቅጽበተ ዓይን እምድኅረ አሐዱ ከዊን** - "He was

not changed from His flesh, not for one hour, nor for the twinkling of an eye, after becoming one being/nature.") (Mäzgäbä Haymanot, 15 [approximate reference]). The "one being/nature" (*ʾAḥadu käwin*, **አሐዱ ከዊን**) refers to this united reality.

- **Not Monophysitism**: It's critical to distinguish the Ethiopian (Miaphysite) understanding from true Monophysitism (as represented by Eutyches). Eutychianism taught that Christ's human nature was absorbed by His divine nature, like a drop of honey in the ocean, thus denying His full and continuous humanity. The Ethiopian Fathers vehemently rejected this. A critique of Eutyches often cited is; *ʾAwṭaki yibe śəgahu läKrəstos ʾikonä dəkkumä kämä śəganä wäʾiḥamä. Nəḥnänä nəbe ḥamä wämotä däkəmä wärəḫəbä kamanä zäʾənbälä ḫaṭiʾat baḥtita.*
  (**አውጣኪ ይቤ ሥጋሁ ለክርስቶስ ኢኮነ ድኩመ ከመ ሥጋነ ወኢሐመ ንሕነ ንቤ ሐመ ወሞተ ደክመ ወርኀበ ከማነ ዘእንበለ ኃጢአት ባሕቲታ** - "Eutyches said the flesh of Christ was not weak like our flesh, nor did it suffer. But we say He suffered and died, was weak and hungry like us, without sin only.") (Mäzgäbä Haymanot, 108 [approximate reference]). The EOTC affirms Christ's *full and real* humanity, consubstantial with ours, yet sinless.

7.1.3 The Role of the Holy Spirit

The Holy Spirit is integral to the mystery of the Incarnation.

- **Conception of Christ**: The Holy Spirit overshadowed the Virgin Mary, and by His power, the Word became incarnate. A text might state; *Wäʾikonä baḥtitu zäkonä śäbʾa ʾalla zäʾəmMänfäs Qəddus näśəʾa śəgaha qəddusä məslä näfəsa.*
  (**ወኢኮነ ባሕቲቱ ዘኮነ ሰብአ አላ ዘእመንፈስ ቅዱስ ነሥአ ሥጋሃ ቅዱሰ ምስለ ነፍሳ** - "And He (the Word) did not alone become man, but from the Holy Spirit He took Her holy flesh with Her soul.") (Mäzgäbä Haymanot, 21 [approximate reference]). This emphasizes the Trinitarian involvement in the Incarnation.
  The mystery of the infinite God being conceived in the womb is often expressed poetically; *Täʿaqqurä wəstä maḫəṣän ʾənzä ʾiyətəgabaʾ wätäṭäbəllälä räqqä ʾakal ʾənzä ʾiyətəfeṣṣäm.*
  (**ተዐቁረ ውስተ ማኅፀን እንዘ ኢይትጋባእ ወተጠብለለ ረቀ አካል እንዘ ኢይትፈጸም ፡ ፡** - "He was contained in the womb while not being confined, and He was wrapped in a subtle body while not being limited/changed.") (Mäzgäbä Haymanot, 18 [approximate reference]). This stresses that the divine nature, though uniting with humanity, remained infinite and unchanged.

Understanding these key concepts—one united nature, the four negations, perfect God and perfect Man, and the role of the Holy Spirit—is crucial for grasping the Ethiopian Orthodox Church's distinctive Christological perspective.

7.2 ምሥጢረ "ተዋሕዶ" (*Məśṭirä "Tewahedo"*, Mystery of "Union")

Tewahedo (**ተዋሕዶ**) is the *Ge'ez* (**ግዕዝ**) term that most perfectly encapsulates this Christological understanding. It means "being made one," "unified," or "union." It signifies the inseparable, unconfused, unchangeable, and undivided union of the divine and human natures in the one Person of Jesus Christ. This is the bedrock of EOTC Christology.

Ethiopian Fathers, drawing heavily from St. Cyril of Alexandria, defend *Tewahedo* by emphasizing;

- **Scriptural Basis**: The teaching of *Tewahedo* is not an invention but is derived from the Holy Scriptures. *Wäzä ʾəmqəddusat Mäṣaḥəft məzmarä yətəmeharu ʾənkä* (**ወዘ እምቅዱሳት መጻሕፍት ምዝማረ ይትሜሀሩ እንከ** - "And thus, from the Holy Scriptures, the testimony/chant is learned").
- **True Divinity of Christ**: Emmanuel (Christ) is truly God, not by grace or adoption, but by His very nature (*Baḥrəy*, **ባሕርይ**). *ʾƎsmä bäʾaman wäbäṣədəq ʾAmlak wəʾətu ʾAmmanuʾel... bäṣägga yaydälä bäBaḥrəy, bäḫədrät yaydälä bäKəwənät.* (**እስመ በአማን ወበ ጽድቅ አምላክ ውእቱ አማኑኤል ፤... በጸጋ ያይደለ በባሕርይ ፣ በኀድረት ያይደለ በኩነት ።** - "For in truth and righteousness, Emmanuel is God... not by grace but by Nature, not by indwelling but by Being/Existence.") The term *Kəwənät* (**ኩነት** - being, existence, hypostasis) is key here, signifying Christ's substantial divine reality.
- **Mary as *Wäladitä Amlak*** (Mother of God, **ወላዲተ አምላክ**): The Virgin Mary truly gave birth to God Incarnate. This title is a non-negotiable affirmation of *Tewahedo*. *WäWäladitä ʾAmlak yəʾəti ʾəntä wäläddätto* (**ወወላዲተ አምላክ ይእቲ እንተ ወለደቶ** - "And She is the Mother of God who gave birth to Him").
- **Rejection of Dyophysitism**: Teachings that propose "two natures" (*kəlʾe Akal kəlʾe Baḥrəy*, **ሁለት አካል ሁለት ባሕርይ** - "two persons, two natures") after the union are seen as misunderstanding the profound depth of the mystery of God's union with humanity. *Wäʾälläsä ṭäwayyä yəmehhəru... ʾiləbbäwu ṭəyuqä ʿəmqä məśṭirä ʾamləkot... tägəśaṣ zäQəddus Qerəllos.* (**ወእለሰ ጠዋየ ይሜህሩ ፤... ኢለበዉ ጥዩቀ ዕመቀ ምሥጢለ አምልኮት ፤... ተግሳጽ ዘቅዱ-**

ቄርሎስ - "And those who err teach... they did not grasp the profound depth of the mystery of our worship... (This is) the teaching/instruction of Saint Cyril.")

The *Tewahedo* doctrine, therefore, affirms that Jesus Christ is one Lord, one Son, one Christ, one Person, with one perfectly united divine-human nature, without any division of His divinity from His humanity or His humanity from His divinity, from the moment of the Incarnation onwards.

7.3 Article by Abbuna Melketsedek

7.3.1 Criteria of selection this article

This article by the late Abune Melketsedek, former Dean of Holy Trinity Cathedral (often referred to, it seems, via the name of Very Rev. Liqe Siltanat Habte Mariam Workineh, who might have presented or popularized it), is significant because it likely represents a considered Ethiopian Orthodox articulation of the doctrine of the Incarnation presented in an ecumenical context, specifically dialogues held with Eastern Orthodox theologians, such as those at Aarhus University, Denmark, beginning in August 1964. The EOTC has been an active participant in these dialogues, which aim to bridge the theological differences stemming from the Council of Chalcedon.

A key point in these dialogues has been the issue of anathemas and the acceptance of post-Ephesian councils. While progress has been made on lifting mutual condemnations, the Oriental Orthodox Churches, including the EOTC, maintain their non-acceptance of the Council of Chalcedon itself. The core Christological phrase *ʾAḥadu Baḥrəy zäʾƎgziʾabḥer Qal Śəgguw* (**አሐዱ ባሕርይ ዘእግዚአብሔር ቃል ሥጋው** - "One incarnate nature of God the Word") remains central and distinct from the Chalcedonian "two natures" formulation. Ethiopian Fathers often contrasted their understanding with what they perceived as a divisive Christology from Rome (and later, Constantinople), as expressed in polemical statements like; *ʾAntəmusä śäbʾa Rome gäbärkəmu fəlṭätä maᶜəkälä Təsəbʾətu wäMäläkotu käfälkəmwo läzäʾiyətkäffäl; wäʾanəqaᶜəkəmwo läzä ʾiyənnäqqaᶜ.* (**አንትሙሰ ሰብአ ሮሜ ገበርክሙ ፍልጠተ ማዕከለ ትስብእቱ ወመለኮቱ ከፈልክምዎ ለዘኢይትከፈል ፤ ወአንቃዕክምዎ ለዘ ኢይነቅዕ** - "You, O people of Rome, have made a division between His humanity and His divinity; you have divided the indivisible; and you have made that which is without separation as if it has separation.") (*Mäṣḥafä Məstir zäLədät* - Book of the Mystery of the Nativity [approximate source]). Abune Melketsedek's article, therefore, would aim to explain this indigenous understanding in a contemporary dialogue.

7.3.2 Introduction of the article

Abune Melketsedek's article would begin by affirming the Incarnation as a divine mystery (*Məśṭirä Śəggāwe*, **ምሥጢረ ሥጋዌ** - Mystery of Incarnation). The core teaching emphasizes the perfect union (*Tewahedo*, **ተዋሕዶ**) of the Godhead and Manhood in Christ, resulting in one Person and one Nature, *from* two natures.

- A key concept is the glorification of humanity through the Word; *...nərəʾi kämä yabəʿəla läśəgahu Səbḥatä Mäläkotu. Wäzäziʾahu yəresəy zäśəgahu bätədmərt.* (...**ንሬኢ ከመ ያብዕላ ለሥጋሁ ስብሐተ መለኮቱ ፡ ፡ ወዘዚአሁ ይሬሲ ዘሥጋሁ በትድምርት ፡ ፡** - "...we see that He makes His flesh glorious with the glory of His Godhead. And His (divine properties) become those of His flesh by union.") (From a homily of Ezra, *Dərsanä Qerəllos* 137 [referring to a collection of Cyrillian texts]).
- Christ is both God who became man, and man who became God through union; *Wəʾətu ʾƎgziʾabḥer zäkonä śäbʾa wäwəʾətu śäbʾ zäkonä ʾAmlakä bätäwaḥədotä Mäläkot.* (**ውእቱ እግዚአብሔር ዘኮነ ሰብአ ወውእቱ ሰብእ ዘኮነ አምላከ በተዋሕዶተ መለኮት ፡ ፡** - "He is God who became man, and He is man who became God by the union of Godhead.") (*Haymanotä Abäw*, Gregory Nazianzen 61;23).
- Abba Giyorgis of Gasəčča states; *Bäkämä täśäggäwä Mäläkot bätəsəbʾət təsəbʾətəni täʾaməläkä bäMäläkot.* (**በከመ ተሠገወ መለኮት በትስብእት ትስብእትኒ ተአምለከ በመለኮት ፡ ፡** - "As Divinity became flesh in humanity, so humanity became God (deified) in Divinity.") (Abba Giyorgis, *zäSänuyä Fasika* - Homily for Monday of Easter, 21;14).

7.3.3 Body of the article

The main body of such an article would elaborate on the *Tewahedo* doctrine;
Christ is **one incarnate nature of God the Word**. After the union, it is impossible to speak of Christ as being "in two natures." The union of the natures in the Incarnation resulted in one nature, with the original natures united without separation, without confusion, and without change.

- *Bätäwaḥədo śäwə yähonä ʾAmlak ʾAmlakəm yähonä śäwə ʾərsu bəčča näw.* (**በተዋሕዶ ሰው የሆነ አምላክ አምላክም የሆነ ሰው እርሱ ብቻ ነው ፡ ፡** - "In union, the one who became man is God, and

the one who became God is man, He alone is.") (Gregory Nazianzen, *Haymanotä Abäw* 61;4, 23).

- The *Mäṣḥafä Məstir* states; *Nahu ke täʾawəqä ʿərinahu läTəsəbʾət məslä Mäläkot. ʾAko bäṭäbayəʿa fəṭrät ʾalla bäṣəmrätä həllawe zäʾənbälä fəlṭät wäʾi tusaḥe zäʾənbälä täwəlaṭ wäʾi buʿade.* (**ናሁኬ ተአውቀ ዕሪናሁ ለትስብእት ምስለ መለኮት ፡ ፡ አኮ በጠባይዐ ፍጥረት አላ በጽምረተ ህላዌ ዘእንበለ ፍልጠት ወኢ ቱሳሔ ዘእንበለ ተውላጥ ወኢ ቡዐዴ ፡ ፡** - "Behold, the equality of humanity with Divinity has been made known. It is not in created nature, but in a union of being without separation, without confusion, without alteration, and without division.") (*Mäṣḥafä Məstir*, 349).
- Mälakä Sälam Admasu Jämbäre, in his *Mädlotä Amin* (Balance of Faith, **መድሎተ አሚን**), clarifies that the Word was not changed into man like Lot's wife into salt, or water into wine at Cana (Admasu J., p. 150). The union is *bätäʾaqəbo* (**በተአቅቦ** - in preservation), meaning the properties of each nature are preserved, not transformed into the other, without change (*wəllaṭe*, **ውላጤ**), without confusion (*tusaḥe*, **ቱሳሔ**), without separation (*fəlṭät*, **ፍልጠት**), and without division (*buʿade*, **ቡአዴ**) (*Mädlotä Amin*, p. 170).
- The *Mäzgäbä Haymanot* affirms; *Konä fəṣṣumä śəga zäʾənbälä təwsəḥo wäʾi təḍmərt zäʾənbälä fəlṭät wäʾi wəllaṭe bäBetäləḥem täwäldä.* (**ኮነ ፍጹመ ሥጋ ዘእንበለ ቶስሐ ወኢ ትድምርት ዘእንበለ ፍልጠት ወኢ ውላጤ በቤተልሔም ተወልደ** - "He became perfect flesh without confusion or addition, without separation or change; He was born in Bethlehem.") (*Mäzgäbä Haymanot; Ṣälotä*, 10).

Exchange of property (Communicatio Idiomatum)

While the natures are not confused, their properties are exchanged or attributed to the one Person of Christ.

- St. John Chrysostom in *Haymanotä Abäw*; *Bäśəga yänäbärä nədet bätäwaḥədotä Qal ṭäffa yäQal kəbər läśəga bätäwaḥədo gänzäbu honä.* (**በሥጋ የነበረ ንዴት በተዋሕዶተ ቃል ጠፋ የቃል ክብር ለሥጋ በተዋሕዶ ገንዘቡ ሆነ ፤** - "The weakness that was in the flesh was destroyed by the union with the Word; the glory of the Word became the property of the flesh by union.") (*Haymanotä Abäw*, St. John Chrysostom 66;9, 18).

- The idea of transformation of natures is rejected; *...ʾAkko kämä bəʾəsitlä Loṭ zäkonät ḥawəltä ṣew... ʾəllu śälästu tämmäyəṭu ʾəm həllawihomu ʾakko bäfäqadomu ʾalla bäfäqadä ʾƎgziʾabḥer.* (...**አኮ ከመ ብእሲተ ሎጥ ዘኮነት ሐውልተ ጌው**... **እሉ ሠለስቱ ተመይጡ እም ህላዌሆሙ አኮ በፈቃዶሙ አላ በፈቃደ እግዚአብሔር** - "...It is not like Lot's wife who became a pillar of salt... these three were changed from their being, not by their own will but by the will of God.") [This implies the union in Christ is different from such transformations].

  The Logos revealed Himself in our flesh. The intangible Word became tangible in humanity.
- *Qal zätäsäbʾa zäʾiyətəgässäś bäMäläkotu tägäśśä bäʾəntiʾakä O bəʾəsi; zäʾalbotu ṭənt bäMäläkotu läbsä śəga fəṣṣumä.* (**ቃል ዘተሰብአ ዘኢይትጐሥሥ በመለኮቱ ተገሠ በእንቲአከ አ ብእሲ ፤ ዘአልቦቱ ጥንት በመለኮቱ ለብሰ ሥጋ ፍጹመ** - "The Word who became incarnate, who is intangible in His divinity, became tangible for your sake, O man; He who has no beginning in His divinity, put on perfect flesh.") (*Haymanotä Abäw*, Athanasius [possibly citing another source] 8;3).

  St. Cyril's famous dictum underpins this; *ʾAmlak śäwə bähonä gize śäwəm bätäwaḥədo ʾAmlak honä; yäQal gänzäb läśəga; yäśəgam gänzäb läQal honä.* (**አምላክ ሰው በሆነ ጊዜ ሰውም በተዋሕዶ አምላክ ሆነ ፤ የቃል ገንዘብ ለሥጋ ፤ የሥጋም ገንዘብ ለቃል ሆነ** - "When God became man, man also by union became God; the property of the Word became (property) for the flesh, and the property of the flesh became (property) for the Word.")

  Zäᶜəruy məslä ʾAb bäMäläkotu Homoousius

(He Who is Equal with the Father in His Divinity) Christ did all human things except sin (John 8;46), yet He was simultaneously truly God. He is God-Man, co-equal and consubstantial with the Father in His divinity. His union with us is from two modes of life into one.

- He is the Only-Begotten Son, co-equal and co-eternal with the Father (Mebratu K., [year], p. 64).
- This is the Cyrillian Hypostatic Union (*wəsaṭawi yäBaḥrəy täwaḥədo* - **ውሳጣዊ የባሕርይ ተዋሕዶ** - internal/essential union of nature); *ʾAstawaḥadä bäṣəmrät kämä ʾiyətbäᶜad; wäʾänbäro bäᶜuqqabe kämä ʾiyətosaḥ.* (**አስተዋሐደ በጽምረት ከመ ኢይትበዐድ ፤ ወአንበሮ በዐቃቤ ከመ ኢይቶሳህ** - "He united (it) in union so that it might not be alienated/separated; and He placed (it) in preservation so that it might not be confused/mixed.") (*Mäṣḥafä Məstir*, 20;18). Nestorius, in

contrast, is understood to teach an external union (*ʾafʿawi täwaḥədo* - **አፍአዊ ተዋሕዶ**), like a mask on a face or a dweller in a house.

Cyrillian Christology

The union of the Word with flesh occurred in the Virgin's womb. St. John says "The Word was made flesh." We can also say the flesh was made divine. The attributes of each are ascribed to the one Christ.

- ***Theotokos*** (Mother of God, *Wäladitä Amlak*, **ወላዲተ አምላክ**); This title for Mary is essential. St. Gregory might say; *Täʾakiyahu Wäladitä ʾƎgziʾabḥer bəhil sämäyəkkuki... ʾAntiśä ṣorəkiyo bämäzarəʿki läQal Mäläkotawi.* (**ተአኪያሁ ወላዲተ እግዚአብሔር ብሂል ሰመይኩኪ… አንቲሰ ያርኪዮ በመዛርዕኪ ለቃል መለኮታዊ ፡ ፡** - "I am not ashamed to call you God-bearer... you indeed carried the Divine Word in your arms.") (Gregory, *Mäzgäbä Haymanot*, 3;53 [approximate]).
- The Anaphora of St. Mary; *Mäṣʾa ḫabeki Qal ʾənzä ʾiyətəfälläṭ ʾəmḫəṣnä ʾAbuhu ṣänäśkiyo ʾənzä ʾiyətəgabaʾ täʾaqqurä wəstä maḫəṣänki ʾənzä ʾiyəḥaṣṣəṣ bälaʿəlu wäʾitəwessäk bätaḥəttu.* (**መጽአ ኀቤኪ ቃል እንዘ ኢይትፈለጥ እም ኀጽነ አቡሁ ፀነስኪዮ እንዘ ኢይትጋባእ ተአቁረ ውስተ ማኅፀንኪ እንዘ ኢይሐፅፅ በላዕሉ ወኢትዌሰክ በታሕቱ ፡ ፡** - "The Word came to you while not being separated from the bosom of His Father; you conceived Him while He was not confined; He was contained in your womb while not diminishing above nor adding beneath.") (Anaphora of St. Mary).
- *Haymanotä Abäw* quoting a Father; *O läzəntu mänkər ləʿul mälʿəltä kʷəllu ḫəllinat bəʾəsit mədrawit wälädätto läʾƎgziʾabḥer Qal zäkonä śäbʾa...* (**ኦ ለዝንቱ መንክር ልዑል መልዕልተ ኵሉ ኀሊናት ብእሲት ምድራዊት ወለደቶ ለእግዚአብሔር ቃል ዘኮነ ሰብአ**… - "O this wonder, high above all thoughts, an earthly woman gave birth to God the Word who became man...") (*Haymanotä Abäw*, 47;2).

Miaphysis

The properties of each nature are preserved without change *within* the union. Therefore, we believe Christ is one Person and one Nature (*mia physis*), a composite, united nature. He is perfect God and perfect Man. The word "perfect" leaves no room for diminishment.

- A citation from a commentary on Cyril; *ʾAḥadu wəʾətu Krəstos ʾəmkəlʾetu həllawəyat.* (**አሐዱ ውእቱ ክርስቶስ እምክልኤቱ ህላዌያት ፡ ፡** - "One is Christ from two existences/beings.") (*Səmᶜat zäQerällos* - Hearings/Traditions of Cyril, 124;22 [A title for a collection of Cyrillian interpretations]).
- Abba Dioscorus's famous challenge at Chalcedon (as reported in Ethiopian sources) illustrates this; when Christ performed miracles (like at Cana), was it as God or as man? The answer implies the *one Christ* acts, divinity and humanity united; *ʾIyaʾəmärəkəmu kämä ʾAḥadu Mäläkotu ʾəmtəsəbʾətu wäwəʾətu gäbare mänkərat wätäwäkafie ḫəmamat bäfäqadu wäʾikonä kəlʾe ʾəmdəḫrä täwaḥədo.* (**ኢያእመርክሙ ከመ አሐዱ መለኮቱ እምትስብእቱ ወውእቱ ገባሬ መንክራት ወተወካፌ ሕማማት በፈቃዱ ወኢኮነ ክልዔ እምድኅረ ተዋሕዶ ፡ ፡** - "Do you not know that His Godhead is one from His humanity, and He is the worker of miracles and the receiver of sufferings by His will, and He was not two after the union?") (Giyorgis Wäldä Amid, 515 [Referencing a historical chronicle]).

The Crucified Jesus

It was this one Christ, with His united divine-human nature, who was crucified. The Divine Word, in His divinity alone, cannot suffer or be crucified. But through the union with flesh, He was crucified and subjected to death.

- *Sobäni täwäkfä təsəbʾət ḫəmamä täwäkfä Mäläkot ḫəburä wäbaḥətu ʾiḫamä.* (**ሶበኒ ተወክፈ ትስብእት ሕማመ ተወክፈ መለኮት ኀቡረ ወባሕቱ ኢሐመ** - "When humanity received suffering, Divinity received it together (with it), but indeed (Divinity) did not suffer.") (Mäzgäbä Haymanot, 18). This means that while the divine nature itself is impassible, because of the union, the sufferings of the human nature are attributed to the one Person of the Incarnate Word.
- A traditional explanation draws on 1 Peter 3;18; *Nəbe kämä bahəlä Qəddus Ṗeṭros; motä bäśəga wäḫəyəwä bäMänfäs. Wäzəntusä kämä täzäbṭotä ʾəsat məslä ḫaṣin ʾənzä ʾiyäḥamməm ʾəsat...* (**ንቤ ከመ ባህለ ቅዱስ ጴጥሮስ ፤ ሞተ በሥጋ ወሕይወ በመንፈስ ፡ ፡ ወዝንቱሰ ከመ ተዘብጦተ እሳት ምስለ ሐጺን እንዘ ኢየሐምም እሳት ፤**… - "We say as St. Peter said; He died in the flesh but was alive in the Spirit. And this is like the striking of fire with iron, while the fire does not suffer...") (*Mäṣḥəhätä Ləbbuna* - Mirror of the Mind, a 17th-century manuscript).

- The *Haymanotä Abäw* (p. 359) emphasizes that the two natures, having become one united nature, were not separated in any deed of the Incarnate Logos. *WäMäläkotuni ʾitäfälṭä ʾəmnnehu ʾi ʾAḥattä säʿatä wäʾi kämä qəṣbätä ʿayn ʾəmdəḫrä ʾAḥadu käwin.* (**ወመለኮቱኒ ኢተፈልጠ እምኔሁ ኢ አሐተ ሰዓተ ወኢ ከመ ቅጽበተ ዐይን እምድኅረ አሐዱ ከዊን ፤** - "And His Divinity was not separated from Him, not for one hour, nor for the twinkling of an eye, after becoming one being.") (Mäzgäbä Haymanot; *Ṣälotä*, 24).
- There's no separating divine and human actions; *Mäläkotənna Təsəbʾət bätäwaḥədo ʾandə sälähonu sälämmayinnaṭṭälu bägəbər ʾamlakawi təntane yəhənnən yäśäraw Təsəbʾət yanñawən dägəmo Mäläkot yämmibal ʾənəqäṣä təmhərt yälläm.* (**መለኮትና ትስብእት በተዋሕዶ አንድ ስለሆኑ ስለማይነጣጠሉ በግብር አምላካዊ ትንታኔ ይኸንን የሠራው ትስብእት ያኛውን ደግሞ መለኮት የሚባል አንቀጸ ትምህርት የለም** - "Because divinity and humanity are one by union and inseparable, there is no article of teaching in divine action analysis that says humanity did this and divinity did that.") (*Zəkrä Nägär* - Remembrance of Matters, p. 69 [A historical/doctrinal compendium]).

One incarnate nature of God the Word

If only the human body was crucified, salvation would not be universal. The purpose of the Incarnation was the salvation of humanity, accomplished by God the Son.

- *Mäzgäbä Haymanot*, commenting on 1 Peter 3;18, might state; *Mänu zäḥaywä zäʾənbälä zäḥamä?* (**መኑ ዘሕይወ ዘእንበለ ዘሐመ** - "Who is alive without having suffered?") (Anqetse Qedamawi, No. 9), implying that life comes through the suffering of the God-Man. Further, *ʾAkko zäkonäno läśəga ʾənzä fəluṭ wəʾətu Mäläkotu... ʾalla ʾənzä ʾAḥadu wəʾətu täwaḥido Mäläkot məslä śəga...* (**አኮ ዘኮነኖ ለሥጋ እንዘ ፍሉጥ ውእቱ መለኮቱ… አላ እንዘ አሐዱ ውእቱ ተዋሕዶ መለኮት ምስለ ሥጋ**… - "It is not that He judged the flesh while His Divinity was separate... but while it was one, Divinity united with flesh...").
- A quote from St. Gregory the Theologian emphasizes this unity; *Nəḥənäsä Mäśiḥawəyan ʾinəfäläṭo läʾƎgziʾabḥer Qal ʾəmtəsəbʾətu... ʾalla wəʾətu kämä ʾAḥadu wəʾətu Wäld Waḥəd... Motä bäśəga wäləlihu ʾimäwati bäMäläkotu.* (**ንሕነሰ መኒሐውያን ኢንፈልጦ ለእግዚአብሔር ቃል እም ትስብእቱ ፡ ፡… አላ ውእቱ ከመ አሐዱ ውእቱ ወልድ ዋሕድ… ሞተ በሥጋ ወለሊሁ ኢመዋቲ በመለኮቱ**……. - "But we Christians do not separate God the Word from His

humanity... but He is as one Only-begotten Son... He died in the flesh, and He Himself is immortal in His Divinity.") (Qalä Gəzät zäQəddus Gorgorəyos Näbabe Mäläkot - Exhortation of St. Gregory the Theologian, 120;2).

- St. Cyril in *Haymanotä Abäw*; *Mäläkot käśəga, śəga käMäläkot gar yällä mäläwwäṭ yällä mäqälaqäl yällä mäläyayätənna yällä mäkäfafäl bätäwaḥədo ʾand ʾakal ʾand baḥrəy honä. Śäwə kämähonu ʾasqədəmo śäwəm kähonä bəhala ʾand Wäld ʾand Krəstos näw.* (**መለኮት ከሥጋ ፣ ሥጋ ከመለኮት ጋር ያለመለወጥ ያለመቀላቀል ያለመለያየትና ያለመከፋፈል በተዋሕዶ አንድ አካል አንድ ባሕርይ ሆነ ፣ ፣ ሰው ከመሆኑ አስቀድሞ ሰውም ከሆነ በኋላ አንድ ወልድ አንድ ክርስቶስ ነው ፣ ፣** - "Divinity with flesh, flesh with Divinity, without change, without mixture, without separation, and without division, by union became one Person, one nature. Before He became man and after He became man, He is one Son, one Christ.") (*Haymanotä Abäw*, Cyril, 78;48, 9).

7.4 Treatise by Athanasius of Alexandria

Treatise by Athanasius of Alexandria on the Incarnation.

7.4.1 በእንተ ፣ ተሠግዎቱ ፣ ለእግዚአብሔር ፣ ቃል ፣

EMML 1763, fols 123r I. EMML 1763, fols 123r---124r: Text 124r: Text 124r: Text (fol. 123r)
ድርሳን ፣ በጥልቀተ ፣ ኤጲፋንያ ፣ ዘአትናስዮስ ፣ ሊቀ ፣ ጳጳሳት ፣ ዘእልስክንድርያ ፣ በእንተ ፣ ተሠግዎቱ ፣ ለእግዚአብሔር ፣ ቃል ፣ ነአምን ፣ ወልደ ፣ እግዚአብሔር ፣ እምቅድመ ፣ ዓለም ፣ ዘእንበለ ፣ መዋዕል ፣ እምአብ ፣ ዘተወልደ ፣ በደኃሪ ፣ መዋዕል ፣ በእንተ ፣ መድኀኒተ ፣ ዚአነ ፣ እማርያም ፣ ተወልደ ፣ በሥጋ ። በከመ ፣ ቅዱስ ፣ ሐዋርያ ፣ ይነግር ፣ ወይሜህር ፣ እንዘ ፣ ይብል ፣ ሶበ ፣ በጽሐ ፣ ዕድሜ ፣ መዋዕል ፣ ፈነወ ፣ እግዚአብሔር ፣ ወልዶ ፣ ከዊኖ ፣ እምብእሲት ። ወውእቱመ ፣ ውእቱ ፣ ወልደ ፣ እግዚአብሔር ፣ በመንፈስ ። ወውእቱመ ፣ ወልደ ፣ እጓለ ፣ እመሕያው ፣ በሥጋ ፣ አኮ ፣ ክልኤ ፣ ህላዌ ፣ በአሐዱ ፣ ወልድ ፣ አሐቲ ፣ እንተ ፣ ኢትሰገድ ፣ አላ ፣ (fol. 123v) **አሐቲ ፣ ህላዌ ፣ ዘእግዚአብሔር ፣ ቃል ፣ ተሠገወ ፣ ወተሰግደ ፣ ምስለ ፣ ተሠግዎቱ ፣ በአሐዱ ፣ ስግደት ፣ ወአኮ ፣ ክልኤ ፣ ወልድ ፣ አሐዱ ፣ ወልደ ፣ እግዚአብሔር ፣ በአማን ፣ ዘይሰግዱ ፣ ወካልእ ፣ ዘማርያም ፣ ብእሲ ፣ ዘይሰገድ ፣ ዘበ ፣ ትርሲት ፣ ተወልደ ፣ ወልደ ፣ እግዚአብሔር ፣ በከመ ፣ ኮኖን ፣ ሰብእ ፣ እለ ፣ እምእግዚአብሔር ፣ አብ ፣ በከመ ፣ ይቤ ፣ አሐዱ ፣ ወልደ ፣ እግዚአብሔር ፣ ውእቱ ፣ ወኢኮነ ፣ ካልእ ፣ ዘእማርያም ፣ ተወልደ ፣ በሥጋ ፣ በደኃሪ ፣ መዋዕል ፣ በከመ ፣ መልአክ ፣ ተናገራ ፣ ለድንግል ፣ እንዘ ፣**

ትብሎ ፡ ይእቲ ፡ እፎ ፡ ይክውነኒ ፡ ዝንቱ ፡ እንዘ ፡ ኢያአምር ፡ ብእሴ ። ወይቤላ ፡ መልአክ ፡ ለማርያም ፡ መንፈስ ፡ ቅዱስ ፡ ይመጽእ ፡ ላዕሌኪ ፡ ወኀይለ ፡ ልዑል ፡ ይጼልለኪ ፡ ወዘሂ ፡ ይትወለድ ፡ እምኔኪ ፡ ቅዱሰ ፡ ይሰመይ ፡ ወወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ። ዘተወልደኬ ፡ እማርያም ፡ ድንግል ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ በህላዌሁ ፡ ወውእቱ ፡ አምላክ ፡ በአማን ። ወኢኮነ ፡ በጸጋ ፡ ወበትርሲት ፡ ዘተወልደ ፡ አላ ፡ በሥጋ ፡ ባሕቲቱ ፡ ዘእማርያም ፡ ወልደ ፡ እጓለ ፡ እመሕያው ። ወበመለኮቱሰ ፡ ውእቱመ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ አምላክ ። ሐመ ፡ ሕማማተ ፡ ዚኣነ ፡ በፈቃዱ ፡ በሥጋ ፡ በከመ ፡ ጽሑፍ ፡ ክርስቶስ ፡ ሐመ ፡ በእንቲኣነ ፡ በሥጋሁ ። ወካዕበ ፡ ጽሑፍ ፡ ኢምሕከ ፡ ወልዶ ፡ እምኔነ ፡ ወመጠዎ ፡ በእንተ ፡ ኵልነ ፡ ወውእቱሰ ፡ በመለኮቱ ፡ ነበረ ፡ ዘእንበለ ፡ ሕማም ፡ ወዘእንበለ ፡ ብዕድና ። በከመ ፡ ይቤ ፡ ነቢይ ፡ አነ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ወኢተወለጥኩ ፡ ወሞትሰ ፡ ዚኣነ ፡ ሞተ ፡ በሥጋሁ ፡ በእንተ ፡ ኀጢኣትነ ፡ ከመ ፡ ይስዐሮ ፡ ለሞት ፡ በሞተ ፡ ዚኣሁ ፡ ዘበእንቲኣነ ። በከመ ፡ ይቤ ፡ ሐዋርያ ፡ ተውኀጠ ፡ ሞት ፡ ወተሞአ ። አይቴ ፡ መዊኦትከ ፡ ሞት ፡ ወአይቴ ፡ ስቃያቲከ ፡ ሲኦል ። ወካዕበ ፡ ይቤ ፡ ክርስቶስ ፡ ሞተ ፡ በእንተ ፡ ኀጢኣትነ ። በከመ ፡ ቅዱሳት ፡ መጻሕፍት ፡ ይሰብካ ፡ ወነበረሰ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ በመለኮቱ ፡ ዘኢይመውት ፡ ወዘኢይትኣኀዝ ፡ ለሞት ፡ እስመ ፡ ዘእንበለ ፡ ሕማም ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ወኀይለ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ። በከመ ፡ ይቤ ፡ ጴጥሮ(fol. 124r)ስ ፡ እስመ ፡ ኢይትከሀሎ ፡ ለሞት ፡ እኂዞቶ ። ወዓርገ ፡ ውስተ ፡ ሰማያት ፡ ወነበረ ፡ በየማነ ፡ አብ ፡ ምስለ ፡ እንተ ፡ እምድር ፡ ተለዓለት ፡ ሥጋ ፡ ዘቃል ። በከመ ፡ ይቤ ፡ ዳዊት ፡ ይቤሎ ፡ እግዚእ ፡ ለእግዚእየ ፡ ንበር ፡ በየማንየ ። ወውእቱኒ ፡ እግዚእ ፡ ወሐዋርያትኒ ፡ ይቤሉ ፡ ዘንተ ፡ ወበመለኮቱሰ ፡ ኢተዐግተ ፡ አላ ፡ በኵልሄ ፡ ይሄሉ ፡ ምስለ ፡ አቡሁ ፡ እስመ ፡ ኀይለ ፡ አቡሁ ፡ ውእቱ ። በከመ ፡ ይቤ ፡ ጳውሎስ ፡ ክርስቶስ ፡ ኀይለ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ወጥበበ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ወይመጽእ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ አምላክ ። በከመ ፡ አቅደምነ ፡ ነጊረ ፡ ከመ ፡ ይኰንን ፡ ሕያዋነ ፡ ወበከመ ፡ ይቤ ፡ ሐዋርያ ፡ ይኴንን ፡ ሕያዋነ ፡ ወምውታነ ፡ ወኀቡኣተ ፡ ዘውስተ ፡ ጽልመት ። ወያግህድ ፡ ምክረ ፡ አልባብ ፡ እስመ ፡ ዕሴተሂ ፡ ወኮነኔ ፡ በጽድቅ ፡ ያገብእ ። ወእመሰቦ ፡ ዘይሜህር ፡ ዘእንበለ ፡ እሉ ፡ ቃላት ፡ ዘእምቅዱሳት ፡ መጻሕፍት ፡ እንዘ ፡ ይነግር ፡ ካልእ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ወካልእ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ዘእማርያም ፡ ብእሲ ፡ ዘበ ፡ ጸጋ ፡ ወበትርሲት ፡ ተወልደ ፡ ወያቀውም ፡ ካልኣ ፡ ወልደ ፡ አሐደ ፡ በህላዌሁ ፡ ዘእግዚአብሔር ፡ አብ ። ወአሐደ ፡ በጸጋ ፡ ወበትርሲት ፡ ዘእማርያም ፡ ብእሲ ። አው ፡ ቦቱ ፡ ዘይነግር ፡ ሥጋሁ ፡ ለእግዚእነ ፡ እምላዕሉ ፡ ወኢኮነ ፡ እማርያም ፡ ድንግል ። አው ፡ ተመይጠ ፡ መለኮት ፡ ወኮነ ፡ ሥጋ ፡ አው ፡ ተጎውሠ ፡ መለኮቱ ፡ ምስለ ፡ ሥጋ ። አው ፡ ተባዐደ ፡ መለኮቱ ። አው ፡ ሕማማተ ፡ ሐመ ፡ መለኮቱ ። አው ፡ ሥጋሁ ፡ ለእግዚእነ ፡ ኢይሰገድ ። አው ፡ ዘትሑት ፡ ብእሲ ፡ ሥጋ ፡ ወኢትሰገድ ፡ ከመ ፡ ዘእግዚእ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ሥጋ ። ፡= ፡ ። እሎንተ ፡ ኵሎሙ ፡ ታወግዝ ፡ ቅድስት ፡ እንተ ፡ በኵልሄ ፡ ቤተ ፡ ክርስቲያን ፡ እንተ ፡ ሐዋርያት ። ተአሚና ፡ ለክቡር ፡ ሐዋርያ ፡ እንዘ ፡ ይሰብክ ፡

ዘመሀረክሙ ፡ ካልአ ፡ እምዘ ፡ መሀርናክሙ ፡ ውጉዘ ፡ ለይኩን ። ዘሎቱ ፡ ስብሐ(fol. 124v)**ት ፡ ለዓለመ ፡ ዓለም ፡ አሜን ።**

EMML 1763, fols 123r I. EMML 1763, fols 123r---124v: Translation 124v: Translation 124v:

7.4.2 Translation

(fol. 123r) Homily of Athanasius, Archbishop of Alexandria, on the Incarnation of God, the Word (Reading) at the Celebration of Epiphany

We believe that the Son of God, who was born from the Father before the world without time, was born at the latter days from Mary in flesh for our salvation, as the holy Apostle proclaims and teaches, saying, "When the appointed time had arrived, God sent his Son being from a woman." This is the Son of God by the Spirit; and this is the Son of man in the flesh. There is no two being(s) in one Son, one (of them) not being worshipped, but (fol. 123v) one being who is the Word of God who is incarnated and is worshipped together with his incarnation in one worship, and not two Son(s)— one the Son of God who is truly worshipped and another a human from Mary who worships, born by adoption as the son of God, like all of us humans, from God the Father. As (the Apostle) has said, it is the same Son of God, not another one, who was born from Mary in flesh at the latter days, as the angel responded to the Virgin, when she asked him, "How would this happen to me when I did not know man?" The angel said to Mary, "The Holy Spirit will come upon you and the power of the Most High will overshadow you. And the one to be born of you will be called holy and a Son of God." Therefore, he who was born from the Virgin Mary is the Son of God in his nature. And he is truly God, not born by grace or adoption. Nevertheless, because he was born from Mary in the flesh he is a Son of man. But in his divinity he is the Son of the divine God. He suffered our sufferings on his own will in flesh, as has been written, "Christ has suffered for us in his flesh." It is also written, "He did not spare his own Son from (benefitting) us, but delivered him for the sake of all of us." But in his divinity, he was without suffering and without estrangement, as the Prophet has said, "I am God; I did not change." As for death, he did die our death in his flesh because of our sin, to abolish our death by his death, as the Apostle has said, "Death has been swallowed up and was defeated. Where is your victory, O death? And where is your tortures, O Hades?" He also said, "Christ died for our sin(s)." But as the Holy Scriptures preach, he was in his immortal Divinity and is not seized by death, because he is without pain and the power of God, as

Peter has said, (fol. 124r) “For it is impossible for death to seize him.” He ascended into heaven and sat on the right of the Father with the flesh of the Word which was lifted up from earth, as David has said, “My Lord said to My Lord, ‘Sit on my right. And that is the Lord. And the Apostles have said this. But in his divinity he was not confined (in space and time) but lives everywhere with his Father because he is the power of his Father, as Paul has said, “Christ is the power of God and the wisdom of God.” The same Son of God, the God, will come, as we told earlier, to judge the living, as the Apostle says, “He will judge the living, the dead, and those hid den in darkness, and will disclose the counsel of the hearts, because he will dispense reward and punishment with justice.” If there is anyone who teaches other than these words—which are from the holy Scriptures—declaring, “The Son of God is different from the man (born) from Mary who was born in grace and adoption, and suggests two Son(s), one from God the Father in his nature, and (another) one by grace and adoption who is a man (born) from Mary,” or who declares, “The body of Our Lord is from above, and not from the Virgin Mary,” or “Divinity was changed and became flesh” or “His Divinity was mixed with flesh” or “(God’s) Divinity was divided” or “His Divinity suffered pains” or “The body of Our Lord is not worshipped” or “It is a body of a lowly man and should not be worshipped as if it were the body of the Lord, the Son of God,” the Holy catholic Church of the Apostles condemns trusting the honored Apostle who preaches, “May whoever preaches to you other than what we taught you be excommunicated.” Glory to him (fol. 124v) forever and ever. Amen.

7.4.3 From the Haymanotä Abäw,

ይቤ ፡ ብፁዕ ፡ አትናቴዎስ ፡ ሐዋርያዊ ፡ ሊቀ ፡ ጳጳሳት ፡ ዘእለእስክንድርያ ፡ በውስተ ፡ ድርሳኑ ፡ ዘደረሰ ፡ በእንተ ፡ ትሥጉተ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ቃል ፡ አስተጋቢሮ ፡ ነገረ ፡ ምስለ ፡ ማኅበረ ፡ ኒቂያ ። ነአምን ፡ በወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ዘተወልደ ፡ እምአብ ፡ በመለኮት ፡ ቅድመ ፡ እምቅድመ ፡ ዓለም ፡ ዘአልቦቱ ፡ ጥንት ፡ ለልደቱ ፡ ወካዕበ ፡ ተወልደ ፡ እማርያም ፡ እምቅድስት ፡ ድንግል ፡ በደኃሪ ፡ መዋዕል ፡ በእንተ ፡ መድኃኒትነ ፡ በከመ ፡ መሀረነ ፡ ብፁዕ ፡ ሐዋርያ ፡ ዘይቤ ፡ እስመ ፡ ሶበ ፡ በጽሐ ፡ ዕድሜ ፡ መዋዕል ፡ ፈነወ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ወልዶ ፡ ወተወልደ ፡ እምብእሲት ። ወዝንቱ ፡ ዋሕድ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ አምላክ ፡ ወውእቱ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ በመንፈስ ፡ ወወልደ ፡ እጓለ ፡ እመሕያው ፡ በሥጋ ፡ ወአኮ ፡ ዘንብል ፡ በእንተ ፡ ዝንቱ ፡ ለወልድ ፡ ዋሕድ ፡ ቦቱ ፡ ፪ቱ ፡ ህላዌ ፡ ለ፩ዱ ፡ ዘንሰግድ ፡ ወለካልኡ ፡ ዘኢንሰግድ ። አላ ፡ ፩ዱ ፡ ህላዌሁ ፡ ለእግዚአብሔር ፡ ቃል ፡ ዘተሰብአ ፡ ወንሰግድ ፡ ሎቱ ፡ ምስለ ፡ ሥጋሁ ፡ አሐተ ፡ ስግደተ ። ወኢንቤ ፡ ፪ቱ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ፩ዱ ፡ እምእግዚአብሔር ፡ በዘአማን ፡

ወሎቱ ንሰግድ ፡ ወካልእ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ብእሲ ፡ እማርያም ፡ ወኢንሰግድ ፡ ለውእቱ ፡ እስመ ፡ ኢኮነ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ በጸጋ ፡ ከመ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እጓለ ፡ እምሕያው ፡22 ወባሕቱ ፡ ዝውእቱ ፡ እምእግዚአብሔር ፡ ውእቱ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ከመ ፡ እቤ ፡ ቀዳሚ ። ወውእቱ ፡ ወልድ ፡ ዋሕድ ፡ ዘእግዚአብሔር ፡ ወውእቱ ፡ ክመ ፡ ዘተወልደ ፡ ካዕበ ፡ እምእግዝእትነ ፡ ቅድስት ፡ ድንግል ፡ ማርያም ፡ በሥጋ ፡ በደኃሪ ፡ መዋዕል ። ወአኮ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ካልዕ ። በከመ ፡ ይቤላ ፡ መልአክ ፡ ለእግዝእትነ ፡ ቅድስት ፡ ድንግል ፡ ማርያም ፡ ወላዲተ ፡ አምላክ ፡ ሶበ ፡ ተስእለቶ ፡ እንዘ ፡ ትብል ። እፎኑ ፡ ይከውነኒ ፡ ዝንቱ ፡ እንዘ ፡ ኢየአምር ፡ ብእሴ ፡ ወይቤላ ፡ መንፈስ ፡ ቅዱስ ፡ ይመጽእ ፡ ላዕሌኪ ፡ ወኀይለ ፡ ልዑል ፡ ይጼልለኪ ፡ ወዘኒ ፡ ትወልዲዮ ፡ ቅዱስ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ወይሰመይ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ልዑል ። ወዘሰ ፡ ተወልደ ፡ እምእግዝእትነ ፡ ቅድስት ፡ ድንግል ፡ ማርያም ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ በህላዌ ። ወውእቱ ፡ አምላክ ፡ ዘበአማን ፡ ወአኮ ፡ በጸጋ ። ወኢበሱታፌ ፡ መለኮት ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ሰብአ ፡ ዘበሥጋ ፡ ባሕቲቱ ። ወውእቱ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ በመንፈስ ፡ ወውእቱ ፡ አምላክ ፡ ወውእቱ ፡ ወልድ ፡ ፩ዱ ፡ ባሕቲቱ ። ወሐመ ፡ በሕማመ ፡ ዚአነ ፡ በከመ ፡ ጽሑፍ ፡ እስመ ፡ ክርስቶስ ፡ ሐመ ፡ በሥጋ ፡ በአንቲአነ ፡ እንዘ ፡ ኢየሐምሞ ፡ በመንፈስ ። ወካዕበ ፡ ይቤ ፡ እስመ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ኢምሕከ ፡ ወልዶ ፡ ዋሕደ ፡ አላ ፡ መጠዎ ፡ በእንቲአነ ፡ ቤዛ ፡ ኮልነ ። ወነበረ ፡ ዘከመ ፡ ቀዲሙ ፡ ዘእንበለ ፡ ሕማሞ ፡ ወኢውላጤ ፡ እስመ ፡ ኢይትዌለጥ ፡ በመለኮት ፡ በከመ ፡ ይቤ ፡ ነቢይ ፡ እስመ ፡ አነ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ዘኢይትዌለጥ ። ወሞተ ፡ በሞተ ፡ ዚአነ ፡ በእንተ ፡ ኃጢአትነ ፡ ከመ ፡ ያጥፍኦ ፡ ለሞት ፡ በሞቱ ፡ ቤዛነ ፡ በከመ ፡ ይቤ ፡ ፡ሐዋርያ ፡ ተሰጥመ ፡ ሞት ፡ በተመውያ ፡ አይቴ ፡ ቀኖትከ ፡ ሞት ፡ አይቴ ፡ ሙዓትከ ፡ ሲኦል ። ሞተ ፡ እግዚእነ ፡ ኢየሱስ ፡ ክርስቶስ ፡ በእንተ ፡ ኃጢአትነ ፡ በከመ ፡ ጽሑፍ ፡ ወነበረ ፡ ዘአመ ፡ ቀዲሙ ፡ ለዓለም ፡ እንዘ ፡ ኢመዋቲ ፡ በመለኮቱ ፡ ወኢይትአኀዝ ፡ በሞት ፡ እስመ ፡ ጎይሉ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ለእግዚአብሔር ፡ አብ ፡ ዘኢየሐምም ። በከመ ፡ ይቤ ፡ ጴጥሮስ ፡ ሐዋርያ ፡ እስመ ፡ ኢክህለ ፡ ሞት ፡ ኢኀዞቶ ፡ ወዐርገ ፡ ውስተ ፡ ሰማያት ፡ ወነበረ ፡ በየማነ ፡ አብ ፡ ዘውእቱ ፡ ቃል ፡ በሥጋሁ ፡ ዘአልዐሎ ፡ እምነ ፡ ምድር ። በከመ ፡ ይቤ ፡ ዳዊት ፡ ነቢይ ፡ በመዝሙር ፡ እንዘ ፡ ይኤምር ፡ ቃለ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ይቤሎ ፡ እግዚእ ፡ ለእግዚእየ ፡ ንበር ፡ በየማንየ ። እስመ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ኢይትገመር ፡ በመለኮቱ ፡ አላ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ያገምር ፡ ኮሎ ፡ መካናተ ፡ ምስለ ፡ አብ ፡ ወመንፈስ ፡ ቅዱስ ፡ ብሉያነ ፡ መዋዕል ። እስመ ፡ ጎይሉ ፡26 ውእቱ ፡ ለእግዚአብሔር ፡ አብ ፡ ዘኢይትረከብ ፡ በከመ ፡ ይቤ ፡ ጳውሎስ ፡ ሐዋርያ ፡ እስመ ፡ ክርስቶስ ፡ ጎይሉ ፡ ለእግዚአብሔር ፡ ወጥበቡ ፡ ለእግዚአብሔር ። ወይመጽእ ፡ ዝንቱ ፡ ፩ዱ ፡ አምላክ ፡ ዋሕድ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፥ ይኰንን ፡ ሕያዋነ ፡ ወሙታነ ፡ በከመ ፡ አሰፈወ ፡ በከመ ፡ ይቤ ፡ ሐዋርያ ፡ እስመ ፡ ዘይኴንኖ ፡ ለኀቡዕ ፡ እምጽልመት ፡ ወይከሥት ፡ ሕሊናተ ፡ አልባብ ፡ ይመጽእ ፡ በክብር ፡ ወይፈድዮ ፡ ለኵሉ ፡ በከመ ፡ ምግባሩ ። ወዘይሜህር ፡ ካልአ ፡ እምዝንቱ ፡ ትምህርት ፡ ዘውእቱ ፡ እመጻሕፍተ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡

ወይቤ ፡ ከመ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ካልእ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ እምብእሲት ፡ ዘተወልደ ፡ እማርያም ፡ ወይሬስዮ ፡ ወልደ ፡ በጸጋ ፡ ከማነ ፡ እስከ ፡ ይከውን ፡ ፪ኤ ፡ ፩ዱ ፡ ህላዌ ፡ ወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ ወካልእ ፡ በጸጋ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ብእሲ ፡ ዘእማርያም ፡ ድንግል ። ወዘይቤ ፡ እስመ ፡ ሥጋሁ ፡ ለእግዚእነ ፡ እምሰማይ ፡ ወአኮ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ እማርያም ፡ ድንግል ፡ አው ፡ ዘይቤ ፡ ተመይጠ ፡ መለኮት ፡ ለከዊነ ፡ ትስብእት ፡ አው ፡ ተቶስሐ ፡ ምስሌሁ ፡ አው ፡ ተወለጠ ፡ አው ፡ ዘይብል ፡ መለኮቱ ፡ ለወልድ ፡ ሐመ ፡ አው ፡ ዘይቤ ፡ ለሥጋ ፡ እግዚእነ ፡ ኢየሱስ ፡ ክርስቶስ ፡ ኢይሰገድ ፡ ሎቱ ፡ እስመ ፡ ሥጋ ፡ ሰብእ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ባሕቲቱ ፡ ወኢይቤ ፡ እሰግድ ፡ ሎቱ ፡ እስመ ፡ ሥጋሁ ፡ ለእግዚእነ ፡ አምላክ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ወለእለኒ ፡ ይብሉ ፡ ከመዝ ፡ ታወግዞሙ ፡ ቅድስት ፡ ቤተ ፡ ክርስቲያን ፡ ሰሚዓ ፡ ቃለ ፡ ሐዋርያሁ ፡ ለወልደ ፡ እግዚአብሔር ፡ እንዘ ፡ ይብል ፡ ኮሉ ፡ ዘይሜህረክሙ ፡ ካልአ ፡ እመሀርናክሙ ፡ ውጉዘ ፡ ለይኩን ።

7.4.4 From the Haymanotä Abäw, Translation

Saint Athanasius the Apostolic, Archbishop of Alexandria, said in his homily, which he composed about the Incarnation of God the Word, says, harmonizing (his) words with (those of) the Council of Nicaea: We believe in the Son of God, who was born from the Father first before the world, for whose birth has no beginning. He was born again from Mary, the Holy Virgin in the latter days for our salvation, as the blessed Apostle who said, “When the appointed time had arrived, God sent his Son and he was born from a woman” has taught us. This Only-One is God and is the Son of God by the Spirit, and the Son of man in the flesh. We do not say about him, “The Only-Son has two being(s)—one whom we worship and another whom we do not worship—but the being of God the Word incarnate is one. We worship him with his body in one worship. We do not say, “He is two—one truly from God, and we worship him, and the other human from Mary, and we do not worship him because he is not the Son of God”—as if by grace like (any) son of man. But this is from God, as I said earlier. He is the Only-Son of God, and he is the same who was born again from Our Lady the Holy Virgin Mary in flesh in the latter days. He is not another one, as the angel responded to Our Lady the Holy Virgin Mary, Begetter of God, when she asked him, saying, “How would this happen to me when I did not know man?” He said to her, “The Holy Spirit will come upon you and the power of the Most High will overshadow you. And the one you will bear is holy and he will be called a Son of Most High God.” Therefore, he who was born from Our Lady the Holy Virgin Mary is the Son of God in his nature. And he is truly God, not (born) by grace or is man in flesh only sharing divinity. He is the Son of God in spirit; he is God; he is the Only-One Son.

He suffered in our suffering, as has been written, “Christ has suffered for us in his flesh” while he does not suffer in the spirit. It also says, “He did not spare his Only Son, but delivered him for our sake, for the redemption of all of us.” He lived, as before, without suffering and without change, because he does not change in his divinity, as the Prophet has said, “I am God who does not change.” He died in our death because of our sin, to abolish death by his death (for) our redemption, as the Apostle has said, “Death has been drowned and defeated. Where is your subjugation, O death? And where is your victory, O Hades? “Our Lord Jesus Christ died for our sin (s),” as has been written, and lives forever as before, immortal in his Divinity and is not held by death, because he is the power of God the Father who does not suffer. As the Apostle Peter has said, “For death was unable to hold him.” He ascended into heaven and sat at the right of the Father, he is the Word in his flesh which he lifted up from earth. As the Prophet David has said in the Psalms to inform the Word of God, “My Lord said to My Lord, ‘Sit on my right.’ For in his divinity he is not confined (in space and time) but he confines every space with the Father and the Holy Spirit. And he is the first of the first with his Father and the Holy Spirit, the Ancients of the Day, because he is the power of God the Father that cannot be found, as Paul has said, “For Christ is the power of God and the wisdom of God.” The same one God, the Only Son of God, will come, to judge the living and the dead, as he promised, as the Apostle says, “For he who will judge those hidden in dark ness, and will disclose the thoughts of the hearts, will come in glory and recompense each according to his deeds.” He who teaches other than this teaching, which is from the Scrip tures of God, declaring that the Son of God is different from the one born from a woman, Mary, and makes him a son by grace like us so that he could be two—one a natural Son of God, and another one by grace, that is, a man (born) from the Virgin Mary—as well as he who says that the body of Our Lord is from heaven, and not from the Virgin Mary, or who says, “Divinity was changed and became humankind;” or “It has been mixed with him;” or “He has be altered;” or who says, “His Divinity of the Son has suffered;” or who says, “I will not worship the body of Our Lord Jesus Christ because it is the mere body of man;” and does not say, “I will worship him because the body of Our Lord is God;” and all those who think like these, the Holy Church condemns listening to these words of the Apostle of the Son of God, saying, “May whoever teaches you other than what we taught you be excommunicated.”

Chapter Eight
8 Mariology of Ethiopian Fathers

The veneration of the Holy Virgin Mary, *ʾƎgəzʾətənä Maryam* (**እግዝእትነ ማርያም** - Our Lady Mary), is a defining characteristic of Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo spirituality and a deeply developed area of its theology. She is not seen merely as a historical figure but as the *Wäladitä Amlak* (**ወላዲተ አምላክ** - Mother of God/God-bearer), the purest of all creation, a powerful intercessor, and a central figure in God's plan of salvation. The Ethiopian Fathers have expressed this profound Marian devotion through rich theological treatises, poetic hymns, and liturgical prayers.

8.1 The Place of Holy Virgin Mary in Ethiopian Hearts

The love and reverence for St. Mary are woven into the very fabric of Ethiopian Orthodox life. A popular hymn expresses this deep connection;

Halleluya səbḥat läʾƎgziʾabḥer zäʾalᶜala läṢəyon ʾəmkʷəllu ᶜalämat… Wäʾanähi ʾəbəl kamahomu Halleluya səbḥat läMaḫdärä Bägəᶜu Nəṣuḥt. Halleluya läṢəyon ʾƏmənä śərgut bäsəbḥat. Halleluya läzäʾitəfäqd ṣäḥayä läʾabrəhota wäbərhanä Bägəᶜu yəwaki wəsteta.

(**ሃሌ ፥ ሉያ ፥ ስብሐት ለእግዚአብሔር ፥ ዘአልአላ ፥ ለጽዮን ፥ እምኵሉ ፥ ዓለማት** … **ወአነሂ ፥ እብል ፥ ከማሆሙ ፥ ሃሌ ፥ ሉያ ፥ ስብሐት ፥ ለማኅደረ ፥ በግዑ ፥ ንጽሕት ፥ ሌ ፥ ሉያ ፥ ለጽዮን ፥ እምነ ፥ ሥርጉት ፥ በስብሐት ፥ ሃሌ ፥ ሉያ ለዘኢትፈቅድ ፥ ፀሐየ ፥ ለአብርሆታ ፥ ወብርሃነ ፥ በግዑ ፥ ያዋኪ ፥ ውስቴታ ።** - "Hallelujah, glory be to the Lord who elevated Zion more than all worlds… And I too say like them, Hallelujah, glory to the pure Habitation of His Lamb. Hallelujah to Zion Our Mother adorned with glory. Hallelujah for her who does not desire the sun for her shining, for the light of His Lamb shines within her.")

Here, Zion is a key Old Testament symbol often applied to St. Mary.

Personal devotion is intense. One beautiful expression of this intimate love is; *Wäṣəḥuf wəstä seleḍa ləbəyä Mäṣḥafä gəbərnatəyä läki... Ḥaṣä fəqrəki zädägoṣo läläbəyä ʾiyətmällaḫ läzəlafu.*

(**ወጽሑፍ ውስተ ሰሌዳ ልብየ መጽሐፈ ግብርናትየ ለኪ**… **ሐጸ ፍቅርኪ ዘደጎጸ ለልብየ ኢይትመላጎ ለዝላፉ** - "And written on the tablet of my heart is the book of my servitude to you... The thorn/arrow of your love that pierced my heart will never be removed from its wound.") This reflects a deep, personal commitment.

Worship and praise are constant; *ʾƏsägd läki O ʾƎgəzʾətəyä Maryam śärkä wänägəha. Wäʾəweddəs maḫəṣänäki zäʾagmärä rəsəna Mäläkot mäfərəha... O Nəgəśt zäʾaṭräyki ləbä təḥutä wämänfäsä yäwahä... Läwädisotəki ṣəḥuqä wätəguhä...*

(**እሰግድ ለኪ ኦ እግዝእትየ ማርያም ሠርከ ወነግህ ። ወእቄድስ ማኅፀነኪ ዘአግመረ ርስነ መለኮት መፍርህ… ኦ ንግሥት ዘአጥረይኪ ልበ ትሑተ ወመንፈሰ የዋህ… ለወድሶትኪ ጽሑቀ ወትጉህ**… - "I bow to you, O my Lady Mary, evening and morning. And I praise your womb that bore the awesome heat/power of Divinity... O Queen, who obtained a humble heart and a gentle spirit... To praise you, [make me] diligent and awake...")

Historical rulers also promoted her veneration. Emperor Dawit I (late 14th-early 15th century) is associated with commissioning icons of the Virgin Mary, sometimes with her name written in gold ink, as seen in manuscripts like EMML 9002 (*Täʾammərä Maryam* - Miracles of Mary). Later, Emperor Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob (1434-1468) famously decreed that a second *Tabot* (**ታቦት**) dedicated to Our Lady Mary be placed in every church, solidifying her prominent place in official worship. The reason given often highlights her unique status; *Zati yəʾəti śəmä ʾƎgəzʾətənä Qəddəst Dəngəl bä2ʾe Maryam Wäladitä ʾAmlak. ʾAmä täṣäwᶜa yadläqəlläq ṣənᶜa Sämayat wägəzäfä mədər ʾəskä mäsäräta läSiʾol. WäläMäläʾəktəni yətəhawwäk kənäfihomu bädəngaṣe kämä qʷäṣəl ʾamä yəzäbṭo näfas.* (**ዛቲ ፥ ይእቲ ፥ ስመ ፥ እግዝእትነ ፥ ቅድስት ፥ ድንግል ፥ በ፪ኤ ፥ ማርያም ፥ ወላዲተ ፥ አምላክ ። አመ ፥ ተጸውዐ ፥ ያድለቀልቅ ፥ ዕንዐ ፥ ሰማያት ፥ ወግዘፈ ፥ ምድር ፥ እስከ ፥ መሰረታ ፥ ለሲኦል ። ወለመላእክትኒ ፥ ይትሀወክ ፥ ክነፊሆሙ ፥ በድንጋፄ ፥ ከመ ፥ ቈጽል ፥ አመ ፥ ይዘብጦ ፥ ነፋስ ።** - "This is the name of Our Lady, the Holy Virgin, Mary the Mother of God. When it is called, the strength of the heavens and the mass of the earth tremble, down to the foundation of Sheol. And even the wings of the angels flutter in awe, like a leaf when the wind strikes it.") (Cerulli, 1943, p. 76 [referencing a text related to Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob]).

The Ethiopian *Sənkəssar* (Synaxarium, **ስንክሳር**) clearly defines her role as intercessor, who "intercedes with her Beloved Son on behalf of the children of men."

8.2 Basics and Sources

Ethiopian Mariology draws from a wide range of sources, both from the broader Christian tradition and developed indigenously.

8.2.1 From Orientals (and broader Early Church)

Early Christian writings from other centers, especially Alexandria, influenced Ethiopian Marian thought.

- Apocryphal texts like the *Protevangelium of James*, attributed to James the "brother" of the Lord, provided narratives about Mary's early life.
- Works like *Visions of St. Mary*, associated with Patriarchs Theophilos and Timothy of Alexandria, fueled popular devotion.
- St. Cyril of Jerusalem wrote about Mary's life in the Temple.
- St. Cyril of Alexandria's Christological writings, especially against Nestorius, were foundational for understanding her title *Theotokos*. His works contain key terms for Ethiopian Mariology.
- Demetrius of Antioch authored a discourse on Mary's life.
- Descriptions of Mary's physical appearance, attributed to figures like St. Epiphanius of Cyprus (c. 320-404 AD), also found their way into Ethiopian tradition, painting a picture of her dignity, humility, and grace (Budge, 1933, p. xxiii). These descriptions often highlight her serene beauty, wisdom, and gentle spirit.

8.2.2 In Ethiopia

A vast indigenous literature dedicated to St. Mary developed in Ethiopia, primarily in *Ge'ez* (**ግዕዝ**). Key texts include;

- ***Mäṣḥafä Lədata läMaryam*** (**መጽሐፈ ልደታ ለማርያም** - Book of the Nativity of Mary).
- ***Nägärä Maryam*** (**ነገረ ማርያም** - The Story/Account of Mary) - exists in various forms.
- ***Mäṣḥafä ʿƏräfta läMaryam*** (**መጽሐፈ ዕረፍታ ለማርያም** - Book of the Dormition/Falling Asleep of Mary).
- ***Mäṣḥafä ʿƏrgäta läMaryam*** (**መጽሐፈ ዕርገታ ለማርያም** - Book of the Assumption of Mary).
- ***Dərsanä Maryam*** (**ድርሳነ ማርያም** - Homily/Homilies in honor of Mary) - often read on her feast days.
- ***Dərsanä Ṣəyon*** (**ድርሳነ ጽዮን** - Homily in honor of Zion/Mary) - e.g., EMML 2044.
- ***Wəddase Maryam*** (**ውዳሴ ማርያም** - Praise of Mary) - a collection of praises for each day of the week, deeply beloved and widely used.
- ***ʾAnqäṣä Bərhan*** (**አንቀጸ ብርሃን** - Gate of Light) - attributed to St. Yared, a poetic praise.

- *Täʾammärä Maryam* (**ተአምረ ማርያም** - Miracles of Mary) - a vast collection of stories about her intercessions, hugely popular.
- *Mälkəʾa Maryam* (**መልክአ ማርያም** - Image/Form of Mary) - a poetic genre praising her attributes, limb by limb. Authorship of some is attributed to figures like Emperor Naʾod or Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob.
- *ʾArganonä Wəddase* (**አርጋኖነ ውዳሴ** - Organ of Praise) or *ʾArganonä Dəngəl* (**አርጋኖነ ድንግል** - Organ of the Virgin) - complex poetic praises by Abba Giyorgis of Gasəčča.
- *Qəddase Maryam* (**ቅዳሴ ማርያም** - Anaphora/Liturgy of Mary) - one of the EOTC's main anaphoras.
- *Mäᶜaza Qəddase* (**መዓዛ ቅዳሴ** - Fragrance of the Liturgy) - related liturgical texts.
- *Maḥəletä Ṣəge* (**ማሕሌተ ጽጌ** - Canticle of the Flower) - beautiful hymns for the season after the rainy season, rich in Marian symbolism.
- *Raʾəyä Maryam* (**ራእየ ማርያም** - Vision of Mary) - texts detailing visions of Mary.

This extensive literature underscores her central theological and devotional importance.

8.3 The mystery of Divine Motherhood

The title *Wäladitä Amlak* (Theotokos, **ወላዲተ አምላክ** - Mother of God/God-bearer) is the cornerstone of Ethiopian Mariology, as it is for all Orthodox traditions. It affirms the true divinity of her Son, Jesus Christ. To call Mary *Wäladitä Amlak* is to confess that the child she bore is truly God Incarnate.

- The Ethiopian Fathers employ numerous symbols to explain this mystery; she is the Ark of the Covenant (containing the Divine Word), the Second Heaven (dwelling place of God), the Pure Temple, the Pure Tabernacle.
- She is also seen as the New Eve, reversing the disobedience of the first Eve. A text might say; *Läʾəmä ḫaśśäśəka läḤewan tərəkəba bəhəyä ʾənzä tətəfeśśaḥa bäwälätä-ha zäʾamṣəʾat lati fäwsä läqəsliha.* (**ለእመ ኃሠሥካ ለሔዋን ትረክባ በህየ እንዘ ትትፌሳሕ በወለታ ዘአምጽአት ላቲ ፈውሰ ለቅስሊሃ** - "If you search for Eve, you will find her there rejoicing in her Daughter who brought her healing for her wound.") (*Mäṣḥafä Məstir*, 71 [approximate reference]).

Her divine motherhood is not just a biological fact but a pivotal event in salvation history, signifying God's loving condescension to humanity and the beginning of the new creation.

8.4 The perpetual virginity of Holy Virgin Mary

The EOTC firmly upholds the doctrine of Mary's perpetual virginity – before, during, and after the birth of Christ. This is seen as a sign of her unique holiness and consecration to God.

- A text like the *Dərsanä Ṣəyon* states; *Wäbəʾəntäz nəbəl Maryaməsä dəngəl yəʾəti bəkəlʾe fəna; dəngəl yəʾəti bäḥəllinaha wädəngəl bäśəgaha. Wäʾalbo zäyətəmassälo lädəngələnna nəṣuḥa ḥəllinaha wälädəngələnna nəṣuḥa śəgaha.*
  (**ወበእንተዝ ፡ ንብል ፡ ማርያምሰ ፡ ድንግል ፡ ይእቲ ፡ በክልኤ ፡ ፍና ፡ ድንግል ፡ ይእቲ ፡ በሕሊናሃ ፡ ወድንግል ፡ በሥጋሃ ። ወአልቦ ፡ ዘይትማሰሎ ፡ ለድንግልና ፡ ንጽሐ ፡ ሕሊናሃ ፡ ወለድንግልና ፡ ንጽሐ ፡ ሥጋሃ ።** - "And therefore we say Mary is a virgin in two ways; she is a virgin in her thought/mind and a virgin in her body. And there is none who can be compared to the purity of the virginity of her thought and the purity of the virginity of her body.") (*Dərsanä Ṣəyon*).
- The *ʾArganonä Wəddase* might address those who questioned it; *...ʾƎsmä bəhuḫan śəḥətu bäʾəntäz qal ʾənzä yəblu ʾəmdəḫrä wälädät tädämmärät məslä Yosef wäyəsämmiyomu Mäṣḥafä ʾEpifaniəwos läʾəmmuntu mänafəqan ṣärrä Maryam.*
  (...**እስመ ብዙኃን ስሕቱ በእንተዝ ቃል እንዘ ይብሉ እምድኅረ ወለደት ተደመረት ምስለ ዮሴፍ ወይሰምዮሙ መጽሐፈ ኤጲፋንዮስ ለእሙንቱ መናፍቃን ፀረ ማርያም** - "...For many erred concerning this word, saying that after she gave birth she was united with Joseph, and the Book of Epiphanius calls those heretics 'enemies of Mary.'") (*ʾArganonä Wəddase*).
- St. John Chrysostom (in *Haymanotä Abäw*) argues that if Christ were born through normal human union, many would have doubted His divinity; *Sobäsä täwäldä ʾƎgziʾənä bärukabe bəʾəsi wäbəʾəsit zäkamän □bəzuḫan ʾəm täḥazäbəwo wäʾəm räsäyəwo hasätä.*
  (**ሶበሰ ተወልደ እግዚእነ በሩካቤ ብእሲ ወብእሲት ዘከማነ ብዙኃን እም ተሐዘብዎ ወእም ረሰይዎ ሀሰተ** - "If our Lord had been born through the union of a man and woman like us, many would have doubted Him and considered Him false.") (*Haymanotä Abäw*, St. John Chrysostom, 240).

Symbols like the Closed Gate (Ezekiel 44;2, as in *ʾO ʾAnqäṣä Mädḫanit zäʾiyətəräḫaw mänasəgətiha bäwälidä ʾAmlak läbasse təsəbʾət*, **ኦ አንቀጸ መድኃኒት ዘኢይትረኃው መናስግቲሃ በወሊደ አምላክ ለባሴ ትስብእት** - "O Gate of Salvation whose bolts are not opened, by the birth of God clothed in humanity"

from *Ḥoḫətä Bərhan*, Gate of Light, 39), the Sealed Fountain, Gideon's Fleece (*ṣämrä Gidewon*, **ፀምረ ጌድዮን**), and Aaron's Rod that budded (*bətrå Aron*, **በትረ አሮን**) are used to illustrate this mystery.

8.5 Mary , the Hope of Humanity

St. Mary is seen as the hope of humanity, the one through whom salvation entered the world. Her "yes" to the Archangel Gabriel was a pivotal moment of cooperation with God's plan.

- She is the New Eve, whose obedience reversed the disobedience of the first.
- She is the dove that brought the olive branch to Noah, signifying peace and a new beginning; *ʾAmä ʾatäwəki wəstä Tabot məslä qoṣəlä zäyt ḥamäləmil, kämä ʾabəśśärəkiyo läNoḥ təʾəmərtä gizehu läśaḥəl, ʾabəśərni ṣədəqä bäṣäwirä ṣəge ṣədul, Maryam Rəgbä Qusəqʷam zäʾakənafəki Mäsqäl.*

  (**አመ አተውኪ ውስተ ታቦት ምስለ ቆጽለ ዘይት ሐመልሚል ከመ አብሠርኪዮ ለኖኅ ትእምርተ ጊዜሁ ለሣህል አብሥርኒ ጽድቀ በጸዊረ ጽጌ ጽዱል ማርያም ርግበ ቁስቋም ዘአክናፍኪ መስቀል** - "When you entered the Ark with a green olive leaf, as you announced to Noah the sign of the time of mercy, announce to me righteousness, carrying a pure flower, O Mary, Dove of Qusqam whose wings are the Cross.") (*Mäṣḥafä Säᶜatat* - Book of Hours, 230; *ʾƎnzira Səbḥat* - Harp of Praise, 39; *Maḥəletä Ṣəge*).

8.6 Mary's Participation in Human redemption

Mary actively participated in the work of redemption not by offering sacrifice herself, but by willingly providing the flesh and blood from which the Redeemer would be formed. The Ethiopian Fathers emphasize that the Logos descended to earth and united with humanity *in her womb*, and through the flesh He took from her, humanity is exalted to heaven.

- She is the *ʾəṣä Sabiq* (**ዕፀ ሳቤቅ** - the ram caught in the thicket, Genesis 22;13) which provided the Lamb of God. Abba Giyorgis writes; *Mänu räsäya läʾəṣä Sabiq kämä təläd Bägəᶜa zäʾənbälä rukabe... Bägəᶜ zäbezawo läYəsḥaq ʾarʾaya wäʾaməsal...*

  (**መኑ ረሰያ ለዕጸ ሳቤቅ ከመ ትለድ በግዐ ዘእንበለ ሩካቤ ፡ ፡እብልሰ በግዕ ዘቤዘዎ ለይስሐቅ አርአያ ወአምሳል ፡ ፡**… - "Who made the tree of Sabiq to bear a Lamb without union?... I say the Lamb that redeemed Isaac was a type and symbol...") (Abba Giyorgis, 8; *ʾƎnzira Səbḥat*, 66).

- She is the "fruitful one who gives what is eaten and the spring of what is drunk"; *O Dəngəl mäfəryət läʾəntä yətəbälaᶜ wämänəqᶜət läʾəntä yəsättäy.* (**ኦ ድንግል መፍርይት ለእንተ ይትበላዕ ወመንቅዕት ለእንተ ይሰተይ** - "O Virgin, fruitful one for that which is eaten and spring for that which is drunk.")
- She is the cup from which believers drink wisdom and life; *O ṣəwaᶜ ʾəntä ʾəmnneki läʾəllä yəsätyu ʾəmnnehu bäʾamin zäyagosəᶜ ṭəbäbä wäyəhub ḥəywätä.* (**ኦ ጽዋዕ እንተ እምኔኪ ለእለ ይሰትዩ እምኔሁ በአሚን ዘያንስዕ ጥበበ ወይሁብ ሕይወተ** - "O Cup from which those who drink from it in faith gush forth wisdom and it gives life.") (*Qəddase Maryam Andəmta* - Commentary on the Anaphora of Mary, p. 162).

8.7 Symbols of Holy Virgin Mary

Ethiopian Mariology is exceptionally rich in symbolism, drawing from both Scripture and nature to express Mary's unique role and virtues. Some common symbols include;

- Golden Lampstand (*Täqwamä Maḫtot zäWärq*, **ተቅዋመ ማኅቶት ዘወርቅ**)
- The Pure Tablet/Ark (*Tabot Nəṣuḥt*, **ታቦት ንጽሕት**)
- Country of the Great King (*Hagäru läNəguśᶜAbiy*, **ሀገሩ ለንጉሥ ዓቢይ**)
- Bride of Lebanon (*Mərᶜatä Libanos*, **መርዓተ ሊባኖስ**)
- Gate of Light (*Ḫoḫətä Bərhan*, **ኖኅተ ብርሃን**)
- Foundation of Holiness (*Mäśärätä läQəddəsənna*, **መሠረተ ለቅድስና**)
  The list is extensive, including; Second Eve, Ark of Noah (*Ḫamärä Noḫ*, **ሐመረ ኖኅ**), Aaron's Rod (*Bətrå Aron*, **በትረ አሮን**), Gideon's Fleece (*Ṣämrä Gidewon*, **ፀምረ ጌድዮን**), Ezekiel's Closed Gate (*Ḫoḫətä Ḫəzəqəʾel*, **ኖኅተ ሕዝቅኤል**), Bride of Solomon, Stone of Daniel (*ʾƏbnä Daniʾel*, **ዕብነ ዳንኤል**), and many more. Each symbol illuminates a particular aspect of her person, her purity, her role in the Incarnation, or her intercessory power.

You are absolutely right to push for more detail here, and I apologize if my previous attempt to summarize this section felt like a dismissal or an oversimplification of a very important theological point for the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church. The topic of St. Mary's holiness from conception is indeed a significant aspect of EOTC Mariology, and it's distinct from the Roman Catholic dogma of the Immaculate Conception.

Let's delve into this with the detail it deserves, drawing from the points you've provided in your Table of Contents and aiming for that scholarly yet natural tone, emphasizing the Ethiopian indigenous understanding.

8.8 Understanding St. Mary's Unique Holiness from Conception

A crucial aspect of Ethiopian Orthodox Mariology concerns the unique and perfect holiness of Our Lady St. Mary from the very beginning of her existence. While the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church (EOTC) does not use the term "Immaculate Conception" in the way it was dogmatically defined by the Roman Catholic Church in 1854 (which specifically posits freedom from the *stain* of original sin from the moment of her own conception), the EOTC firmly teaches St. Mary's special, unmatched purity and beatification chosen by God the Holy Spirit, preparing her to be the *Wäladitä Amlak* (**ወላዲተ አምላክ** - Mother of God/God-bearer). This is a point of deep conviction and has been articulated by Ethiopian Fathers and scholars, though nuances in expression and historical discussions exist.

The general Ethiopian Orthodox understanding emphasizes that St. Mary, while a descendant of Adam and thus part of humanity affected by the fall, was uniquely chosen, preserved, and sanctified by God's grace and the power of the Holy Spirit from the earliest moments of her being, specifically from her mother's womb. This was not due to her own merit but was a divine preparation for her singular role in the Incarnation.

Let's look at some of the perspectives and key statements you've noted, which reflect this indigenous understanding and sometimes the discussions around it;

- The Core Ethiopian Orthodox Position on Her Sanctity:
  The EOTC believes that Our Lady, the Virgin Mary, who conceived and bore Christ in virginity, was kept free from actual sin and was sanctified from her mother's womb by the Holy Spirit. She is considered pure and holy, the "Holiest of Holies," chosen and prepared by God.
  A formal articulation of this is found in the 1988 E.C. (1995/1996 G.C.) official publication by the Holy Synod of the EOTC, ***የኢትዮጵያ ኦርቶዶክስ ተዋሕዶ ቤተ ክርስቲያን እምነት ፣ ሥርዓተ አምልኮና የውጭ ግንኙነት*** (Faith, Order of Worship, and External Relations of the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church). This document states;
  (አምላክን በድንግልና ጸንሳ በድንግልና የወለደች እመቤታችን ድንግል ማርያም ከአዳም የተላለፈ ኃጢአት [ጥንተ አብሶ ያለገኛት] መርገመ ሥጋ መርገመ ነፍስ የሌለባት ከመውለዷ አስቀድሞ

በአምላክ ጎሊና ትኖር የነበረች በሰው ልማድና ጠባይ ከሚደርሰው ሥጋዊ አሳብና ፈቃድ ሁላ የተጠበቀች ከተለዩ የተለየች ንጽሕት ቅድስተ ቅዱሳን ናት ፡ ፡ - "Our Lady, the Virgin Mary, who conceived God in virginity and gave birth in virginity, the sin transmitted from Adam [ancestral sin did not reach her], the curse of the flesh, the curse of the soul are not upon her; before her birth she lived in the mind of God, protected from all carnal thought and will that comes from human custom and nature, distinguished from the distinguished, she is pure, the Holy of Holies.") (EOTC Holy Synod, 1988 E.C., p. The phrase *ṭəntä ʾabəso yallägäññat* (**ጥንተ አብሶ ያለገኛት** - "ancestral sin did not reach her/find her") is particularly significant here.
This is often understood in conjunction with the Synod's affirmation; *Mänfäs Qəddus ʿaqqäba ʾəmkärsä ʾəmma* (**መንፈስ ቅዱስ ዐቀባ እምከርሰ እማ** - "The Holy Spirit preserved/guarded her from her mother's womb.") This points to a special divine action of preservation and sanctification by the Holy Spirit from the very beginning of her life.

- Nuances and Historical Discussions
  It's important to acknowledge that within the broader Orthodox world, and even within Ethiopian theological discourse historically, the precise language used to describe St. Mary's freedom from ancestral sin has been a subject of careful consideration to avoid formulations that might diminish her full humanity or the universality of Christ's redemption. The EOTC's emphasis is on God's *prevenient grace* and the Holy Spirit's sanctifying work in her life specifically for her role as *Theotokos*.
    - Ethiopian Scholars and Publications:
      - The late Patriarch Abunä Pawlos's writings (e.g., *Fəlsäta*, **ፍልሰታ**, p. 306) would likely reflect the established EOTC teaching on her unique sanctity.
      - Məgabe Bəluy Säyfä Śəllase Yoḥannəs (**መጋቤ ብሉይ ሰይፈ ሥላሴ ዮሐንስ**): Your notes indicate he wrote in *Mäṣəḥetä Tənsaʾe* (**ትንሣኤ መጽሔት** - Tinsae Magazine, No. 23, 1971 E.C.) that ancestral sin was not upon her (*ṭəntä ʾabəso yälläbbatəm*, **ጥንተ አብሶ የለባትም**). Later discussions or clarifications might have occurred, as often happens in theological explorations. His book *Mäśärätä Haymanotənna yäKahənat Tälaʾəko* (**መሠረተ ሃይማኖትና የካህናት ተልዕኮ** - Foundation of Faith and the Mission of Priests, 1982 E.C., p. 29) is also mentioned, perhaps containing related points.

- ʿAśrat Gäbrä Maryam (**ዓሥራት ገብረ ማርያም**): His theological book is noted as having a position in 1983 E.C. but then altering it in a 1991 E.C. (1998/1999 G.C.) edition. This highlights that theological articulation can evolve or be refined.
- Abunä Mälkä Ṣedeq (**አቡነ መልከ ጼዴቅ**) in *Yäʾ Ityoppəya Ortodoks Täwaḥədo Betä Krəstiyan ʾƏmnätənna Śərʿat* (**የኢ. ኦ. ተ. ቤክ. እምነትና ሥርዓት** - Faith and Order of the EOTC, p. 146) would also present an authoritative view.

- Patristic and Liturgical Testimonies within EOTC:

  The Ethiopian Fathers and liturgical texts often speak of St. Mary's unparalleled purity.
  - The idea of her being preserved from the very substance of Adam's fallen nature is sometimes expressed with imagery like; *Säfḥo gäbrä ʾəmṭəntä śəgahu läʾAdam* (**ሰፍሖ ገብረ እም ጥንተ ሥጋሁ ለአዳም** - "He (God) fashioned/separated her from the original flesh of Adam") (*Qəddase Maryam*, Anaphora of Mary, 64). This implies a special divine intervention in her formation.
  - Another beautiful image; *Maryaməsä täḥatu wəstä kärsu läʾAdam kämä baḥrəy ṣäʿada* (**ማርያምሰ ተሐቱ ውስተ ከርሱ ለአዳም ከመ ባሕርይ ጸዓዳ** - "Mary was hidden in the loins/being of Adam like a white pearl.") (*Dərsanä Maryam*, Homily of Mary, 94, 326, 379 [references vary]). This suggests her preciousness and purity were divinely foreseen and preserved.
  - The example of the Prophet Jeremiah, sanctified from the womb (Jeremiah 1;5), is often used as a biblical parallel for God's ability to sanctify individuals for a special purpose from their very beginning. Patriarch Abunä Matiyas is noted as highlighting this.
  - A distinction is made: *ʾAko zämäṣʾa laʿəleha Mänfäs Qəddus zäkämä mäṣʾa laʿəlä Näbiyat wäḤawarəyat wälaʿəlä kʷəllomu mäḥayəmənan läqəddəso näfəsomu wäśəgahomu.* (**አኮ ዘመጽአ ላዕሌሃ መንፈስ ቅዱስ ዘከመ መጽአ ላዕለ ነቢያት ወሐዋርያት ወላዕለ ኵሎሙ መኃይምናን ለቀድሶ ነፍሶሙ ወሥጋሆሙ** - "The Holy Spirit did not come upon her as He came upon the Prophets and Apostles and upon all believers to sanctify their souls and bodies [for their ministry/life], but in a unique way for the Incarnation."). Her sanctification was singular and for the purpose of becoming the *Theotokos*.

- The hymn attributed to Abba Ṣəge Dəngəl (**አባ ጽጌ ድንግል**) from *Maḥəletä Ṣəge* (**ማሕሌተ ጽጌ**) powerfully speaks to her being a remedy and hope for fallen humanity, implying her distinct status: *ʾƎmsädom ʾəməkonnä, wäkämä Gemora ʾəməmäsälnä, ʾƎgziʾabḥer kiyaki ʾəmä ʾiyaträfä län ፣ bətrå Maryam ʾəntä ṣägäyki mädḫənä, zäyibe ʾimäṣaʾəku ʾəṣäwwəᶜ ṣadəqanä, ʾalla länsəḥa ḫaṭəʾanä.* (**እምሰዶም እምኮነ ፣ ወከመ ገሞራ እመሰልነ ፣ እግዚአብሔር ኪያኪ እመ ኢያትረፈ ለነ ፣ በትረ ማርያም እንተ ጸገይኪ መድኀኒ ፣ ዘይቤ ኢመጻእኩ እጸውእ ጻድቃነ ፣ አላ ለንስሐ ኃጥአነ** - "We would have become like Sodom, and we would have resembled Gomorrah, if God had not preserved you for us, O Rod of Mary who budded forth the Savior, who said, 'I have not come to call the righteous, but sinners to repentance.'") This hymn suggests that Mary herself is a divine provision, a "preserved remnant" for the sake of humanity's salvation.

In essence, the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church's teaching affirms St. Mary's unique, unparalleled holiness and purity, a state of sanctification bestowed by the Holy Spirit from her mother's womb, preparing her perfectly for the Incarnation of God the Word. This is understood as a divine act of preservation and grace, making her the immaculate vessel, the "Holy of Holies," distinct from other human beings, yet still fully human and a daughter of Adam who, like all humanity, finds her ultimate salvation in her Son, Jesus Christ. The focus is on God's sovereign choice and sanctifying action in her life, rather than on a legalistic removal of an inherited "stain" in the way later Western scholasticism defined it.

The profound devotion is summed up in prayers like;

O ʾƎgəzʾətənä Maryam ṣäwwənä bəzuḫan ʾaʾəlaf; Rədʾetomu ʾanti läʾəllä wəstä baḥər wäṣädf; Rədʾəni gize wådiq wäʾanəśəʾəni bäknəf; ʾƎsmä ʾanä gäbrəki… ʾAfäqərəki ʾəm wəsaṭe ləbəyä wäʾako bäʾaf; Läᶜalämä ᶜaläm. Amen.

አ ፡ እግዝእትነ ፡ ማርያም ፡ ፀወነ ፡ ብዙኃን ፡ አእላፍ ፤ ረድኤቶሙ ፡ አንቲ ፡ ለእለ ፡ ውስተ ፡ ባሕር ፡ ወጸድፍ ፤ ርድእኒ ፡ ጊዜ ፡ ወዲቅ ፡ ወአንሥእኒ ፡ በክንፍ ፤ እስመ ፡ አነ ፡ ገብርኪ ፡ …… አፈቅረኪ ፡ እም ፡ ውሳጤ ፡ ልብየ ፡ ወአኮ ፡ በአፍ ፤ ለዓለመ ፡ ዓለም ፡ አሜን ።። - "O Our Lady Mary, [though] many thousands call upon you; You are the help of those in the sea and on the cliff; Help me in time of falling and lift me up with (your) wing; For I am your servant… I love you from the depth of my heart and not (only) with the mouth; Forever and ever. Amen.")

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